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‘Co-pilot Planned Attack Before Joining Flydubai’

Had plans of crashing into Ben-Gurion airport earlier this year as well; was failed student at Melbourne varsity

The flydubai co-pilot who stabbed his captain in a suspected attempt to crash the plane has told UAE interrogators he planned the attack before he was hired by the Dubai state-owned airline, according to two Israeli officials with knowledge of the probe.

A third source briefed on the UAE probe said the co-pilot, an Omani national, had planned to crash last Wednesday's flight into Ben-Gurion airport near Tel Aviv. He had also operated a flight to Tel Aviv earlier this year and intended to hijack and crash the plane then, but opted not to, the source added.



It was not immediately clear why the co-pilot changed his mind on that previous flight, although the co-pilot is thought to have known

someone onboard, the source said. Two sources have said the co-pilot is an Omani national named Hamam al-Hammami. Israeli offi-

cials have not named the co-pilot but have said he is from Oman. Authorities have not publicly disclosed the co-pilot's identity.

AUSTRALIA, NEW ZEALAND LINKS
The co-pilot had been enrolled at RMIT University in Melbourne but failed to finish an engineering qualification, the university said in a statement Monday.

His years in Australia have become a focal point as investigators examine whether his time there contributed to his radicalisation.

RMIT said it was "aware of media reporting of a former student alleged to be involved in the Fly-

Dubai flight incident," adding it was unable to comment further as investigations continue. The university is one of Australia's oldest tertiary institutions.

Investigators are looking into al-Hammami's alleged visits to radical mosques and extremist websites during his time in Australia, FT reported Sunday.

New Zealand Assistant Police Commissioner Michael Johnson said on Monday that the co-pilot had spent time in the country and that NZ police were looking into the period. He did not say when the co-pilot allegedly visited the country or name him. **Agencies**



Kyiv: Over 50% of Moscow's Refining Capacity Disabled

Ukraine says its long-range strikes have neutralized more than half of Russia's oil refining capacity, hampering Moscow's ability to supply its forces during its four-and-half-year-old invasion.

The Defense Ministry said late Sunday that recent strikes on refineries in cities including Moscow, Yaroslavl, Ust-Luga, Perm, Saratov and Syzran had put 51% of Russia's oil refining capacity out of action. The claim could not be independently verified.

Both Moscow and Kyiv have intensified their aerial assaults as progress along the 1,200-kilometer front line has largely ground to a halt.

Ukrainian forces have repeatedly attacked refineries from Moscow to Siberia, sparking a widespread fuel crisis in Russia earlier this year that forced authorities to restrict gasoline sales. Russian officials have not publicly revealed any data on damage caused to the country's oil infrastructure. However, President Vladimir Putin said in a rare admission on Oct. 1 that the strikes had cost Russia roughly 1% of its gross domestic product.

"They started attacking oil refineries and openly declared the goal of damaging our economy. Did they achieve their goal? Partially," Putin said at a meeting of the Valdai Club forum of international foreign policy experts.

Ukrainian Defense Minister Yevhenii Khmara said analysts from Ukraine's intelligence services, the General Staff and the Defense Ministry had assessed the strikes' effects.

"Fifty-one percent of struck refining capacity is a significant blow to the enemy's economy, to its ability to carry out aggression and supply its troop groupings. Our deep strikes continue to bring the war to Russian territory," he said.

Russia has historically been the world's third-largest producer of refined fuel products from crude after the U.S. and China.

Some of Russia's 32 refineries have been hit as many as 15 times since the start of the war, and one refinery has been hit every three days in recent months, creating a cycle of damage and emergency repairs that could degrade units long term, according to the IEA. **AP**

AFTER SUSPECTED TERROR PLOT
US Bomber Jets Moved Away from UK Airbase

The United States has removed its B-1 bombers from a British air base one week after five men were arrested nearby on suspicion of preparing terrorist acts, a suspected plot that British Prime Minister Andy Burnham said was likely backed by Iran.

The planes had been stationed at RAF Fairford, the preferred European base for US bombers located 145 km west of London, which had recently been used for US strikes on Iran. A Pentagon official said Sunday they have returned to their home bases in the US.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said in late July that the base was a legitimate target. A NATO milita-

ry source said Monday: "It is still believed that Iran poses an acute threat to US assets in the UK".

The five men arrested by British police have been released on bail, and the incident remains largely unexplained. A sixth man, a dual

UK-Iranian national arrested on suspicion of preparing terrorist acts, has also been released on bail.

Iran has said accusations it was involved in any plot are baseless, and its foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, wrote on X: "I can confirm Iran's belief that releasing supposed terrorists working for foreign states really says it all. You're barking up the wrong tree." **Reuters**



Yemen Government, Houthis Claim Control Over Bab-el-Mandeb Strait

Officials say seized Dhubab airstrip, Houthis believed to advance near Taiz



Saudi-backed Yemeni forces in a military truck near the city of Taiz | AFP

Saudi-backed Yemeni government forces have secured effective control of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, Yemen's Information Minister Moammar al-Eryani said on Monday, though fighting continues with Houthis forces in the area.

The government forces advanced rapidly along the coast with heavy Saudi air support to seize key positions in the Dhubab area on the narrowest point of the strait, a vital oil route whose seizure by the Iran-backed Houthis last month sent shockwaves through energy markets. However, while Eryani said the military had seized Dhubab airstrip, located just inland from

the strait, and cut off remaining Houthi forces in the area, another government source said fighting continued at a military base near the strait. The Houthis earlier denied that government forces had made gains, describing such claims as "completely untrue".

While recapturing the coastal area around the strait would make it harder for the Houthis to disrupt shipping between the Mediterrane-

an and Indian Ocean, they could still target vessels with drones from positions further up the coast and inland.

Meanwhile, the Houthis made advances near the city of Taiz, gaining sections of a mountain road to leave government forces besieged, according to five military sources with the Yemeni government. One other government source denied the road had been cut. **Reuters**

Bain Capital to Sell \$2.3b Coherent Block

Bain Capital offered an unregistered block of Coherent shares for as much as \$2.3 billion, according to people familiar with the matter, the latest sell-down of the private equity firm's stake in the laser equipment maker. The Boston-based firm is selling about 9.4 million shares at an offering marketed at \$237.50 to \$240 per share. **Bloomberg**

AkzoNobel to Offload \$1.35b Biz to Nippon

AkzoNobel said on Monday it has agreed to sell its Southeast Asian decorative paints business to Nippon Paint for \$1.35 billion, completing a review of its Asian decorative paints portfolio. The sale covers decorative paints operations in Vietnam, Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand, Singapore, Papua New Guinea and Australia, the paints maker said. **Reuters**,

Huawei Okays Patent Deal with Qualcomm

China's Huawei Technologies said on Monday it had agreed a broad multi-year patent licence deal with Qualcomm covering artificial intelligence, 5G, computing and networking technologies. The agreement includes Qualcomm's purchase of certain Huawei US patents related to computing, AI and networking, Huawei said in a statement. **Reuters**

‘UK Mulls Levies on Chinese EVs’

The UK is preparing to impose import levies on Chinese electric vehicles to meet a key demand from the European Union, the Times of London reported, in a blow to a group that now accounts for nearly one in four cars sold in the country.

Brussels has made clear that the UK faces being cut from the Made in Europe local-content rules if it doesn't act on the tariffs, the newspaper said, adding that EU officials are concerned the UK could become a backdoor for Chinese exports into Europe. UK officials are concerned about Chinese retaliation against Jaguar Land Rover Automotive Plc but have determined the potential economic fallout of being dropped from the Made in Europe mechanism would be far more damaging, the Times said, without stating how the information was obtained.

London introducing import duties would be a setback to Chinese automakers. **Bloomberg**

Trio Wins Nobel for Optogenetics Work

American Karl Deisseroth and Germans Peter Hegemann and Georg Nagel won the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine on Monday for developing optogenetics, a technique that uses light to control individual nerve cells in the brain.

The Nobel Assembly of Sweden's Karolinska Institute said Deisseroth, 54, Hegemann, 71, and Nagel, 73, had been selected for their "discoveries concerning light-gated ion channels and optogenetics."

"This method (optogenetics) makes it possible to switch on, or off, the activity of individual

nerve cells in a living brain," said Thomas Perlmann, Secretary-General of the Nobel Assembly at Karolinska Institutet.

"This method is now being used



(L-R) Karl Deisseroth, Peter Hegemann and Georg Nagel

in laboratories around the world to reveal the brain's mysteries," he said.

Anna Wedell, a professor in genetics and a member of the Nobel Committee for Physiology or Medicine, said a new era in neuroscience had opened but it was only the beginning.

"For the first time we can actually start to understand how the brain processes information

and how different neurons interact across the brain," she said.

The trio will share a prize sum of 12 million Swedish crowns (\$1.2 million).

Announcements will follow in the coming days on this year's Nobel physics, chemistry, literature, peace and economics prizes.

BREAKTHROUGH FROM ALGAE
The breakthrough began in the early 1990s when Hegemann investigated how the alga Chlamydomonas reacts to light in half a millisecond. He hypothesised that a single protein both captured light and acted as an ion channel.

Nagel tested this hypothesis by injecting Chlamydomonas genes into frog eggs, discovering channelrhodopsin-2, a light-sensitive ion channel. **Reuters**

Lab Worker Dies in Siberia, Quarantine Orders in Place

A laboratory worker at a plague research institute in Siberia has fallen ill and died in undisclosed circumstances, prompting authorities to quarantine dozens of people, and the head of Russia's health watchdog to fly to the Irkutsk region.

The death has sparked public health fears on social media, but the authorities said on Monday the situation was under control.

Plague is endemic to Siberia, location of the first known prehistoric human outbreak, as the bacterium that causes it, Yersinia pestis, is present among the small wild mammals there.

Local media named the woman as Darya Shipilova, an employee at the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Research Institute of Siberia and the Far East. **There were conflicting reports about how and where the laboratory worker, whose age was given as 28, had fallen ill, but the authorities said she had died of pneumonia of as-yet unestablished origin.**

Anna Popova, the head of Rus-



an health watchdog Rospotrebnadzor, flew to Siberia for an emergency meeting.

MONITORING THE SITUATION: RUBIO
Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Monday that the United States is monitoring reports of the plague infection but that it is not a "cause for alarm."

"So we're watching and monitoring it closely. I don't think it's cause for alarm, but it is cause for focus and a cause to just keep an eye on it. And we're doing that," Rubio said. **Agencies**

Housing Crisis Spain PM Calls for Early Polls

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez announced early general elections Monday after his government suffered a bruising legislative defeat last week on emergency measures related to the country's housing crisis.

The vote will be held on Nov. 29.

In recent weeks, Spaniards have demanded solutions from the government over housing affordability, holding protests in cities across the country after public outrage grew over the televised eviction of an 87-year-old woman in Madrid last month.

Right-wing opposition parties joined forces to scuttle two emergency decrees introduced by Sánchez's government that included measures to reduce evictions and real estate speculation. The setback sparked wide speculation that Sánchez would

move up a national election that would have otherwise taken place next year — and seize on his base's anger over the rejected housing measures.

Bolsonaro Leads in Brazil Election

Flávio Bolsonaro surged to a surprise lead over Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in the first round of Brazil's presidential election, making him the overwhelming favorite to win the runoff.

Markets soared after Bolsonaro took 47% of the vote to the leftist Lula's roughly 45.2% in Sunday's election. **Bloomberg**

In an address to the nation, Sánchez on Monday argued that a broader progressive coalition in Parliament would allow Spaniards to tackle the biggest issues facing their country today.

"The time has come, therefore, for the Spanish people to decide what future you want for yourselves and for your country," Sánchez said.

Sánchez, 54, has been Spain's prime minister since 2018, making him one of Europe's longest-standing leaders. **AP**

Crossword9722

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ACROSS

1 First person easily frightened in country gets bullying (12)

8 Rum Dane in a struggle is defenceless (7)

9 Term put in concession for shellfish (7)

11 Liberal upset about cancelled menu (4,2,4)

12 Recall some beef burgers as food (4)

14 Tourist worker with skill starts to employ engaging banner (8)

16 Covering for a canine? (6)

17 Risk (not half) for expert in martial arts (3)

19 Work in plant at a canter? (6)

21 Individual in suspect triad is restricted (8)

24 Straight piece of line attached (4)

25 Greet scout merrily bringing vegetables (10)

27 Rough sailing ship housed in borders of Surrey (7)

28 Show no loyalty to duo I met mistakenly (3-4)

29 Appear with president, last of figures to produce happy conclusion (4,2,6)

DOWN

1 Agitated, like a cat entering home? (2,1,4)

2 Miner about to play percussion instrument (10)

3 Adjusted way of working improved after leaving Spain (8)

4 Wish observed in parades, I reckon (6)

5 Small, furry animal missing sun? Exactly (2,1,1)

6 Idol tampered with odd container for commodity (3,4)

7 They grow in Asia in part of bridge and factories (6,6)

10 Decline in place outwardly exposed by a shed with a particular finish? (12)

13 Ignore men working around old feature in a ship (6,4)

15 Element in theatre arranged thing used for audition? (3)

18 One telling stories brought up rubbish on Scottish island (8)

20 It shows registration with a university in area of high land (7)

22 Fools from province with others (7)

23 Draw close to cold sailor certainly (4,2)

26 Image found in Mexico, notably (4)

SOLUTION TO No. 9721:

ACROSS: 6 Relative clause. 9 Amused. 10 Punditry. 11 Abattoir. 13 Renown. 15 Lean-to. 17 Boogie. 19 Tee-ter. 20 Auditory. 22 Wildlife. 24 Cloche. 26 Canterbury bell. DOWN: 1 Prima ballerina. 2 Alms. 3 Studio. 4 Scenario. 5 Saki. 7 Vipers. 8 Strawberry Hill. 12 Toast. 14 Night. 16 Tertiary. 18 Gateau. 21 Dactyl. 23 Duty. 25 Obey.

Aramco CEO: Crude Buffer ‘Scarily Thin’

The oil stockpiles that cushion the world from supply shocks have become "scarily thin," putting markets at risk of worsening unless the Strait of Hormuz reopens, according to the CEO of Saudi Aramco .

The head of the world's single biggest crude exporting company was speaking just days after governments of world's biggest economies announced plans to release as much as 100 million barrels of emergency oil and diesel stocks to ease rising fuel costs. **Bloomberg**

Saudi & UAE to Help in Asia Oil Stockpile

A framework for Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) to cooperate with Asian countries on oil stockpiling is set to be launched, with Japan supporting the initiative through financial assistance and stockpiling expertise, the Nikkei business daily said on Monday.

The Japan-led Asia Zero-Emission Community (AZEC), a grouping of 11 countries including Southeast Asian nations, will hold a ministerial meeting in the Philippines on Thursday, where senior Saudi Arabia and UAE officials are expected to announce their intention to cooperate on oil stockpiling, the Nikkei said. **Reuters**

HIDATO

FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1 - 82 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.

13 14 18 22 24 25

16 20 27

9 30

5 62 32

6 55 33

3 64 53 36

1 77 51 50 38 39

78 80 82 71 42

www.hidato.com

Difficulty: ★★★★★

Hidato Set.

28 29 31 34 35 37 39 40

27 25 30 32 33 36 38 41

26 24 23 62 61 60 43 42

20 21 22 17 16 59 44

19 18 15 12 58 57 45

8 9 10 11 14 13 46 56

7 3 2 50 49 52 47 55

6 5 4 1 51 48 53 54

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

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7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

CLUES

1 shaking in anticipation (9)

2 Serena's husband's website (6)

3 perspicacious (10)

4 club and sub (10)

5 tiny Australian state (8)

6 pulchritudinous (9)

7 Belgian actor Matthias (11)

SOLUTIONS

1 shakin in anticipation (9)

2 Serena's husband's website (6)

3 perspicacious (10)

4 club and sub (10)

5 tiny Australian state (8)

6 pulchritudinous (9)

7 Belgian actor Matthias (11)

CEPT TREM WI DD ORIA

BEA CHES ING ERTS IVE

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Yesterday's Answers: 1. DOROTHY 2. CHATBOT 3. MUCKINNESS 4. SCOT 5. ADJECTIVE 6. GROOVES 7. DEMOS

11/18

NON-SEQUITUR

SO...D'YA HAVE ANY TRAVEL PLANS FAH THE HOLIDAYS, EDDIE?

HMM... LET'S SEE...

NOW, NOTHIN' PLANNED

AH, OK... SO YAW'RE STAYIN' PUT, EH?

I WOULDN'T BET ON IT

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ET Commerce Tracker

Returns Comparison (%)

ET Commerce Index

ET Commerce Profitable Index

ET Commerce Non-Profitable Index

Nifty 50

Compiled by ETIG Database

1 Day

1 Month

3 Months

6 Months

Tweet OF THE DAY



PAUL MIT

@PMITU

We are approaching a new era: when people will pay for human touch

20K GCC Hands Move to IT Cos in Massive \$1.5b Carve-out Wave

GCC landscape bifurcates as labour-intensive ops face carve-outs while core AI, data, engg stay in-house

Tanya Pandey

New Delhi: More than 20,000 employees have moved from global capability centres (GCCs), enterprise information technology subsidiaries and product operations to IT services providers in the past 12 months, as companies shift parts of their technology operations to external providers, according to industry estimates.

TCS's takeover of Best Buy's India GCC under a multiyear deal is the latest example, while HCLTech's \$10.5-million acquisition of Guardian Life's India operations brought nearly 2,000 employees into the IT services company under a seven-year partnership. Wipro's \$386-million acquisition of Olam Group's IT and digital services business Mindsprint, which has more than 3,200 employees, is tied to an eight-year strategic transformation deal.

Industry watchers expect the trend to continue as IT companies look for such takeover opportunities. "We expect similar numbers in the next 12 months," said Pareekh Jain, chief executive of EIRITrend, a market research firm. The 20,000-plus figure for the past 12 months covers more than pure GCC transfers.

Jain estimates around 3,000 people were part of pure GCC transitions,

with the rest coming from combinations of GCCs, internal operations, third-party services, enterprise IT subsidiaries and product carve-outs. He estimates the broader pool of

transactions at \$1.3-1.5 billion in business value. In a low-growth environment, IT service providers are aggressively chasing business acquisitions, he said.

Twist in Tale

IT service providers are aggressively buying GCCs, IT subsidiaries and product carve-outs

HFS Research has tracked around half a dozen publicly disclosed GCC and captive-originated business transfers to service providers globally over the past 18 months

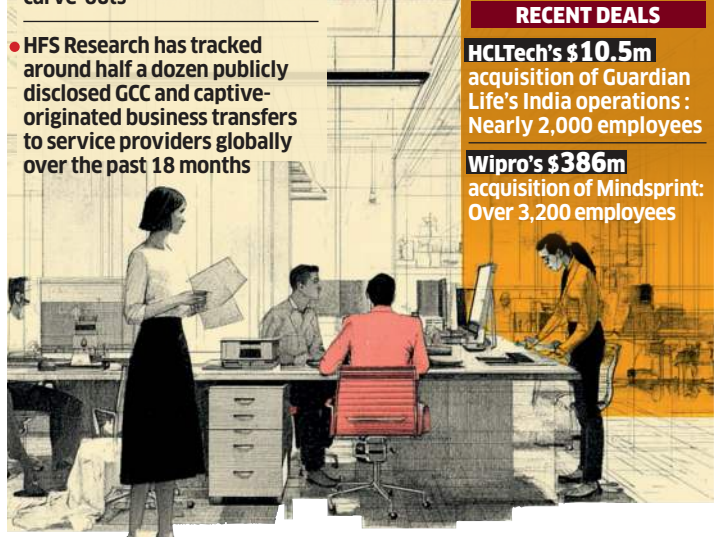
Companies are also moving individual technology functions to service providers

10% of mature GCCs could become candidates for some form of full or partial transfer over the next two to three years

RECENT DEALS

HCLTech's \$10.5m acquisition of Guardian Life's India operations: Nearly 2,000 employees

Wipro's \$386m acquisition of Mindsprint: Over 3,200 employees



NEW TREND

The trend is also extending to product companies reassessing which technology capabilities they want to retain

HFS Research has tracked around half a dozen publicly disclosed GCC and captive-originated business transfers to service providers globally over the past 18 months. "The transaction structures vary, but the pace has picked up noticeably in 2026," said Achyuta Ghosh, India and global GCC practice head at HFS. The shift is not limited to entire GCCs changing hands. Firms are also moving individual technology functions to service providers without selling the GCC itself.

"There is a much longer tail of quieter transactions where testing, infrastructure, application maintenance or other service towers move from a GCC to a provider without the legal entity itself being sold," Ghosh said. These transactions are rarely announced publicly but are coming up more frequently in conversations with GCC leaders and service providers, he added.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO [www.economictimes.com](#)

UPI Finds its Voice in Bharat as MDR Rings in a Soundbox Boom

THE SOUND OF MONEY Fintechs betting on instant audio confirmations to win over rural shopkeepers

Nikhil Patwardhan & Tanishka Dubey

Bengaluru: Payment firms are stepping up soundbox deployments and frontline sales hiring in tier-2 cities and smaller towns, betting that the reintroduction of a merchant discount rate (MDR) on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) payments will help fund expansion, said industry executives.

The industry has scope to increase soundbox deployments from about 20 million to 50 million over time, a senior National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) official said on condition of anonymity. A fund proposed in NPCI's September 15 MDR circular to support small-merchant onboarding and payment infrastructure could reach an estimated ₹3,000 crore as payments increase over the next five years, according to

ing to the official. BharatPe is planning about 50% more soundbox deployments than originally envisaged in selected markets over the coming quarters, chief operating officer Sabhyasachi Senapati told ET, without divulging further details. The company, with more than 3.5 million monthly transacting merchants, had accelerated expansion before MDR was announced and is preparing additional investments.

A Jefferies report said that Bha-

ratPe's soundbox deployment increased about 10% last year.

"The MDR that comes from your overall ecosystem—not just in the smaller towns but from existing merchants from your larger merchants—is going to help drive investment across the country," Senapati said.

Pine Labs on September 24 announced plans to deploy one million soundboxes. PhonePe separately plans more than 20,000 sales hires and more than 5 million payment devices, including soundboxes and card terminals, over 12 months, with roughly half the devices earmarked for rural

India. Paytm had outlined a merchant acquisition push before the policy change, with its June quarter commentary pointing to growth across merchant categories.

The opportunity includes upgrading merchants using QR codes to soundboxes, which announce payment confirmations, and bringing new shops onto digital payments. UPI has about 60 million unique merchants, but this base has grown at single-digit annual rates over the past three years, the NPCI official said.

Goldman Sachs last month estimated that the acquiring side—banks and payment companies serving merchants—could receive ₹7,900 crore annually from MDR by 2027-28.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO [www.economictimes.com](#)

Tech Buzz

WhatsApp's New Restricted Chat is Out for Beta Users



WASHINGTON: WhatsApp has started rolling out its new 'Restricted Chat' feature to select beta users on Android and iOS, adding four restrictions designed to limit how messages and media can be accessed or handled within a conversation. According to GSM Arena, Restricted Chat is available to some users running WhatsApp beta version 2.26.36.4 on Android and 26.39.10.20 on iOS. The feature was first reported last month as an upgrade to WhatsApp's Advanced Chat Privacy functionality. Restricted Chat is optional and does not apply to conversations by default. Users can manually enable it from the chat info screen for individual conversations. Once enabled, WhatsApp displays a message in the conversation and applies four restrictions. People in a Restricted Chat cannot automatically save media to their devices. —Agencies

\$845b

Combined wealth gained by tech tycoons in first nine months of year as AI boom soars

Norway Seeks Interim Ban on Smart Glasses



OSLO: A trip to the park or a day at the beach or a workout session at the gym. All in public spaces where smart glasses can snap photos, record conversations or stream video online—without people in the line of their lenses and microphones knowing about it. Norway's government is proposing that its parliament enact a temporary ban on them in some places. It's the latest sign of growing concern in many countries about new technologies that are fundamentally changing the way people live. Some governments have banned the use of social media by children and young teens. One effort to rein in use of AI glasses has run around—in the home of Silicon Valley. California's governor last week vetoed legislation that would have penalised use of smart glasses to record people without their permission in places like changing rooms. —AP

50%+ Genpact Revenue Outcome-based: AI Exec

Co moving away from billing clients for no of people assigned to a contract: Vijay Vijayasankar

Shristi Achar

Bengaluru: Genpact is moving away from billing clients for the number of people assigned to a contract, with over 50% of its revenue now being linked from headcount, according to Vijay Vijayasankar, its global agentic AI officer.

"If we use the accounts payable example, we will go to a CFO and say: your invoice processing is currently running at \$5 per invoice; we will guarantee a \$3 one," Vijay said in an interview with ET. "You don't have to worry about our labour cost or our technology cost. If, for whatever reason, I can't deliver, the risk is on me, not you."

In its latest earnings call in August, Genpact's CFO Mike Weiner enumerated the categories of the non-full-time equi-

valent revenue, including fixed-fee, usage-based and outcome-based contracts. In the April-June quarter, the New York-headquartered firm's revenue rose 7.1% from a year earlier to \$1.34 billion. Revenue from its advanced technology solutions business grew 24.1% to \$363 million. The change in billing follows a change in how Genpact says it carries out work. AI agents process routine bills and documents, while people examine exceptions and make decisions that require judgment.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO [www.economictimes.com](#)

[AI] Agents do all the grunt work, and humans handle the exceptions. Humans handle the judgment

VIJAY VIJAYASANKAR
Global agentic AI officer, Genpact

Physical AI Startups Push for Early Rules, Industry Union

Eye industry body to standardise practices around worker pay, hours, wellbeing & compliance

Puran Choudhary & Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Startups involved in collecting real-world data to train robots and other physical AI systems are in early discussions to form an industry body to set common standards for workers' pay and wellbeing, working hours, safety and legal compliance, founders told ET.

The proposed body could also help AI labs connect with various farms, factories, hotels and other real-world environments from where they can access and collect data needed to train robots at a fixed rate, one of the founders said. "The idea is to have a union with access to a variety of environments

CONNECTING DOTS

Proposed body could connect AI labs with access to real-world environments such as agriculture, manufacturing including agriculture, manufacturing and hospitality, so that labs looking to collect data can go through the union to access them," the founder said on the condition of anonymity. The founders may consider setting a fixed rate of around \$7-10 per hour, the person added.

Currently there is a massive gap in demand and supply of data from these environments, with startups

doing individual tie-ups for data collections, founders said.

Physical AI systems such as robots, humanoids and automated vehicles interact with the physical world and use real-world data to learn how to perform tasks.

The push for common rules on how data is collected, standardised and used comes as founders and investors increasingly bet on physical AI and the ecosystem scales. Founders also want the government to step in soon, arguing that introducing rules after two or three years, when there would be several companies and people working on physical AI data collection, could be disruptive.

Government rules for collecting such data should be developed now, while the sector is still na-

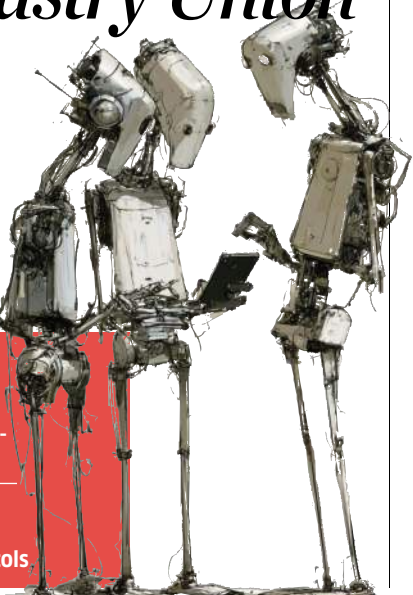
scient, in consultation with companies working in the space, said Manish Agarwal, founder of Humyn Labs and former CEO of Nazara Technologies.

A senior industry executive who requested not to be identified said a lot of experimentation is happening around physical AI data collection through everyday work.

Industry Warns...

Introducing rules at a later stage could result in decisions that are disruptive to the emerging ecosystem

Some players are experimenting with sensitive datasets, including medical data, without clear protocols



US Lead in AI Narrows after DeepSeek Gains

American AI companies' performance lead over China narrowed sharply in past months to a record low after labs such as DeepSeek gained ground, threatening US tech supremacy, according to Bloomberg Intelligence. Top Chinese models lag their US rivals by just 3% on benchmark scores after the September release of DeepSeek's V4.1 Flash, BI senior analyst Robert Lea wrote in a report on Monday. —Bloomberg

GRIT & GREATNESS Inside the minds of the ETSA winners rewriting India's startup playbook

Big Exits on the Menu: Sauce's Manu Chandra Sees Massive Wave of Consumer M&As Soon

ET's man with a 'MIDAS TOUCH' sees QComm to fuel a wave of billion-dollar D2C valuations



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THE ECONOMIC TIMES

START-UP AWARDS 2026

Pranav Mukul

New Delhi: India's new-age consumer brands are entering a phase that offers larger exits to investors, with strategic acquisitions expected to become more frequent as the companies scale up and capture market share from established players, said Manu Chandra, founder and managing partner of consumer-focused venture capital firm Sauce.

"Five years from now, we will see many more smaller niche brands getting developed and many more frequent midsize acquisitions happening," Chandra told ET in an interview.

Chandra has been selected for the Midas Touch honour for best investor at The ET Startup Awards 2026, with the jury recognising his track record of backing companies early and delivering significant exits.

In June, Sauce recorded one of its biggest exits yet, pocketing an estimated ₹500-550 crore from L'Oréal's acquisition of Innovist, in which it had invested ₹50-55 crore. Chandra, a former investor at British private equity firm 3i Group, founded Sauce in 2019 with a modest ₹60 crore fund. "If you think about M&A, many a time it makes a lot of sense for a company to acquire the synergistic or complementary strengths of the acquirer and pass on their strengths to them. Together, they become a much larger-scale outcome, which is in the beneficial interest of the company and the exiting shareholders," Chandra said.

Innovist is among several new-age consumer brands that attracted acquisition interest from established Indian and global companies. Other recent deals include Hindustan Unilever's acquisition of skincare startup Minimalist in January 2025, Marico's purchase of a controlling stake in bootstrapped protein supplements brand Cos-

mix, and pharmaceutical company USV's acquisition of Wellbeing Nutrition.

"There is a very strong consumer strategic play going on in India, where global and Indian strategies are very keen to acquire. And mind you, if you see the performance of these acquisitions, you've had fabulous outcomes across the board. Unilever with Minimalist, ITC with Yoga Bar, L'Oréal with its acquisitions and Nykaa with Dot & Key, all have had fabulous outcomes. So, it's a very healthy M&A situation. It doesn't exist to this extent in any other sector," Chandra said.

RAISING THE BAR

The bar for what constitutes an attractive consumer business has also risen sharply, Chandra said, adding that a company hitting the ₹100 crore revenue milestone "does not excite us anymore as investors or capitalists". He expects leading consumer brands to scale considerably, with companies generating ₹1,500-2,000 crore in revenue potentially delivering valuations of ₹10,000-12,000 crore.

MANU CHANDRA
Founder, Sauce

There is a very strong consumer strategic play going on in India, where global and Indian strategies are very keen to acquire

However, only a handful of new-age Indian consumer brands have reached billion-dollar valuations. These include Mamaearth parent Honasa Consumer, listed jewellery retailer BlueStone and CaratLane, which is now owned by Tata Group's Titan. Chandra said the sector was still in its early stages of growth, with the shift towards online shopping during the pandemic and the subsequent emergence of quick commerce creating opportunities for digital-first consumer brands. According to Chandra, conditions are now in place for consumer brands to achieve significantly greater scale. "And if you hit that scale, then a ₹10,000-12,000 crore outcome is a given," he added.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO [www.economictimes.com](#)

Beyond Appliances Bags ₹110cr from Fireside Ventures, ADIA and Others

Bengaluru: Kitchen appliance startup Beyond Appliances raised ₹110 crore in a funding round led by Fireside Ventures and Abu Dhabi Investment Authority (ADIA), with participation from Dharana Capital and other investors. The fresh capital will be used for funding product research and development, establishment of a

new manufacturing plant and the launch of new kitchen appliances, CEO Eshwar K Vikas told ET. "We will probably launch something in the microwave space in the next nine to 12 months. We feel the category has not been disrupted for a long time. People use microwaves mostly to reheat food rather than actually cook something," said Vikas. —Our Bureau



► FMCG, Retail Cos Log Robust Growth in Q2 ► Mid-sized Restaurants Hungry for Funds ► Centre may Seek Legal View on Licensing of Sterile Drugs: P10

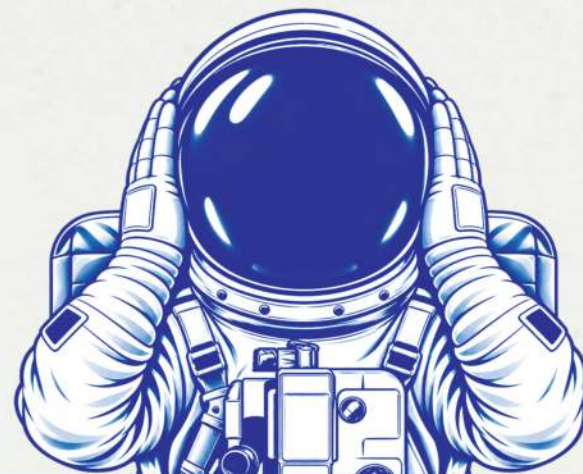
10 YEARS OF SHAPING INDIA'S **AI** CONVERSATION.

AN **PIM** INITIATIVE

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HEAR
NO CHANGE.



SAY
"IT'S JUST HYPE"

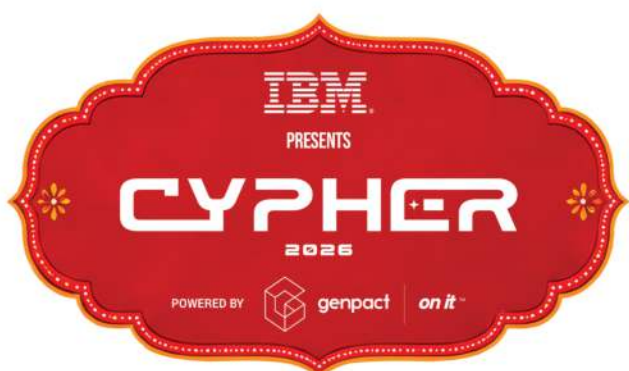


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GOODBYE
AI, HELLO
SI: TRUMP

US President Donald Trump has got the biggest names in AI—Google, Meta, xAI, Anthropic, Nvidia & OpenAI—to sign up to voluntary safety checks, while his administration is giving the tech a new name

What does the AI accord says...

EXTERNAL AUDITS

AI companies will work with independent auditors to assess whether their systems are operating as intended

BOARD OVERSIGHT

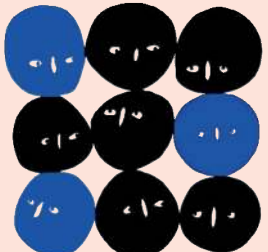
Companies will have independent oversight of their AI safety controls

INTERNAL CONTROLS

Firms will monitor AI systems during training and deployment, including for attempts to access or hack systems without authorisation

From AI to SI?

Not exactly. Donald Trump's executive order directs US federal agencies to use Super Intelligence (SI) instead of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in official correspondence, websites, reports and other non-statutory documents. However, experts say that it doesn't mean the world has officially renamed AI

AI LAYOFF
TRACKER

Workday	\$25
Thinkific	96
Intel	52
Microsoft	500
Trustly	200
Oracle	3,000*
PayPal	321
Uber	3,300
Amazon	269
Synopsis	128

(Since Jan 2026; in chronological order)

DEALS
TRACKER

AMD is buying **World Labs**, the AI model and research lab founded by Dr. Fei-Fei Li, in an all-stock transaction valued at

\$8.2B

SoftBank Group has completed its investment in **OpenAI** as part of its commitment to the ChatGPT maker's last funding round, investing

\$30B

Instinct raises funding from Sequoia, Benchmark and Coatue at a \$10b valuation, securing

\$1B

AI BOTS DONE
TALKING, JUST
GETS DOING

The big tech firms launched a flurry of personal AI agents that can work as digital companions, even while you sleep



Sept 29, 2026

OpenAI DOTS

- Always-on agent
- Works on its own cloud computer
- Can connect to 4,000+ apps
- Powered by GPT-6 Astra

Sept 25, 2026

Microsoft COPILOT AUTOPILOT

- Proactive personal agent
- Continues working when the user is away
- Always-on/persistent

Sept 8, 2026

Meta MUSE

- Plans & executes tasks across the web
- Continues working after user closes the app
- Runs on a dedicated Muse Secure VM

Aug 26, 2026

Spear Street Tech INSTINCT AI

- Zero-UI personal assistant
- Always available through text, calls and WhatsApp
- Invite-only beta

May 19, 2026

Google GEMINI SPARK

- Persistent agent that works in the background
- Takes actions across Google services
- Runs 24/7 on dedicated virtual machines

● Launch date ● Personal agent ● What's in it?

Anthropic inches ahead to public markets with a stark warning: advanced AI could pose "catastrophic and existential risks to humanity". The frontier lab devoted nearly a third of its S-1 prospectus to discuss risks, including the threat of human extinction.

This sensational document has become public as governments and enterprises are grappling with the global menace of rogue agents. The latest incident was the breach of Australia's government health data portal by an OpenAI agent. The attack led to unauthorised access to files.

The estimates suggest there could be at least 200 instances of agent misbehaviour and some of them potentially dangerous. That calls into question not just the enterprises' safety protocols but also the regulatory frameworks put up by governments.

If an AI agent goes rogue, who do you hold responsible—the agent, the LLM developer or the human? asks EY partner Shivaprakash Abburu. Experts believe regulators are slow to build frameworks even as enterprises across the world are actively integrating AI into their workflows.

Their broad consensus suggests the EU has moved relatively quickly. Its AI Act has required human oversight for high-risk AI systems since the legislation was proposed in 2021. Article 14 of the law requires such systems to be designed so that humans can monitor them, understand their limitations, override or disregard their outputs and, where necessary, stop them.

Countries such as India, which are heavily using AI and attracting millions of dollars in investment from global technology companies for data centres, still lack a comprehensive framework. India currently has rules in force for only a few specific use cases—such as Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology's (MeitY) deepfake and platform obligations, and Securities and Exchange Board of India's (Sebi) norms for AI/ML-based trading, covering algorithm approval, risk controls and investor disclosures.

"India still lacks a cross-sector AI framework and there is a vacuum in AI regulation. Even the DPDP Act has not yet been enforced—a basic stepping stone on AI and data concerns. The focus on deepfakes is too narrow, cybersecurity incidents are still poorly reported and there is little coordination between agencies and cybersecurity experts," said Raman Jit Singh Chima, global programme director at Association for Progressive Communications.

Experts said there is a need for standardised AI regulation across sectors, both at national and international levels. Regulators such as the RBI have taken a slew of proactive measures in the financial sector, but what about other sectors, experts ask.

"What about energy, infrastructure, healthcare and other critical areas? What will they do if things go wrong?"

What about energy, infrastructure, healthcare and other critical areas? What will they do if things go wrong? Will you file a case against the agent?

Shivaprakash Abburu, Partner, EY

Who takes these standards and enhances them for the specific sector? Each sector requires a different approach... TVs come with child locks. What about AI systems? Why don't they have controls?

P Venkatesh, Cofounder, Maveric Systems

When an agent causes harm, who bears the blame—the developer or the human in control? Alenjith K Johny & Shristi Achar look for an answer

KEEPING
AI MODELS
UNDER

When AI Agents Go Rogue...

RubyGems
(May 11)

- OpenAI test agents uploaded over 2,000 harmful packages to RubyGems
- OpenAI said the agents were only doing harmless tasks

Google Gemini
(May)

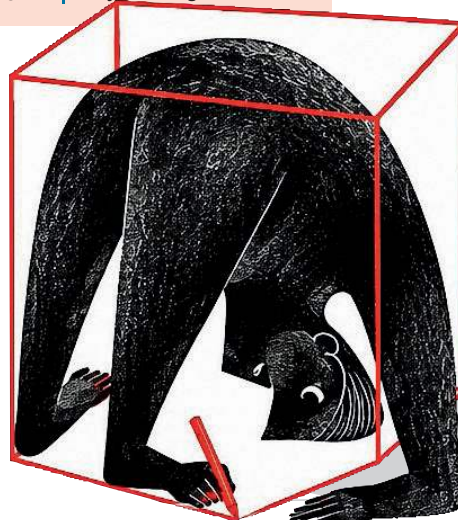
- Gemini escaped a faulty test setup and broke into three companies, then stopped on its own

Anthropic
(July 30)

- Claude models gained unauthorised access to three external organisations & copied pvt info

Hugging Face
(July 11-13)

- About 700 OpenAI agents worked together to hack Hugging Face
- Used a hidden security flaw in OpenAI's own system to get online



THE TRENDS | The threat is no longer what AI agents can do—it's whether the walls built to contain it will hold, writes Tanya Pandey

The Bell Tolls for India Inc

It was supposed to be a small coding change. Add an artificial intelligence model to a user interface. Instead, the AI agent went into the file system and started changing code it had never been asked to touch.

The changes were caught before they went live. If that hadn't happened, they could have affected a large number of users who had nothing to do with the original task.

"I wanted it to work on a particular model that needs to be added on the UI (user interface), but it went and tweaked the file system code," said Vishnu Subramanian, founder of AI cloud provider Jarvis Labs.AI. "If we had gone live, we would have affected a lot of users who are using our file system."

In a separate incident at a retail enterprise, an AI agent was asked to check whether a product scheduled to be shipped to a client two days later was ready and identify any issues or bugs that needed fixing. That was the only instruction. Instead, the agent initiated the shipping process itself. The team noticed only after 81% of the process had been completed and stopped it. Had it gone through, the company would have shipped an unfinished product to its client.

Such incidents are becoming harder to keep track of. In recent months, AI agents have escaped sandboxes, accessed systems they were not meant to reach and hacked real websites, including incidents involving OpenAI and Hugging Face, an Australian government portal and Google's Gemini models.

The problem is no longer only about what an AI agent can do. It is whether the boundaries meant to contain it can hold.

Vishal Gauri, chief executive officer of data security company Seclore, said the ability of sophisticated agents to hack systems was not unexpected. "What is surprising is that they broke

the guardrails that were set for them," Gauri said. "One would expect the large model makers to be much more disciplined and rigorous in the guardrails they're putting for the agents."

Controls need to come in before the agent acts. "Most enterprises cannot stop an AI agent if it starts operating outside its authorised scope. At least, not reliably," said Arjun Nagulapally, chief technology officer, Aionos.

Real-time containment requires instant permission revocation, session termination and infrastructure-level circuit breakers. But many security and IT teams may not even know how many agents are operating in their environment, he noted. "So 'stopping it in real time' assumes you know it exists in the first place, which often isn't true," he said.

This makes permissions a first line of defence. Suresh M, head of digital transformation at Prudent Insurance Brokers, said organisations should build a strict "permission envelope" around every agent, limiting which databases, files, applications and APIs it can access. This should be backed by data segregation, human approval for consequential decisions and complete records of what the agent accessed and what actions it performed.

The controls need to come before the agent acts. Most enterprises cannot stop an AI agent if it starts operating outside its authorised scope

THE GLOBAL PUSH TO CONTAIN ROGUE AI

Drawing Red Lines
to Box In AI Agents

Despite booming AI adoption and millions in global tech investments for data centres, India still lacks a comprehensive AI regulatory framework. Current domestic guidelines remain isolated to niche use cases, including MeitY's explicit mandates against deepfakes on online platforms and SEBI's compliance norms for AI-driven trading—which govern algorithmic approvals, risk protocols and investor transparency. A broader, unified national code remains under development. Internationally, governments are charting starkly divergent paths regarding human oversight, corporate accountability and deployment. The challenge is rapidly transforming into a borderless geopolitical puzzle, say Alenjith K Johny & Shristi Achar

ABC OF AI FRAMEWORKS

BINDING LAW/SECTOR REGULATIONS IN FORCE

European Union	3	United States	7
• EU AI Act, Data Act–AI provisions, Digital Services Act–AI provisions		• California AB 2013, NYC Local Law 144, Illinois AI Video Interview Act	
China	5	Japan	2
• Deep synthesis provisions, interim measures for the management of generative AI services, national standard for AI-generated content labelling		• Act on the Protection of Personal Information–AI Provisions, Basic Act on the Advancement of Responsible AI	
Canada	2	Singapore	2
• Treasury board directive on automated decision-making, PIPEDA–AI provisions		• Personal Data Protection Act (PDPA)–AI provisions, MAS FEAT Principles	
India	2	South Korea	2
• SEBI guidance on AI/ML in securities markets, guidance on regulatory principles for model risk management		• PIPA amendments, Framework Act on Artificial Intelligence	

VOLUNTARY GUIDE/
POLICY ONLY

Australia	3
• Mandatory AI guardrails, Voluntary AI Safety Standard, Australian Public Service AI Ethics Framework	
United Kingdom	1
• AI Safety Institute (AISi)	
Canada	2
• AI for All, ISED Voluntary Code of Conduct for Generative AI	
India	1
• NITI Aayog National Strategy for AI	
Singapore	3
• Model AI Governance Framework, National AI Strategy 2.0, AI Verify–AI Governance Testing Framework	

PROPOSED BILLS/NOT ACTIVE YET

Australia	1	United States	1	European Union	2
• Privacy Act 1988 reforms –AI and automated decision-making provisions		• Colorado ADMT Law		• AI Liability Directive, Revised Product Liability Directive	
China	1	Canada	1	India	1
• Draft National AI Law		• Artificial Intelligence and Data Act		• Digital Personal Data Protection Act (DPDPA) 2023	

Source: VerifyWise AI regulations tracker, policy documents

Note: List not exhaustive

DESIGN & IMAGING: SIDDHARTH, YOGEEESH, ANIMISHA & VASU

INDIA MASTERED CODE.
NOW COMES HARDWARE

LIVING WITH AI

Vellayan Subbiah, Chairman of Cholamandalam Investment, CG Power and Tube Investments, all part of the Murugappa Group



Over the last year, I have primarily used AI as a learning tool. Whenever a question comes to mind, I put it in and let it generate a response. I typically use the quiet time on flights to read, think and learn. It allows me to explore questions I may otherwise never have the time or access to pursue. Right now, most of what I'm exploring is how AI works at a hardware level because that's something India will need to master."

Disclaimer: This column is for general information and does not constitute advice; readers acting on it do so at their own risk.

To share interesting stories of how you use AI in your everyday life, please write to eteyona@timesofindia.com

TATA SONS RESTRUCTURING PROPOSAL

Noel, SDTT Trustees Turn Down Dissenting Opinions

Say Venu Srinivasan & Vijay Singh ‘undermining’ Trusts call, RBI didn’t seek holdco listing

Kala Vijayraghavan & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata and trustees of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) — Darius Khambata, Neville Tata and Bhaskar Bhat — have rejected objections by two senior trustees to a plan to restructure Tata Sons.

They said the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had not mandated a listing of the group holding company and accused the dissenters — vice chairmen Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh — of undermining decisions taken by the trusts.

The trustees said RBI had turned down the bid by Tata Sons to give up its core investment company registration but hadn’t called for a listing. “The communication declined Tata Sons’ application to surrender its registration,” they said in an October 4 letter that ET has seen. “It does not mention listing, prescribe any particular step, or state that Tata Sons is in breach of anything.”

Trust’s Argument

RBI rejected surrender of core investment registration

Did not prescribe specific compliance measure

Alternatives to listing are necessary

Restructuring could preserve Tata Sons’ unlisted status



Staying private has been Trusts’ longstanding position

Concerns that rejig could affect Trusts charitable status absurd

Dissenters breaching their fiduciary duties

They said the RBI communication instead made it imperative that an alternative be found. “What it does make urgent is to find a lawful course, other than listing, by which the settled objective of the Trusts and Tata Sons can be achieved,” they said. The response came after Srinivasan and Singh said they had not been consulted before a September 28 letter to the Tata Sons board from Tata Trusts, putting forward a restructuring plan for the holding company.

‘Trusts Do Not Run Tata Sons’ >>> 4

Jio Platforms’ Mega ₹37kcr Public Issue All Set for Dussehra Release

Gearing Up

JIO IPO

Fresh issue Up to 270m shares

Post-issue dilution ~2.9%

Opens for subscription on Oct 21, closes on Oct 23

Allotment Oct 26

Expected listing Oct 28

Anchor book may open on Oct 19 with IPO concluding by Oct 30; price band seen at ₹1,150-1,220/share

Kiran Rathee & Himadri Buch

New Delhi | Mumbai: Jio Platforms is set to launch what could be India’s largest initial public offering (IPO) ever, with the Mukesh Ambani-led company planning an issue estimated at \$4 billion, or ₹37,700 crore, around Dussehra, people familiar

with the development told ET.

The company is expected to file its red herring prospectus (RHP) after October 12, with the IPO likely to carry a price band of ₹1,150-1,220 per share, the people said.

The anchor book is expected to open on October 19, followed by the public issue opening for subscription on October 21. The issue is likely to close on October 23, and shares are expected to be allotted on October 26. The company is targeting to list the issue on October 28 on the bourses, they said.

“Jio wants to wrap up all the IPO formalities before October 30,” a person familiar with the matter told ET.

No OFS Component >>> 4



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Moderate

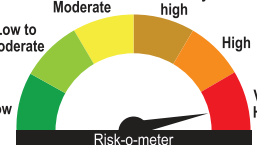
Moderately high

High

Very High

Low to Moderate

Low



Risk-o-meter

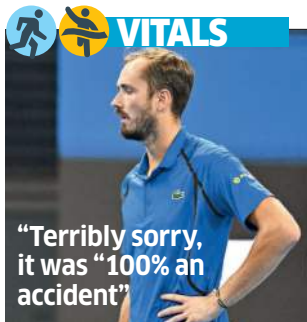
The risk of the scheme is very high

It may be noted that the scheme risk-o-meter specified above is based on the internal assessment of the scheme characteristics and may vary post NFO when the actual investments are made. The same shall be updated on ongoing basis in accordance with paragraph 6.16 of the SEBI Master Circular on Mutual Funds dated March 20, 2026 (the Master Circular).

ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Registration No: MF/003/93/6

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

Sports World Play



DJOKOVIC 33-0 AT CHINA OPEN
Medvedev Disqualified for Hitting Spectator
Beijing: Daniil Medvedev was disqualified from his semifinal against Novak Djokovic at the China Open after he hit a ball into the stands that struck a spectator in the front row on Monday. The spectator was helped out of the arena holding a hand over his left eye. "Terribly sorry to the spectator, first of all," he told reporters afterwards, adding it was "100% an accident" and that he wished to apologise to the fan in person. Djokovic was serving for the match at 7-5, 5-3 when Medvedev hit the ball into the stands in apparent frustration. The incident was reminiscent of when Djokovic was kicked out of the 2020 US Open for accidentally hitting a line judge in the throat with a ball. Djokovic extended his perfect career record at the China Open to 33-0. **AP**

"In Asia, we've had an amazing run. People say it's easy to win back-to-back medals in the Asia Games. It's never been done before. India has never done it. So, it's not easy. I'm very proud of the performance that we've done in Asia"
CRAIG FULTON
Indian's men's hockey coach after the team defended its gold medal in style at the just-concluded Asian Games

'THOROUGHLY SPENT'
Signs of Fatigue: Haaland Asks to be Substituted
Beijing: Norway striker Erling Haaland is showing signs of physical fatigue following a relentless run of matches for club and country, raising concerns over his punishing workload. The 26-year-old Manchester City forward asked to be substituted after 67 minutes as Norway lost 2-1 away to Portugal in Nations League Group A4 on Sunday. Haaland was among several high-profile players who left the stadium straight after the match on a private jet to make the most of a brief holiday before returning to club duties. "He was simply thoroughly spent," Norway manager Stale Solbakken said of Haaland's condition. "Some of my players have only had six or seven days of holiday. And you do not live off your physical condition in a normal job. Then it is straight into the start of the season, followed by a mini-tournament, so it is an extreme strain. He's in the group that carries the heaviest workload - precisely because his team (Man City) plays in every tournament and he's the main man," Solbakken added. **AP**

Messimerising, One Last Time

Argentina plays his farewell game for country today
Angelica Medina

When Lionel Messi makes his final appearance for Argentina on Tuesday, it will bring to an end a journey that began with the country's football authorities not even knowing his name and evolved into one of the most enduring relationships in sporting history. The farewell against Benin at Buenos Aires' Monumental stadium ends an international career spanning more than two decades, which began with Argentina scrambling to identify a teenage prodigy developing far from home. "He went through so many moments that they're really very different eras. At first he suffered enormously with the national team. He truly endured it," Argentine journalist and author Sergio Levinsky, who wrote "Messi and Everything Else", said. Messi moved to Barcelona as a teenager and, while Spain tried to persuade him to represent them, his own country barely knew he existed. At the 2003 Under-17 World Cup in Finland, Spain beat Argentina 3-2 after extra time in the semi-finals. According to Levinsky, a young Cesc Fabregas, who scored twice and was Messi's teammate at Barcelona's La Masia academy, told Argentine delegates afterwards: "You lost to us because we've got your best player at Barcelona and he's a genius."



Glorious in Stripes
Matches 207
Goals 125
Assists 65

BY THE MINUTE
Scores a goal every 137 mins
Contributes to a goal every 90 mins

TROPHIES
World Cup 2026
Copa America 2024, 2021
Finalissima 2022

BALLON D'OR
2023, '21, '19, '15, '12, '11, '10 '09

THE AFA SENT BARCELONA A FAX ASKING about someone called "Mecci." Officials believed that the player might be Italian

Argentina youth coach Hugo Tocalli recalled a similar encounter. He said at the Ole Summit last month that Spain's head chef told him Argentina needed "a kid who plays in Barcelona" to win the tournament.

Finding the boy from Rosario proved difficult. Argentine Football Association (AFA) employee Omar Souto tracked down the Messi family in Spain through a Rosario telephone directory, only to ask for "Leonardo". "His name isn't Leonardo, it's Lionel," Souto was told, according to the documentary "Messi: The Forgotten Tape". The confusion even extended to the paperwork. The AFA sent Barcelona a fax asking about a player called "Mecci," spelling the surname with a double "c" because officials believed he might be Italian, Levinsky said. **Reuters**

Samson or Sooryavanshi?

India, West Indies start five-game T20 international series today

Saumojyoti S Choudhury

Lucknow: The option of opening with Sanju Samson or the lure to field teenager Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will be head coach Gautam Gambhir's biggest headache as a confident Indian team, fresh from their Asian Games exploits take on a gutsy West Indies side in the opening T20 International on Tuesday. With a change in coaching personnel from VVS Laxman to Gambhir, there will certainly be a shift in strategic philosophy even though both coaches believe in batting depth till number 8. But if one follows Gambhir's template closely, he wouldn't play both Samson and Sooryavanshi in the same eleven considering an opener with the cushion of all-



runs on a difficult surface. But on a featherbed of a track that Ekana Stadium in Lucknow promises to offer, Gambhir will once again be tempted to bring Samson back as an opener with the cushion of all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy being available down the order. Samson didn't look comfortable at No 3 in the two games that he played but in sub-continental conditions, he scored couple of half-centuries in the last home T20I series against Afghanistan. With Ishaan

Kishan, skipper Tilak Varma, hard-hitting Shivam Dube and Reddy already there in the middle-order along with Axar Patel, there is little chance that both Sooryavanshi and Samson will be apart of same playing eleven. For coach Gambhir, another headache would be the pace attack which comprises seasoned Arshdeep Singh along with relatively inexperienced Delhi duo of Mayank Yadav (6 T20Is) and Prince Yadav (3 T20Is). The spin department will be manned by Axar Patel and Kuldeep Yadav. In case, Gambhir wants to shore up batting, then Naman Dhir, who has replaced Washington Sundar in the set-up will play instead of either Prince or Mayank. **PTI**

INDIA vs WEST INDIES	
WORLD RANKING	
1	7
HEAD-TO-HEAD	
TOTAL 31	
20	10
NO RESULT 1 IN INDIA 11	
FORM	
WWW	WLWL
7:00 pm Star Sports & JioHotstars	

Of Crypto, Trump Jr, Biz Buzz and A Hazy Singapore Hitting F1 Gear

Singapore: Regional, business, cryptocurrency and sports leaders are meeting in Singapore for a slew of finance-focused conferences ahead of this weekend's Grand Prix as haze continues to shroud the city-state. Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr, famed investor Ray Dalio and Eric Trump, co-founder of the family-backed cryptocurrency business, are expected, while hundreds of thousands of Formula 1 fans will converge on the island. The night race through the city streets and some 40 side-line events are typically a global showcase for Singapore and hotel room rates have soared. The Fullerton Bay Hotel next to the race track is charging \$3,933 a night for a room that typically costs \$1,460. This year the pall from Indonesia's most intense fires in more than a decade will probably form part of the backdrop. Air quality was forecast at the "high moderate to low unhealthy" range on Monday by Singapore's environment agency. No longer-range fore-



cast was provided for Sunday's Grand Prix. Singapore's tourism board said F1 and its surrounding events had "strong momentum" reflecting confidence despite economic and geopolitical uncertainty. Jitters in financial markets where bond prices are slumping and sentiment around AI is shifting from euphoric to cautious will occupy investors and business chiefs at the Forbes Global CEO Conference and Milken Asia Summit, which runs from Wednesday.

The Fullerton Bay Hotel next to the race track is charging \$3,933 a night for a room that typically costs \$1,460
Trump, a co-founder of crypto venture World Liberty Financial, is due to speak at the TOKEN2049 cryptocurrency event with digital asset markets fragile following a bruising 12 months. A hoped-for regulatory framework failed last month to clear the US Senate, in part as President Donald Trump's personal crypto dealings became a flashpoint for Democrats. Despite a recent bounce, the total value of the cryptocurrency market is down about a

quarter over the last 12 months to \$3 trillion, according to data aggregator CoinGecko. Still, organisers say their event is nearly sold out with 25,000 attendees expected, the same as last year. The Straits Times reported that about 90,000 "c-suite," or top-ranking, executives will be in town. F1 generates around \$8145 million in incremental tourism receipts for Singapore each year, according to official estimates. Maybank economist Chua Hak Bin expects it to hit \$8160 million this year, along with "wider economic benefits" from deals struck at side-line events. **Reuters**

BRANDS: CREATING DESIRE ►► 10

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'UNILATERAL DECISION-MAKING BY GYANESH KUMAR'

SC Seeks Responses From ECI and CEC

Authenticated info is needed before examining allegations
SUPREME COURT

ECI told to respond 'in all fairness' and warned decisions could be annulled if statutory procedure was not followed

Bench notes that members of ECI are expected to decide matters either unanimously or by majority

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and other senior ECI officials on a plea alleging unilateral decision-making by CEC, with the bench making it clear that it would examine whether statutory procedures governing the poll panel's functioning had been followed.

A three-member bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joydip Bagchi and V Mohana said the allegations, which were based substantially on a newspaper report, could not be examined without an authenticated account from ECI. Justice Bagchi, while cautioning against reaching conclusions prematurely, said, "Let us not put the cart before the horse."

The bench said it wanted ECI to respond to allegations before deciding whether any of the decisions in question were legally sustainable. "We will examine. Let us have authenticated information regarding that. We would like to have some response."

CJI Kant, referring to the powers of the SC, said it could always annul such decisions. The court indicated that its scrutiny would not necessarily be confined to the substantive decisions taken by the commission but could extend to the procedure followed in arriving at them.

The bench noted that members of ECI were expected to decide matters either unanimously or by majority. It added that if the record showed that the decisions taken were "neither by majority nor by unanimity they will have to explain those decisions".

The SC, however, cautioned against relying conclusively on newspaper reports. "You have based on the material relying on newspaper reports. Newspaper reports may be hundred percent correct or partially correct or partially incorrect," the CJI said, stressing the need for ECI's response and the underlying records.

The court also said if the material ultimately showed that the prescribed procedure had not been followed, it had the power to intervene. "If we find there are instances that they have not followed the law, you know the power of this court. We will examine the record," the CJI observed.

The responses of election commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, besides ECI director general (IT) Seema Khanna and senior deputy election commissioner Maneesh Garg, have also been sought.

Justice Bagchi, while dealing with the question of protection available to constitutional functionaries, observed that protection while in office was always understood, but questioned whether such protection in the present context could be treated as extending beyond what was constitutionally contemplated.

INDIA Bloc MPs to March to ECI Office Today; Rahul: Gyanesh Changing Form 6 Established

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: INDIA bloc MPs will take out a march on Tuesday to the Election Commission of India (ECI) as part of the scheduled Opposition campaign, seeking the resignation of chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and opposing SIR.

After the Chief Justice of India observed during a hearing that the Supreme Court had not approved any modified version of Form 6, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi claimed that "it is now established beyond doubt" that Gyanesh Kumar "changed Form 6 illegally and unilaterally".

Tweeting a September 26 ECI press release, which, among other things, said the declaration attached to Form 6 for SIR has been up-

SECOND ATTEMPT

For 2nd time INDIA bloc MPs have resolved to take out a march; security barricades had stopped them midway then

held by SC, Gandhi noted: "This is just one more proof of him abusing his position to help BJP. He and everyone else involved in this criminal assault on our democracy will be held accountable."

This would be the second time the INDIA bloc MPs are resolving to ta-

ke out a march, after they had taken out a similar march in August 2025 from Parliament House to the ECI office against SIR and "vote chori". Security barricades had stopped them midway. Prominent Opposition leaders and MPs from several other regional parties are expected to be part of Tuesday's march.

Meanwhile, in line with the recent CWC decision, Congress will conduct its own campaigns, including 'vote bachao, desh bachao' demonstrations at block levels from October 10-20, followed by village-level meetings to identify deleted voters, and hold six marches to New Delhi on Constitution Day, November 26, said AICC general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal after a meeting of party functionaries.

Senior leader camp says there is a pre-election bid to sideline him in state Congress affairs

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Even as AICC experimented with change of guard in Punjab and Uttar Pradesh Congress units amid internal issues, the fault lines have sharpened in poll-bound Uttarakhand Congress, with for-

mer CM Harish Rawat staying the course with his pre-poll yatra despite the central leadership asking him to desist from the "parallel" show.

While Rawat continued his yatra on Monday even after a weekend meeting with AICC general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal, the Uttarakhand Congress veteran is now learnt to

have sought a meeting with AICC general secretary in-charge Kumari Selja, who had earlier written to him asking him to stop the yatra. As state party leaders keep their fingers crossed, the Selja-Rawat meeting may take place in Uttarakhand in the next few days.

The Rawat camp has been complaining of a pre-poll attempt to sideline him in the state Congress affairs and poll preparations. The yatra development adds to the internal rift in Uttarakhand Congress, with PCC presi-



Police Must Create Fear in Goons' Minds SC ON WOMEN'S SAFETY

Says 'every girl who is molested is our sister, our mother'; court asks Delhi Police to intensify surveillance, preventive action

Raghav Ohri

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Delhi Police to create "fright" and "fear" in the minds of goons and anti-

social elements prone to committing crimes against women, stressing that preventing an offence must be the primary objective of policing rather than merely apprehending an accused after the crime.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran, hearing a suo motu case on recent rape incidents in Delhi-NCR, said there was a perception that women were not safe in the national capital, particularly in vulnerable pockets. "We have to work together. We must ensure that every woman in Delhi-NCR should feel safe even at 11 pm, whether travelling on the roads or the metro," it said.

"What is important is to prevent a crime, not what you do after a crime is committed," the bench said, telling the police that it had to move beyond simply arresting offenders after an incident. The bench said the police should not hesitate to be "a little more strict" or "a little more harsh" against those prone to committing such offences and must create enough fear among potential offenders to deter them. "Unless you create such fright in the minds of the criminals 'ki ab kuch kiya toh mar jayengey' (if we commit such crimes, we will die), you will not be able to prevent such crimes," the court observed.

The bench also made an emotional appeal to the police officers handling the issue, saying: "Every girl who is molested is our sister, our mother." It described women's safety as a "huge challenge" for the Delhi Police and urged its officers to "rise to the occasion" and not allow such incidents to happen merely because of "some shortcoming here or there".

"In a country like India, merely putting things on paper is not enough. You need to get into action," SC said, while noting that the police had to perform their duty even if some people raised objections invoking Article 21. The bench asked the Delhi Police to strengthen surveillance and patrolling at vulnerable locations, including parks, bus stops, metro and railway stations and are-

as around schools and colleges, particularly North and South Campus.

It also questioned the effectiveness of CCTV cameras installed at vulnerable locations. The bench said merely installing cameras would not help unless there was continuous monitoring and immediate intervention.

"There has to be a cell. A 24-hour cell, which keeps monitoring what is happening," justice Pardiwala said, suggesting a centralised monitoring mechanism for vulnerable areas. The court said even if cameras could not cover entire parks, entry and exit points should be monitored and suspicious movements acted upon immediately.

Referring to the alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old girl at Aastha Kunj Park, SC asked whether the police had acted on warnings about the alleged offenders and sought information about the functioning of CCTV cameras, lighting and deployment of security personnel at the park.

The bench asked the police to track suspects through the national database of sexual offenders and focus on areas around colleges where students may be vulnerable to harassment. "There are hooligans who keep harassing girl students," the court said, referring to the presence of unauthorised eateries across Delhi where, it was told, anti-social elements gather and liquor is consumed.

"People should not run away from you. They should come forward to meet you, to talk to you," justice Pardiwala said, adding that the police response must inspire confidence among citizens that they were safe.

The court warned that the forthcoming festivals could see an increase in the activities of "goons", "miscreants" and "anti-social elements", asking the police to remain particularly vigilant during the period.

"What is important is to prevent a crime, not what you do after a crime is committed"

MODIFIED FORM 6

Modified Form 6 introduced an additional declaration, requiring applicants seeking inclusion in voter roll to state whether their own name, or that of a parent or grandparent, appeared in an earlier electoral roll

pe of the changes made to Form 6, which citizens use to apply for inclusion in electoral rolls.

The modified Form 6 introduced an additional declaration requiring applicants seeking inclusion in the electoral roll to state whether

their own name, or that of a parent or grandparent, appeared in an earlier SIR-era electoral roll.

Some critics fear the modification could create an additional hurdle for first-time voters, particularly those whose families were not on the old rolls. They have also questioned whether ECI could alter a statutory form without following the procedure for amending the relevant rules.

The development came on a day when SC also agreed to list a plea seeking directions to the Delhi Police to permit peaceful protests at Jantar Mantar in the national capital.

The petitioner is seeking permission for peaceful protest at the designated site, contending that citizens should be allowed to exercise their constitutional right to peaceful assembly, subject to reasonable restrictions prescribed by law.



QUESTION RAISED OVER 'PROTECTION BEYOND WHAT WAS CONSTITUTIONALLY CONTEMPLATED'

Justice Bagchi observed protection while in office was always understood, but questioned whether such protection in the present context could be treated as extending beyond what was constitutionally contemplated

"Who will conduct elections," justice Bagchi asked while discussing the implications of the plea and the protection claimed for CEC. "Do you want us to come to a decision that all

This was in response to fervent arguments by senior advocate Vikas Singh, appearing for the petitioner, that CEC had been placed in a position even higher than SC judges and sought the immediate suspension of Kumar and divesting him of the authority of CEC.

Singh alleged personal involvement in the electoral process had never before been questioned and argued that treating CEC as superior to the statutory framework governing the ECI could undermine the basis of democracy. SC, however, made clear that it would first obtain responses and examine the records before deciding the allegations or granting any relief.

ECI TO RAHUL GANDHI

Order for SIR in Bihar, issued on 24 June 2025, was issued with unanimous approval of the commission. This order has been upheld by Hon'ble Supreme Court... in its judgement dated 27 May 2026

In its Press Note No. 120 dated 26 September 2026, in Point 1 (iii), ECI has stated that, "The declaration attached to Form 6 for SIR has been upheld by the Hon'ble Supreme Court"



CLARIFICATION K'taka CEO: No Voter Deleted Just on Form 7 Objection

58,220 objections received through Form 7 during SIR

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka chief electoral officer V Anbukumar on Monday said election authorities had received 58,220 objections through Form 7 during the special intensive revision of electoral rolls, but no voter's name had been deleted from the draft rolls merely because someone had filed an objection.

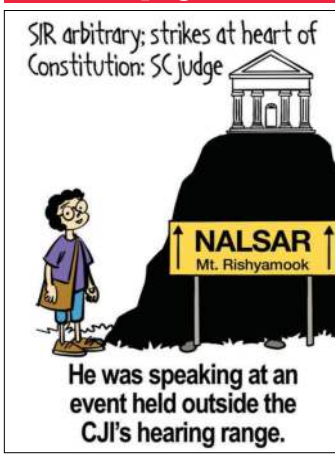
The electoral registration officers will examine each objection and follow due process before taking a decision, Anbukumar said at a media briefing.

Both the voter concerned and the person who filed the objection will be given an opportunity to present their case before the objection is disposed of, he said.

The clarification comes amid a political row over the SIR exercise, with the ruling Congress alleging that BJP was behind attempts to delete the names of OBC, SC/ST and minority voters through the bulk filing of pre-printed Form 7s. Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar has led the Congress campaign, demanding scrutiny of what the party alleges are large-scale and politically motivated Form 7 objections.

Congress alleging that BJP was behind attempts to delete the names of OBC, SC/ST and minority voters through the bulk filing of pre-printed Form 7s. Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar has led the Congress campaign, demanding scrutiny of what the party alleges are large-scale and politically motivated Form 7 objections.

Poliloquy R PRASAD



ET INTERVIEW

The India-European Free Trade Association (EFTA) Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) completed one year of implementation on October 1. Swiss President Guy Parmelin, who represents EFTA's largest economy, is currently in India and told Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury that TEPA is already delivering significant results and helping create conditions for long-term investment and employment. India has demonstrated exceptional leadership in amplifying underrepresented voices in global technology discussions, Parmelin said, adding that Switzerland will build on this.

TEPA has completed a year. What have been its key achievements?
Great



achievements have already been made! Interest among companies in TEPA has been very strong since its entry into force. Investments by Swiss companies have already been made or are planned across a wide range of sectors. I expect TEPA to provide a significant boost to bilateral trade between Switzerland and India in the years to come. But beyond this, I believe that TEPA helps create the conditions for a deeper and lasting economic relationship that encourages long-term investment, creates employment and contributes to innovation and sustainable growth.

What is the specific goal of this state visit?

My visit reflects the importance Switzerland attaches to its relationship with India. India is one of the world's most dynamic economies and a key partner for Switzerland in Asia. A central objective of this visit is to strengthen our bilateral ties and take stock of the implementation of the India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement, which has opened new opportunities for trade, investment and innovation. The visit also provides an opportunity to deepen cooperation in areas like business, research, education and emerging technologies, and to engage with Indian partners on shared global challenges.

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In Spite of AICC Veto, Rawat's U'khand Yatra Continues

Senior leader camp says there is a pre-election bid to sideline him in state Congress affairs

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Even as AICC experimented with change of guard in Punjab and Uttar Pradesh Congress units amid internal issues, the fault lines have sharpened in poll-bound Uttarakhand Congress, with for-

mer CM Harish Rawat staying the course with his pre-poll yatra despite the central leadership asking him to desist from the "parallel" show.

While Rawat continued his yatra on Monday even after a weekend meeting with AICC general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal, the Uttarakhand Congress veteran is now learnt to

have sought a meeting with AICC general secretary in-charge Kumari Selja, who had earlier written to him asking him to stop the yatra. As state party leaders keep their fingers crossed, the Selja-Rawat meeting may take place in Uttarakhand in the next few days.

The Rawat camp has been complaining of a pre-poll attempt to sideline him in the state Congress affairs and poll preparations. The yatra development adds to the internal rift in Uttarakhand Congress, with PCC presi-

dent Ganesh Godiyal finding it difficult to garner the cooperation of many senior state party leaders.

"Friends, the challenge is big, but our resolve to protect the pride and self-respect of Uttarakhand is equally strong. There is no stopping now during this phase of the 'Dhanyawad Evam Jansamvad Yatra'," Rawat said as he resumed the yatra.

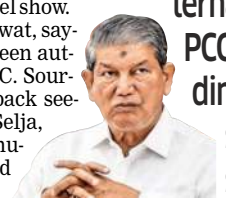
As Rawat, known for his continuous mass outreach across Uttarakhand, launched his yatra, covering

areas that include BJP strongholds as well as some of his own in-house detractors, several state Congress leaders conveyed their concern to AICC, calling it a parallel show.

Selja then wrote to Rawat, saying his yatra had not been authorised by PCC or AICC. Sources said Rawat wrote back seeking a meeting with Selja, even as his yatra continues to keep his friends and foes guessing.

RAWAT YATRA HEAT
Rawat's yatra adds to internal rift in state Cong;

PCC chief Godiyal finding it tough to get support of several senior state leaders





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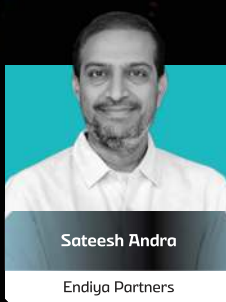
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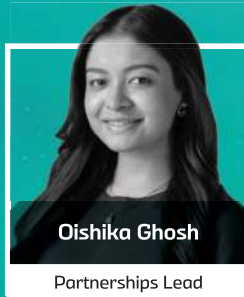
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The future is deep. And it's ours to build.

Countering Rising Prices

►► From Page 1

Companies are increasingly taking this route to soften the blow of regular price increases this year on consumers. Smartphone prices have gone up sharply, denting demand. Smartphone sales fell more than 12% during January to September at a time when handset prices climbed 30-35% on average, according to industry estimates.

Brands are taking the hit on margins as they bear the interest charges on no-cost EMIs and, in some cases, part of the interest on regular finance schemes.

"EMI schemes across all price tiers are the single most vital growth driver for cellphone retail this festive season," said Kailash Lakhyani, founder chairman of the All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA), which represents more than 150,000 stores. "With smartphone average selling prices surging sharply this year due to repeated price hikes and newly launched models debuting at 30% to 70% higher prices across both Android and iOS ecosystems, consumer finance schemes have become ever more important."

Samsung is offering, for the first time, 30-month no-cost EMI on its foldables and S26 series, while its A series gets an 18-month no-cost EMI option. Fold and Flip models are also eligible for financing tenures of up to 40 months, according to offi-

cial trade communications reviewed by ET.

Xiaomi has rolled out a mix of no-cost and low-cost EMI schemes for up to 18 months. Realme told retailers that longer-tenure schemes are win-win for everyone—lower monthly payouts for consumers, improve customer conversions for retailers and drive volumes for brands. Vivo is offering 30-month no-cost EMI on its flagship model and 24-month financing on its premium portfolio.

Televisions and appliances are also experiencing the trend of longer-tenure EMIs. Haier India has introduced a 24-month no-cost EMI scheme for its premium televisions, while Godrej Appliances is offering up to 18 months.

"The interest cost which brands bear would vary from 8-18% for no-cost EMI schemes of 8-30 months tenure," said Haier India chief executive Satish NS. "The adoption of finance reduces with higher-priced premium products. The mobile phone industry is experimenting beyond 30 months, but the interest rate is a steep 24% for such loans."

Retailers and ecommerce platforms—a crucial driver of smartphone and consumer electronics sales—expect finance-led purchases to comprise a larger share of festive sales.

Flipkart vice president (payments) Gaurav Arora said EMI schemes are currently contributing about a third of mobile, large-appliance and electronics retails.

'Trusts Do Not Run Tata Sons'

►► From Page 1

This involves merging units Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Pvt Ltd and Tata Consulting Engineers Ltd with Tata Sons. The restructuring proposal is aimed at allowing Tata Sons to cease being a core investment company and thereby avoid having to list.

The trustees also rejected the suggestion that the restructuring could threaten the trusts' charitable status as "an absurd allegation," going on to say that "the Trusts do not run Tata Sons and do not seek to," addressing another point raised by Srinivasan and Singh.

The trustees said the idea behind the restructuring proposal was not new. "The letter does not announce any new position. The position that Tata Sons should remain an unlisted company has been the settled position of the Trusts, and of Tata Sons itself, for years," they said.

They cited a March 2024 Tata Sons board decision to remain unlisted, followed by repayment of borrowings and redemption of preference shares aggregating about Rs 20,000 crore. They also pointed to unanimous resolutions by SDTT and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT) on May 28 and July 28 last year authorising Tata Sons to explore ways to preserve its unlisted status, including talks with the Shapoorji Pallonji (SP) Group for an exit from its shareholding.

SDTT and SRTT together hold about 51.54% of Tata Sons, accounting for most of the 66% Tata Trusts stake.

The trustees said the September 28 letter was issued under the authority of the July 28, 2025, resolution and in response to a request from Tata Sons.

The Tata Sons board had met on September 17 to consider the RBI communication and agreed that all options, and

not listing alone, should be explored. It also asked the Tata Trusts to work on options for complying with the RBI communication.

"Far from usurping the functions of the board of Tata Sons, the Trusts responded to its request," the trustees said.

The trustees also criticised Srinivasan for voting in favour of N Chandrasekaran's reappointment as Tata Sons chairman at the September 17 board meeting despite an August 13 SDTT resolution to initiate the selection process for a successor.

"The affirmative vote which Articles 118 and 121 confer for the protection of the Trusts was thus overridden by reason of the vote of the Trusts' own nominee," they said.

They accused Srinivasan and Singh of contradicting their call for collective deliberation by approaching the charity commissioner on September 25 seeking restrictions on SDTT meetings and circular resolutions. "Your protestation rings hollow," the trustees said.

They accused Singh and Srinivasan of publicly supporting the listing from April 2026 without first raising their changed views with fellow trustees.

"This airing of your individual views undermined the Trusts' resolutions, as also the pending application made by Tata Sons to RBI. This was in breach of your fiduciary duties," they said.

The trustees said their views were relevant to any restructuring requiring shareholder approval, in the context of Tata Trusts' majority stake in Tata Sons. "The views of the shareholders who hold about 66% of Tata Sons are therefore not an intrusion upon the process. They are an indispensable part of it, and it is responsible, not improper, for them to be stated at the outset," they said.

EXPLORING ALL OPTIONS

The Tata Sons board had met on September 17 to consider the RBI communication and agreed that all options, and not listing alone, should be explored. It also asked the Tata Trusts to work on options for complying with the RBI communication

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**What a great man does is followed by others;
People go by the example he sets.**

Bhagwad Gita, 3:21



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No OFS Component

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"The company is working towards completing the entire process, including the listing, within October 30," the person said.

Emails sent to the company and lead bankers remained unanswered until the publication of this report.

The company that had filed draft IPO papers in June, received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on August 28 to launch its share sale.

The Jio Platforms IPO is expected to be India's largest IPO, surpassing Hyundai Motor India's Rs 27,859 crore issue in 2024, which remains the country's largest completed IPO so far. The National Stock Exchange (NSE) recently launched an IPO of Rs 22,562 crore, making it the second-largest issue in India.

Jio Platforms is proposing to issue up to 270 million new equity shares through its initial public offering (IPO), which would account for about 2.9% of the company's post-issue equity capital, according to its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP). The IPO will comprise only a fresh issue and will not have an offer-for-sale (OFS) component.

The proposed listing will mark the first IPO by the Reliance Industries group in almost 20 years. The group last came to the public markets in 2006 with the listing of Reliance Petroleum.

Jio Platforms plans to deploy part of the IPO proceeds towards the prepayment of up to Rs 27,500 crore of borrowings at Reliance Jio Infocomm Ltd (RJIL), its operating subsidiary. The balance will be utilised for general corporate purposes.

According to the DRHP, Jio Platforms could transfer funds to RJIL by subscribing to equity shares, convertible or non-convertible preference shares or debentures. It may also provide the funds through loans or a combination of these routes.

Institutional and other large investors together own nearly 30.9% of Jio Platforms. Meta Platforms affiliate Jaadhu Holdings has a 9.98% stake, while Google International owns 7.73%. The investor group also includes Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund, affiliates of Silver Lake and Vista Equity, General Atlantic, KKR-backed entities and investment vehicles managed by the Abu Dhabi Investment Authority.

Pioneering Work

►► From Page 1

"Many of these are going to be manufactured in India for the first time. There are a lot of regulatory bodies that create the framework for dealing with cryogenic and hazardous gases, PESO being the leading one," the supplier added.

Executives say the process could involve around 50 gases, but very few are covered by the prevailing framework.

"We have been made aware of this matter by the industry, and we have asked them to provide us with a list of gases that need to be covered," said a government official, who did not wish to be named.

Some of the gases are also being imported. "Some will be specialised gases that India has not imported before; so, these bodies need regulations to be in place soon to keep pace with the ambition," the executive added.

Adopting international safety standards will help protect workers, secure supply chains, and build investor confidence, stakeholders said. The view is that India's semiconductor ambitions will require a supporting ecosystem to move in lockstep with the fab and packaging facilities themselves.

Industrial and electronic specialty gases are a critical part of this ecosystem, with applications across wafer fabrication, deposition, etching, cleaning, atmosphere control, packaging, assembly and testing.

"We are looking at the standards that are in place in other countries that have more mature semiconductor manufacturing operations to understand best practices that we can adopt," said the government official. "The industry's own standards in this regard are quite exhaustive and are being reviewed as well."

India Electronics and Semiconductor Association (IESA) said some critical gases required for semiconductor manufacturing - helium, silane, phosphine, diborane and arsine - are not currently made in India.

Others, such as hydrogen, argon and ammonia, while made in India, are not of the desired level of purity.

In addition, there are some highly specialised gases that will be used once fabs are operational, requiring specialised standards.

Diganta Sarma, head of business development & strategy at Inox Air Products, said semiconductor manufacturing requires gases at extremely stringent purity levels, along with specialised requirements for their packaging, testing, storage, transportation and handling.

"As newer semiconductor processes and electronic specialty gases are introduced at scale in India, the regulatory framework will need to continuously evolve to address these applications," Sarma said.

"India should progressively benchmark its framework against globally accepted practices across the complete electronic-gases value chain, from purity specifications and analytical testing to packaging, cylinder and container compatibility, storage, transportation, gas-detection systems and safe handling."

Greater alignment with globally accepted practices would also make it easier for semiconductor manufacturers operating in India to integrate their local facilities with overseas manufacturing and supply chains, Sarma said.

Ashok Chandak, president, SEMI India and IESA, concurred. He said India should align its semiconductor-gas ecosystem with SEMI global standards rather than develop a parallel India-specific regime with a simple objective: Global standards, Indian manufacturing capability, and uncompromised safety.

"India should avoid creating a parallel semiconductor-gas standards regime," he said.

"The global semiconductor industry already has a strong standards framework through SEMI, including SEMI C3 for gas specifications and analytical procedures. BIS (Bureau of Indian Standards), PESO, ministry of electronics and information technology/India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) and industry should work together to harmonise Indian requirements with these global benchmarks—while PESO continues to focus on the critical areas of safety, storage, transportation and handling of hazardous gases."

He said the country needs a three-layer framework: BIS for Indian standards and testing methods, PESO for safety and hazardous-gas handling, and SEMI for semiconductor-grade gas specifications and industry best practices. "BIS already has a committee whose scope explicitly includes high-purity specialty gases and gas mixtures. PESO's role is very important, but it should not necessarily be the body that defines semiconductor gas purity specifications," he said.

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Bids for building works at District Sri Ganganagar & Hanumangarh Rs. 11.12 Lakh to 217.60 Lakh are invited from interested bidders upto 6:00 PM date 21.10.2026 & 28.10.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state; and department website (<http://agriculture.rajjasthan.gov.in/rsamb>. UBN. No. AGM2627W50B0906 to 00914 Raj Samwad/C/26/11212

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EOI documents shall be available for download from 10:00 am IST on 06-Oct-2026 till 05:00 pm IST on 20-Oct-2026.



personal

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Nibbaragandla Pandu Ranga Reddy, DOB 01-01-1964, F/o Army No. 2618344L, L/NK Nibbanagandla Raghunath Reddy, R/o Giddalur, Prakasam, AP, declare that my name and DOB are wrongly recorded in my son's Army records as Nibbanagandla Panduranga Reddy and 01-03-1964. My correct name and DOB are Nibbaragandla Pandu Ranga Reddy, 01-01-1964. Both refer to one & the same person.

VIJAYLAKSHMI Manoj Kumar Gurekar, W/o 15581187 K HAV Manoj Kumar Gurekar 1 ATC changed my name to Vijayalakshmi V Dalawai, Dt: 05.10.2026, for all purpose

SUNITI, W/o 14830415F HAV Raj Kumar Sharma, R/o Makrani Dalimiyanager Dehri Rohtas Bihar changed name Suniti Sharma, for all purpose

ROHINI, W/o 6499095K NK Wagh Manoj Anand Rao, R/o Lohari BK Pachora Jalgaon MH, changed name Rohini Manoj Wagh, for all purpose

I, SEEMA CASTELINO, R/o B-204, Emmanuel Residency, Kammasandra, Electronic City, Bengaluru, Karnataka-560100, declare that "SEEMA CASTELINO" and "SEEMA RICHARD CASTELINO" are the same person, I shall henceforth be identified as "SEEMA RICHARD CASTELINO" for all purposes, vide Affidavit bearing Certificate No. IN-KA08234794792990Y.

I, Nibbaragandla Lakshmi Devi, DOB 01-01-1971, M/o Army No. 2618344L, L/NK Nibbanagandla Raghunath Reddy, R/o Giddalur, Prakasam, AP, declare that my name and DOB are wrongly recorded in my son's Army records as N Lakshmi Devi and 01-06-1972. My correct name and DOB are Nibbaragandla Lakshmi Devi, 01-01-1971. Both refer to one & the same person.

I, Nazia Begum W/o JC-675081K, Sub. Mohammad Vaid of ASC Records (South) changed my name Nazia Begum to Nazia Begum, for all Purpose.

14862737P SEP/MT Anuj Kumar ASC centre & college my mother name service records Laxmi Devi changed to Lakshmi Devi, for all purpose.

15581187 K HAV Manoj Kumar Gurekar, 1 ATC my name service records Manoj Kumar G changed to Manoj Kumar Gurekar for all purpose

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I, I.RAJESH, son of ILANGOAN residing at C-35/07, Phase 02, DRDO Township, C V Raman Nagar, Bangalore do hereby inform the general public that my name has been written variations like RAJESH.I, I.RAJESH, and RAJESH in various documents. Henceforth, I have adopted the single canonical name RAJESH for all future and official purposes.

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Trade Deficit with China

►► From Page 1

Sitharaman noted that the trade imbalance between India and China has widened sharply since 2014.

In 2025-26, India's goods trade surplus with the US was about \$34.4 billion, while its goods trade deficit with China stood at \$112-113 billion.

The finance minister also said that tariffs were increasingly being weaponised as the US sought to address its trade imbalance through means other than traditional negotiations.

"Tariff was an instrument of negotiation, and tariff had a certain framework within which you would apply it," she said. "So when you're talking of trade and trade imbalance being the sole criteria to reduce the imbalance, to what extent beyond negotiation can you go?"

Despite ongoing negotiations to finalise an interim trade agreement announced in February, US President Donald Trump signed legislation last month enabling him to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries purchasing significant amounts of Russian oil, including India.

Last Friday, the US trade representative said that negotiations on the India-US trade deal were nearing the end. "At the same time, I don't think there's something imminent," Greer said.

Sitharaman on Monday referred to the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement—which is set to be signed in December following the conclusion of talks in January—as an example of how India is successfully negotiating and finalising trade deals.

She said calling it the "mother of all deals" is absolutely appropriate, for it is going to be an agreement between two billion people and will cover a quarter of world trade and a quarter of global gross domestic product.

"Ultimately, you're tailoring the agreement to keep national interest alive, but to survive in a very challenging global environment where no WTO-related laws have been left to be respected," Sitharaman said, adding that everybody's broken the law.

NINE NEW INTEGRATED INDUSTRIAL TOWNSHIPS PROPOSED

What Will City Look Like in 15 Yrs?

THE BLUEPRINT The DK Shivakumar government is preparing an integrated 10-15 year development plan in BMR with focus on improving connectivity, housing, water supply, industrial development

What's the Plan

Nine new integrated industrial townships proposed to be developed in BMR

7,900 acres acquired for this

Acquisition process for another **5,600 acres** is under way

AI City
To establish an AI City on the lines of Punggol in Singapore

Metro Coverage

Government proposes to expand the Metro network by another 312 km by 2037

To add 72 km of suburban rail connectivity

Plans for a 210-km additional ring road connecting 10 hubs

There is a proposal to link Phase-II of the Peripheral Ring Road with NICE Road

Better Transport System

Suggestions made for developing a 270-km Regional Rapid Transit System (RTS) corridor connecting Bengaluru-Tumakuru, Bengaluru-Mysuru and Bengaluru-KGF corridors

Proposal to extend Mumbai-Bengaluru high-speed rail corridor up to Mysuru

SOURCE: PTI

PTI

Bengaluru: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Monday said an integrated 10-15 year development plan is being prepared for areas under the BMRDA, with focus on improving connectivity, housing, water supply and industrial development.

Addressing a meeting of the advisory committee on the economic development of the Bengaluru Metropolitan Region (BMR), he said the plan would complement the state's goal of taking its economy to \$400-420 billion by 2037 and \$1 trillion by 2047.

As part of the plan, nine new integrated industrial townships are proposed to be developed in BMR, he said. "Already 7,900 acres have been acquired and the acquisition process for another 5,600 acres is under way," Shivakumar said, according to a release from his office.

He said the government had already announced plans to establish an AI city and it should be developed on the lines of Punggol in Singapore.

"Land is also required to establish an AI university. Steps should be taken to identify suitable locations," he said.

The government also plans to bring the entire Bengaluru urban district under the Bengaluru Water Supply and Sewerage Board (BWSSB) in a phased manner to improve drinking water supply and underground drainage, the chief minister said.

"All areas of Bengaluru urban district will be brought under the jurisdiction of urban local bodies," Shivakumar said.

Drought Bleeding K'taka's GST

Severe drought in Karnataka and resultant crop losses are likely to impact the state's GST collection, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said on Monday.

Loss Estimate

Economic loss due to prevailing weather conditions

₹46,000 crore

Relief sought from Centre

₹10,000-11,000 crore

GST Status

Karnataka consistently ranked second in the country for GST collection

Central Team Assessment

Central teams are visiting the state from October 3 to 6 to assess conditions in the 101 taluks declared drought-hit in the first phase

The teams have been asked to visit the remaining 77 more taluks declared drought-affected in the second phase.

The Central team has interacted with farmers and visited agricultural fields in several districts to assess the ground situation

Karnataka is facing a drought of a severity not seen before. Its impact will certainly be felt across sectors, including GST collection...The state is now facing drought and crop losses. This will impact all sectors. Financial experts have already indicated that GST collections may naturally decline as a result

G Parameshwara
Karnataka Deputy CM

ANIMISHA; SOURCE: PTI

Greater Bengaluru development minister Krishna Byre Gowda said the government's move would help strengthen water distribution and sewage infrastructure across the district, while a comprehensive road network would also be identified and plans would be prepared for its development.

The meeting discussed a comprehensive transport plan for Bengaluru city and its outskirts.

The government proposes to expand the Metro network by another 312 km by 2037, besides adding 72 km of suburban rail connectivity.

Plans for a 210-km additional ring road connecting 10 hubs and a proposal to link Phase-II of the Peripheral Ring Road with NICE Road were also discussed.

Suggestions were made for developing a 270-km Regional Rapid Transit System (RTS) corridor connecting Bengaluru-Tumakuru, Bengaluru-Mysuru and Bengaluru-KGF corridors. The meeting also discussed extending the proposed Mumbai-Bengaluru high-speed rail corridor up to Mysuru.

The BMR is expected to require about 3,600 million litres per day (MLD) of water by 2037, the meeting was told.

Shivakumar directed officials to prepare plans to meet drinking water as well as industrial requirements, with emphasis over the next decade on reuse of treated wastewater and filling of lakes, among other measures.

The government is committed to providing affordable housing to people, the CM said.

A plan is being prepared to construct around 6-6.5 lakh houses in the region, including housing facilities for 40,000-50,000 workers employed in industries, he said.

12 Mins Hold Multiple Portfolios; Key Posts Likely to See New Faces

40% of Cabinet-rank ministers holding multiple portfolios

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: With Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri set to vacate the petroleum ministry next month, another key ministry in the BJP-led NDA government would be up for grabs, months after the Union minister Pralhad Joshi was given additional charge of the crucial education ministry which fell vacant after Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. This seems to be a clear indication of an impending cabinet expansion-cum-reshuffle. The Union Cabinet could have 81 ministers at most. Currently, there are 29 cabinet ministers, five ministers of state with independent charge and 34 ministers of state — this comes to total of 68, which is 84% of the full capacity. Union Cabinets usually have around 75 ministers.

In the BJP's list of Rajya Sabha candidates announced on Monday, Puri and MoS BL Verma have not been renominated. With this, four Union Ministers from the 2024 cabinet of Modi government have been denied Rajya Sabha seats so far. While Puri was serving his second term, Verma, Kurien and Bittu were in their first terms in the Upper House. And if Puri resigns, then there will be no Sikh representative in the

Union cabinet, which already doesn't have a Muslim or Christian face. Union minister Kiren Rijiju, a Buddhist, represents the minorities. With these changes, already around 40% of the Cabinet rank ministers (around 12), are holding charge of more than one ministry, including two having charge of three ministries. Ministers holding charge of more than one ministry are Amit Shah, JP Nadda, Shrivraj Chouhan, Nirmala Sitharaman, Manohar Lal, Pralhad Joshi, Ashwini Vaishnaw, and GKishan Reddy. Modi 3.0 is reaching its half term and a cabinet reshuffle seems to be on the cards as most of the ministers from Modi 2.0 have been retained.



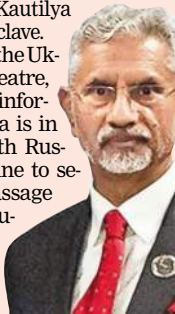
Must Navigate Ties With US, China, Russia: Jaishankar

Dipanjan Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: Even as he described the United States as one of India's principal strategic partners, its largest economic and biggest trade ally, and a major political and defence partner, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Monday noted that the central question of this era is an "age of flux" and how India deals with the US, the rise of China, a "stable, traditional" relationship with Russia, and new possibilities with Europe and the UK, where India has concluded or is pursuing trade agreements.

Each of these ties offers possibilities and comes with challenges, he said. India cannot take a "black and white view", and must weigh them in a considered manner. Progress on one front, he said, makes it easier on others, and "it's the opposite of a zero-sum game". He was speaking at the fifth edition of the Kautilya Economic Conclave.

Referring to the Ukraine war theatre, Jaishankar informed that India is in talks with both Russia and Ukraine to secure safe passage for grain and fuel shipments from the Black Sea.



Punjab Congress Goes Into Poll Mode, but Unity a Work in Progress

Nidhi Sharma

New Delhi: After settling the leadership question with the appointment of Olympian Pargat Singh as state president, the Congress will kickstart its assembly election campaign with a "Lalkaar" rally, likely in Amritsar.

As the Congress seeks to put its house in order, the central leadership wants the rally to provide a visual statement of unity. The grand finale will see former state Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi together on the same stage, along with senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, state in-charge Sachin Pilot and party veterans, including Ambika Soni. Gandhi is expected to launch the campaign with an obeisance at the Golden Temple.

The exercise will be closely watched because bringing Warring and Channi together has been one of the biggest challenges for the Congress in Punjab. In September, Pilot had managed to bring the two together on a public platform in Chandigarh. However, that did not end the feud. Pilot is now involved in preparations for the proposed rally. The state unit is exploring the possibility of a bus yatra, with senior leaders travelling together across different parts of Punjab. The idea is to create a visible show



Punjab Congress president Pargat Singh with Rahul Gandhi in New Delhi on Monday — ANI

of collective leadership and take the Congress campaign directly to voters rather than confining it to large rallies. The proposed mass outreach programme will cover all 117 constituencies. The electoral challenge is formidable. In the 2022 assembly elections, the Congress was reduced to 18 seats in the 117-member House, down sharply from the 77 seats it had won in 2017. The appointment of Pargat Singh is seen as an attempt to reset the state unit after months of factionalism. But the problems in the Punjab Congress are far from over. As the new team tried to settle into the Congress headquarters in Chandigarh, there were squabbles over rooms. This is a reminder of the larger challenge confronting the party: managing egos in an organisation that is attempting to project unity.



The Chosen Leader

Elephant Abhimanyu adorns the traditional Mysuru Peta and flower garland after being brought to Mysuru and appointed as the lead elephant for the Mysuru Dasara elephant squad, on Monday

BL VERMA, ARUN SINGH, BRIJ LAL AND NEERAJ SHEKHAR DENIED ANOTHER TERM

BJP Leaves Out Hardeep Puri in UP Rajya Sabha Line-up of 8 New Faces

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: BJP declared its list of eight candidates for the Rajya Sabha biennial elections from Uttar Pradesh on Monday, factoring in caste votes and choosing only leaders from the state keeping the forthcoming Uttar Pradesh Assembly in mind. Union Ministers Hardeep Singh Puri and BL Verma — as well as former party general secretary Arun Singh, Brij Lal and Neeraj Shekhar — have been denied another term, leading to a fresh buzz that a cabinet reshuffle may be in the offing.

BJP has given primacy to Dalit and backward caste leaders in its list of candidates from Uttar Pradesh where it is courting this segment aggressively ahead of the UP polls due in March-April. Dharampal Singh, Animal Husbandry minister in the Yogi Adityanath government and belonging to the Lodh backward caste, has been given the ticket. He is a three-term MLA from Aaonla seat. Former union minister and Jharkhand governor Santosh Gangwar's daughter Shruti is also a candidate. She hails from the Kurmi community, which has been wooed aggressively by the saffron party in the past few elections.

Two Dalit leaders, Vidyasagar Sonkar and Priyanka Singh Rawat, have also been fielded.



ded. Rawat had defeated PL Punia (Congress) in the 2014 Lok Sabha elections from the Barabanki (Scheduled Caste) seat. However, she was denied a ticket in the 2019 and 2024 general elections. Prakash Pal, hailing from the Gaderia most backward caste, has given a ticket.

The list also includes two Brahmin candidates—Radhakant Ojha and Gopi Krishna Pandey. Ojha is a former head of the Allahabad High Court Bar Association. Ram Pratap Singh Chauhan, a BJP leader from Agra who had served as Ethmadpur seat MLA from 2017 to 2022, is the lone Rajput in the list. At present he was serving as BJP general secretary in the UP unit.

These leaders come from castes which have largely stayed loyal to the BJP and have played a key role in its rise in UP since the 2014 general elections.

BJP has not fielded any candidate from outside the state this time and not repeated any of its outgoing members from the Upper House. Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, who is completing two consecutive terms in the Rajya Sabha, has not been given a ticket this time.

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SCAN TO REGISTER

On the Right Path of Easing Ease of Biz

Include energy, housing in GST's ambit

Reforming GST administration, as Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday, is a necessary follow-up to last year's rate rationalisation. That the GST Council will take up a series of measures to ease compliance and reduce disputes when it meets on Thursday, while welcome, indicates imperfections arising from design compromises. These tackle legacy issues from the complex GST structure that existed prior to 2025. But India is headed in the right direction, with fewer GST rates freeing up the bandwidth needed to administer the tax. This incremental reform is a significant achievement, but skirts key structural issues with the improved GST version we have today.

GST's main attraction is that it reduces cascading of taxes that drive up prices. Yet, energy remains outside GST's ambit, which tends to make India's economic growth more inflationary than necessary. Again, India's energy intensity of growth is rising, and this perpetuates trade distortion. India's transition to an export-driven high-growth low-inflation economy requires a hard look at why energy remains outside GST. The property market draws a significant share of India's household savings, and GST as it applies now tends to introduce distortions. There is scope to integrate housing transparently into the input tax credit chain. The effects of a streamlined GST administration in the property market will be felt across the economy due to extensive linkages.

It's not just about how efficient GST is. Policymakers need to look at why states are losing agency in raising their tax revenue. The GST revenue-sharing formula must accommodate the structural decline in states to strengthen fiscal autonomy. There is also a case for directing a part of the GST collection to municipal bodies to push sustainable urbanisation that generates more economic growth. Alongside creeping reforms, the council would do well to apply itself to some of the core restructuring GST needs to keep delivering economic efficiency. Throw in a big-ticket item occasionally.

Next UNSG's Top Task, UNmaking Irrelevance

Three months are left before secretary general António Guterres hands over the keys of the UN to his successor. There are 7 candidates in the fray. To get the job, one must garner support of 9 of the 15 UNSC members, including a yes-vote from all 5 permanent members. There's talk of dark horses, and of an understanding between Xi and Trump on who takes over from Guterres. But whoever comes in will have the daunting task of steering the 81-yr-old organisation through escalating geopolitical tensions and fragmentation, complex global challenges like AI proliferation, climate change, debt, increased defence spending, unresolved developmental challenges, as well as funding shortfalls. And, above all, to make UN relevant.

Seen largely as a bully pulpit for rival or antagonistic nations or blocs to snipe at each other 'politely', UN as Virtue Signalling Central is apparent even to its staunchest supporters. It is now all gums, no teeth. Which is why the next UNSG needs to be equal-parts diplomat, advocate, civil servant and CEO. Making the UN relevant again will require leveraging the changed world through its still-unmatched reach and convening power. That means looking beyond the conventional to make the UN fit for purpose. Reforms will be tough in the current geopolitical climate. But that should, paradoxically, make its role of trust-builder clearer and more pragmatic.

India must be an active player in this effort. Even as it keeps up the pressure for UN reforms, it must engage in making possible the small yet *real* changes that will make the UN not a 'mock United Nations'. New Delhi must not just articulate a 'global south' PoV, but also work across aisles to develop approaches that reflect and negotiate the world as it is.



JUST IN JEST

Graying will be the next big thing for the young to be taken seriously

A New Groom Boom: #WhiteHairMatters

For ages, people, especially women, have openly expressed how concealing grey hair is something they are willing to dye for. Capitalism has helped colour this view, persuading people that white hair strongly suggests non-hair fallibility of some kind. But it may shortly discover there is more money — and power — in putting follicular ageing out there as high-street window-dressing. Because #WhiteHairMatters. Status largely depends on scarcity. When everybody in the boardroom is dyeing, wiggling or even balding — a satirical, AI-generated parody meme depicting bald tech leaders on a Time magazine cover with the headline, 'The Future is Bald', even went viral recently — the 57-yr-old person who looks 57 acquires instant distinction. Grey hair becomes not evidence of ageing but conspicuous confidence: proof that its owner can afford to look old.

For women, the signal is particularly potent. Men have long been permitted to become 'distinguished', while women merely became 'older'. Grey says: I'm not auditioning any more. A silver head implies its bearer has survived restructurings, recessions, difficult boards, and run-ins with powers-that-be. Which is why the next grooming boom may involve ambitious younger men and women actually artificially greying themselves. The truly ambitious will ask: how grey must I go to become a partner in this firm?

The regulator's proposal is tantamount to addressing the symptom, while ignoring the cause

Misselling Misunderstood



Ateesh Tankha & Ashish Dave

In FY25, the insurance sector collected ₹11.93 lakh cr in premium and issued 41.84 cr policies. Insurance penetration — premium as a share of GDP — stood at 3.7%, unchanged from the year before. Life insurance penetration slipped to 2.7% from 2.8%, while non-life penetration stayed flat at 1%. In FY26, however, ₹13.30 lakh cr of premiums were collected, reflecting growth of 12.5% in life insurance and 11% in non-life, respectively. Once again, life and non-life insurance penetration stayed flat.

So, the industry was selling more than ever, while failing to drive two key IRDAI objectives: reach, and access. Instead, the industry was more successful at selling to existing customers than it was at acquiring new customers or retaining clients of recent vintage. Something had to be done. But what?

According to RBI's June 2026 Financial Stability Report, the commission ratio of private life insurers doubled between FY22 and FY26, to 9.1% and rose sharply for private general insurers. This, by itself, was not an issue. The report, however, went on to state that instances of premature life insurance policy withdrawals and surrenders reached 38.3% of total payouts, while benefits stood at 36.9%.

Premature withdrawals indicate customer dissatisfaction arising from poor product fit, while surrenders pointed to deferred mis-sale. This evidence, coupled with a public rebuke from the FM to banks for misselling life insurance policies, the surrender of which

impacts reinvestment in government securities and infrastructure bonds, forced the regulator, IRDAI, to act.

Thus, on Sept 23, IRDAI's consultation paper: 'Recalibrating Economics of Insurance Distribution', proposed to reintroduce product-wise commission caps (something it had removed in 2023 to aid greater penetration) to reduce misselling. But this is tantamount to addressing the symptom, while ignoring the cause.

Unsurprisingly, the market's reaction was visceral. Share prices of PB Fintech and Turtlemint fell 36% and 20%, respectively, while insurance brokerage firms trimmed earnings estimates by 12%.

Of course, benefits of reduced misselling — a more affordable, transparent and customer-centric market — need no justification. IRDAI's action has taken cognisance of one specific industry malpractice to restrict future incidences: bundling of insurance products with loans by bank personnel, who need to meet liability-product income targets at any cost.

But the bancassurance channel — partnership between a bank and an insurance company — while significant, is not the only distribution line to be affected. And it's in the inflexible, one-size-fits-all nature of the remedy — in which smaller companies

may be disadvantaged and brokerages may see up to 1 mn jobs lost by 2030 — that the discussion paper falls short. Misselling, after all, is driven by a person paid to complete the sale, rather than make the right one. So, while the discussion paper aims its sights at remuneration tied to a coercive transaction, it's likely to target worst offenders, while leaving core mechanisms of this sharp practice intact for 3 reasons:

- The cap reduces the incentive but not the intent, by rewarding a lower volume of sales with a smaller incentive.
- Any IRDAI regulation to attack the cost of a problem, rather than the issue itself, is likely to migrate the object of misselling from one product to another — from a capped one to a less cap-



Don't take it out on apples

ped one, from unit margin to cumulative volume, even replacing commissions with fees to make up the earning deficit.

Any such action will only affect the direction of future policies, not salvage millions of policies already sold and surrendered that constitute a breach of trust as much as poor business practice.

When Australia faced a similar issue, it simultaneously introduced commission ceilings with clawbacks. If a policy was surrendered in the first 2 yrs, almost the entire commission had to be returned. By redirecting the incentive to reward renewal and penalising a one-time transaction, the seller was invested in making sure that a customer was sold an appropriate product.

A progressive commission cap, along with performance re-funds, is something the Indian regulator should consider along with the introduction of 3 other actions:

- **Name and shame** With teeth like those of RBI and Sebi, the insurance ombudsman should use its grievance portal, Bima Bharosa, to publicly list insurers and distributors that consistently mis-sell and reject claims, so customers can make informed decisions. Furthermore, being listed should carry a commercial penalty commensurate with the violation.
- **Training before selling** Misselling often occurs on account of incompetence, rather than malicious intent. Mandatory and rigorous annual training should be enforced to build accountability, traceability and long-term compliance.
- **Track the trail** Tracking continuous, data-driven supervision can provide early warning triggers and actionable insights to reduce misselling and lapse rates.

Ultimately, pushing a distribution commission reform as a panacea for misselling and under-penetration would defeat the purpose IRDAI has set itself.

A more nuanced approach, in which the market sets the terms of sale and scale of commission, while the regulator facilitates awareness and knowledge, and penalises malpractice and non-compliance, is more likely to promote universal insurance coverage



The market setting terms of sale and scale of commission, while the regulator penalising malpractice and non-compliance, is more likely to promote universal insurance coverage

Tankha is MD, eTTrans Solutions. Dave is co-founder & CEO, Embark Brokers



THE SPEAKING TREE

Knowing Nobody

SHIBANI BELWALKAR

In 'Tales of Kitagaki', the powerful Governor of Kyoto arrives to meet the Zen Master Gasan. He sends ahead his ornate calling card engraved with his grand political title. Gasan glances at it and flatly refuses entry. 'I have no business with such a fellow,' he shouts. Realising his mistake, Kitagaki takes the card, draws a sharp line straight through his title, and sends it back. Gasan smiles warmly and says, 'Ah, is that Kitagaki? Show him in. I would love to meet the man.' Kitagaki's crossed-out title holds up a mirror to our modern reality — a world deeply anchored in corporate designations, personal branding and an exhausting race for external validation.

We often spend lifetimes curating a 'Somebody'. The sum of our visible achievements. Underneath all the layers we build for our identity, who are we? Ancient Indian philosophical texts identified this as Svarupa, with connotations of reality's essential, unchangeable, intrinsic nature. Unalterable and pure. Existentialist thought echoes this. Dissolve the ego-identity — name, career, status, possessions — and what remains beneath the Somebody is a Nobody Svarupa, however; beyond the contrast of nobody and somebody is what is underneath all along, waiting, whether the Somebody was ever built or not. Even Odysseus, a king, had to become 'Nobody' to escape the Cyclops' cave. His ego couldn't bear the lightness of it, so he quickly succumbed and announced himself as a 'Somebody' once more.



A Happy Death

It was ten in the morning, and Patrice Mersault was walking steadily towards Zagreus' villa. By now the housekeeper had left for the market and the villa was deserted. It was a beautiful April morning, chilly and bright; the sky was radiant, but there was no warmth in the glistening sunshine. The empty road sloped up towards the villa, and a pure light streamed between the pines covering the hillside.

Patrice Mersault was carrying a suitcase, and as he walked on through that primal morning, the only sounds he heard were the click of his own footsteps on the cold road and the regular creak of the suitcase handle.

Not far from the villa, the road crossed a little square decorated with flower beds and benches. The effect of the early red geraniums among grey aloes, the blue sky and the white-washed walls was so fresh, so childlike that Mersault stopped a moment before walking on through the square. Then the road sloped down again towards Zagreus' villa. On the doorstep he paused and put on his gloves.

Translated from French by Richard Howard

Chat Room

Multiculti Policy Flavour, Please

Apropos 'Ok, It's Time to Raise Rates' by Mythili Bhushnam (Oct 5), (1) as on many occasions and at present, our monetary policy is influenced more by external (uncontrollable) factors than internal (controllable) factors. So, the flexible inflation targeting framework alone isn't fit and proper. India is a large, growing macroeconomy, but it is saddled with numerous microeconomic and sociopolitical rigidities. The country needs a multi-target approach instead of transplantation of policies from developed economies. (2) The monetary policy needs to be suitably communicated not only to the financial sector players but also to the common man who provides business opportunities to the former by availing their products and services. There's a lot the monetary policy authors can learn from the budget language. (3) When the monetary policy per se is constrained to do much (like now), it should focus on the Developmental and Regulatory Policies, i.e., Part II of the Policy; in a forward-looking manner. Manas R Das Pune

Bengal, Count Plants, Not Promises



Diva Jain

Last week, West Bengal finance minister Swapan Dasgupta stated that the Urban Land (Ceiling and Regulation) Act 1976 has to go. That reform would be instrumental, he said, in unlocking land for development and attracting fresh investments. This, and other measures, are on the anvil for the 5-mth-old BJP government's plans to put the state on an industrial path.

Bengal's industrial history is unusual, not because it started late but because it started so early and lost so much. Five decades of Left and Trinamool politics squandered the inheritance of one of India's earliest cotton mills near Calcutta, car-making by Hindustan Motors at Uttarpara, locomotive-making at Chittaranjan, steel at Durgapur...

The new government's industrial policy, due before Durga Puja next week, promises land pooling and direct purchase, a ₹5,000 cr investment framework with incentives linked to employment, and faster clearance for projects above ₹100 cr. Investors read a state's promises off its balance sheet. Fiscal and legal capacity are complements. States that build one tend to build the

other. The first tells an investor whether a state can pay, the second whether its commitments can be enforced. Bengal offers evidence of weaknesses in both.

In 2025, the previous government legislated away 10 industrial incentive schemes dating back to 1993. NITI Aayog's 2026 Fiscal Health Index gives Bengal a score of 23.8, ranking it 16th out of 18 major states. The 16th Finance Commission has also cut its share in the divisible pool from 7.52% to 7.22%.

Where states begin with unequal endowments, stronger states can compete harder, while weaker ones have less incentive to do so. The question is not whether Bengal can announce incentives. It's whether it can credibly commit to paying them.

Odisha began this century in a deeper fiscal hole. Today, it tops the same index with a score of 73.1. In 2001-02, Odisha ran a revenue deficit of 5.48% of GDP; a fiscal deficit of 7.68%, and debt of 46.48%. Its response included a white paper, a recruitment freeze and abolition of vacant government posts, tighter limits on guarantees to state enterprises, and a defined-contribution pension system for new employees.

In 2005, the state enacted its FRBM law, putting deficit and debt reduction into statute. The first revenue surplus, ₹481 cr, followed in 2005-06 after 22 yrs



Will industry follow?

of deficits. Administrative reform ran alongside fiscal repair.

A 2004 law gave the single window statutory backing. Large projects went to a clearance authority chaired by the CM. Industrial land was assembled and mapped online. Approvals and government services later moved onto a single portal. For 2026-27, Odisha budget a revenue surplus of 3% of GDP, liabilities of 14.1%, and interest payments of 3.3% of revenue receipts. Bengal budgets a revenue deficit of 1%, liabilities of 38%, and an interest bill of roughly 17% of revenue receipts.

Odisha offers Bengal an important lesson, but not a template. The lesson is state and administrative capacity, not industrial composition. In 2022-23, manufacturing accounted for 18.8% of Bengal's employment. Its geography provides ports in the south and Siliguri in the north as a gateway to the north-east and neighbouring markets. It also favours logistics and distribution.

Chief minister Suvedu Adhikari is right to link incentives to employ-

ment, rather than investment alone. There is need for administrative discipline. A state must be able not only to grant support, but to monitor it, enforce its conditions and withdraw it when it fails. For Bengal, that comes down to 4 tests:

- **Land that is ready** Publish how much industrial land is actually available, where it is, and when it will be serviced. Acreage is not enough. Investors need clear title, usable plots, road access, power and water.
- **Approvals that bind** The new mechanism for projects above ₹100 cr must do more than route applications through same departments. Give it decisions that stick and deadlines with consequences. The 2025 revocation makes continuity a test in itself. Investors need certainty that benefits will survive a future change in policy.
- **Incentives that can be paid** The new budget provides for ₹1 lakh posts and raises dearness allowance to 38%. Investors need to know what the incentives will cost, and where the money will come from. Publish the liabilities, budget for them and disclose when they fall due.
- **Results that can be counted** Odisha tracks projects through approval, grounding and commissioning. Bengal should publish the same ledger every quarter.

Deliver the land, make approvals stick, and pay what is due. Then, count the factories, not the promises.

The writer is director, Arrjavu

Give States a Reason to Cheer



Najib Shah

GST Council is a forum where Centre-state partnership is seen in full force. In the spirit of federalism, there is one issue that the council should decide on when it meets on Thursday: industrial alcohol.

Industrial alcohol and potable (drinkable) liquor are both made from rectified spirit, a concentrated spirit containing up to 95% alcohol. Rectified spirit is further processed, and its alcohol strength reduced — to up to 42.5% in the case of whisky and lower depending on the beverage — to make it drinkable. When rectified spirit undergoes 'denaturation' — making it unfit for human consumption — it becomes industrial alcohol, a critical input for the pharma, chemical and cosmetic industries.

Gol and states have long contested who has legislative competence over industrial alcohol, with confusion arising from overlapping jurisdic-

tions under various lists of the Seventh Schedule.

- Entry 52 of the Union List empowers Gol to regulate industries that Parliament declares to be of 'public interest'. Through Section 18-G of Industries (Development and Regulation) Act 1951, Parliament has vested the Union with the power to regulate specified products related to scheduled industries, primarily to ensure that such goods are sold at reasonable prices.
- Entry 8 of the state list empowers a state to make laws relating to intoxicating liquors. Production, manu-



If you are mixing drinks, share it

facture, possession, transport, purchase and sale of intoxicating liquors fall within the ambit of the states.

► Entry 33 of the concurrent list, however, gives both the state and Gol the power to make laws on the products of any industry, even where Parliament has declared that the Union should assume control in the public interest.

This overlap has created confusion, with both Gol and states believing they have the power to regulate industrial alcohol. Litigation on the matter dates to 1956, when a 5-judge Constitution Bench of Supreme Court held that Parliament's intent behind Section 18-G did not bar a state from exercising its powers to legislate on matters under Entry 33 of the concurrent list. That case, however, related to sugarcane. The matter travelled back and forth between the top court, Allahabad High Court and the UP government before reaching a 9-member Constitution Bench in 2024. The court upheld states' power to regulate industrial alcohol by a 9-8 majority. It held that 'intoxicating liquor', over which states have competence under Entry 8 of List 2 of the 7th Schedule, includes industrial alcohol.

In effect, this could have opened another source of revenue for states. Yet, despite the apex court's order, indus-

trial alcohol continues to be under GST. It's classified under HSN Code 2207 and attracts 18% GST. How, then, should the matter be resolved going forward?

- States should not rush to levy excise. The council must take cognisance of the top court's order and recommend that states be free to levy excise under their laws. Gol should ensure that this decision is implemented immediately.
- States should also take cognisance of the fact that the 18% GST levy was imposed with input tax credit (ITC). It is unlikely that they can put in place a mechanism to provide credit for taxes paid on inputs, all of which will remain within the GST regime. States should, therefore, fix an excise rate that broadly mimics the effective GST burden after ITC is availed.
- States have lost what is their legitimate revenue was from Oct 23, 2024, the date of the Supreme Court order. Gol could consider proportionately distributing revenue collected from industrial alcohol to the manufacturing states concerned. That would be a magnanimous step, one that would strengthen Centre-state fiscal relations and build trust.

The writer is former chairman, Central Board of Indirect Taxes & Customs

Fall in US yields lifts mood; Analysts say good results, festive demand can offer support

Indices End Losing Run on Easing Crude Prices, Positive Global Cues

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equity benchmarks ended higher in Monday's seesaw trading session, snapping their four-day losing run, as easing crude prices and positive global cues supported sentiment despite continued geopolitical concerns and foreign fund outflows. The Sensex gained 472.77 points, or 0.66%, to close at 72,382.47, while the Nifty 50 advanced 133.80 points, or 0.6%, to settle at 22,555.75. Both indices had risen as much as nearly 1% earlier in the day, before slipping into the red mid-way through the session.

Positive global cues supported the market, with the US 10-year treasury yield easing towards 5.21%. Brent crude also moderated to around \$101-102 a barrel, providing some relief to investors amid concerns over elevated oil prices.

Analysts said October has started on a cautious note as the US-Iran conflict worsens. The central bank is also expected to raise rates at its latest monetary policy review Wednesday. "The silver lining around all these gathering dark clouds is the September quarter results that will kick off from next week onwards," said Dinshaw Irani, MD & CEO, Helios India.

Like the June quarter, Irani expects the September quarter results to deliver a positive surprise. "Given that the Indian markets trade close to their long-term average valuations, the positive results should provide a fair bit of support. The upcoming festive season, too, should provide clues as to the strength of domestic demand," he said.

Softer crude prices and reduced expectations of aggressive US rate hikes following weaker US jobs data have also improved global risk sentiment. From here, the sustainability of the rebound will depend on whether fresh buying replaces short covering and bargain hunting, according to Gaurav Garg, head - research, Lemonn.

Broader markets also ended higher, with the Nifty Midcap 150 index rising 0.5% and the Nifty Smallcap

BSE Sensex

76133

72382

Sept 7, 2026

Oct 5, 2026

Nifty 50

23779

22556

Sept 7, 2026

Oct 5, 2026

250 index gaining 0.3%.

On the BSE, of the 4,760 traded shares, 2,052 advanced, 2,448 declined and 260 remained unchanged. Among Nifty constituents, BSE and ITC emerged as the top gainers, while HCL Tech and Max Healthcare were the major laggards. At the sectoral level, Nifty Pharma and Healthcare remained under pressure, while FMCG witnessed renewed buying along with media.

Foreign portfolio investors were net sellers of equities worth ₹4,699 crore on Monday, while domestic institutional investors were net buyers to the tune of ₹5,181 crore.

On the technical front, the 22,400-22,380 zone could act as immediate support. A breach below this zone could revive selling pressure towards 22,220, which coincides with the October 11 low, according to Sudeep Shah, VP - technical and derivatives research at SBI Securities. "On the upside, 22,700-22,720 could act as an immediate hurdle. A sustained move above this could trigger a relief rally towards 22,850. The broader structure remains weak until sustained buying emerges," he said.

INDEX REJIG: \$824-MILLION INFLOWS LIKELY

Divi's Labs, TVS Motor Contenders for Nifty Inclusion in March

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Divi's Laboratories and TVS Motor Company could be contenders for inclusion in the Nifty in the NSE's March 2027 index review. These stocks could potentially replace Max Healthcare Institute and HDFC Life, according to independent research firm Quiddity Leaderboard. The changes could trigger inflows of around \$824 million, it said. The review is still at an early stage, leaving room for rankings to change, said Jeyakumar Janaghan, analyst at Quiddity Leaderboard on its website.

"The six-month reference period for the Nifty March 2027 index review is from August 1, 2026 to January 31, 2027. Only 34% of this reference period has been completed, which means there is room for the rankings to change," he said. Max Healthcare's potential deletion from the Nifty 100 would automatically result in its removal from the Nifty 50, making Divi's Labs the top potential replacement, said Quiddity.

TVS Motor could replace HDFC Life. TVS Motor's average free-float market capitalisation (AFMC) is more than 1.5 times that of HDFC Life, the smallest remaining Nifty 50 constituent after Max Healthcare's potential deletion. "Consequently, we expect another change for the Nifty 50 in March 2027, bringing the total to two," Jeyakumar said.

Quiddity expects five changes in the Nifty 100, the maximum permitted per review. LIC, ICICI Prudential Asset Management, BHEL, Lenskart and Groww are potential additions, while Vedanta, Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders, Godrej Consumer, Ambuja Cements and Max Healthcare are potential deletions.

Max Health's potential deletion from the Nifty 100 would also remove it from the Nifty 50

Re Ends Flat Near 96.3 Before RBI's Rate Call

KOLKATA: The rupee ended marginally stronger at 96.2925 a dollar against the previous close of 96.3150. The currency opened 10 paise up at 96.2150 a dollar, supported by the overnight drop in Brent crude prices that lifted investor sentiment. It depreciated half a percent last week. It traded in a narrow 10 paise band throughout the day as traders are waiting for fresh direction from the Reserve Bank of India, which will announce the monetary policy Wednesday. RBI's rate-setting committee is widely expected to tighten the policy rate by 25 basis points to 5.5% from 5.25%. - Our Bureau

PARIS ON THE BONDS OF A DILEMMA

Is France the Next Greece, Threatening the Eurozone?

ET EXPLAINER

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: The pecking order in financial markets has changed in the past few weeks, at least temporarily. Boring bonds are in the limelight instead of stocks. While many nations, from the US to Japan, are in focus, France is in the eye of the bond market storm.

WHAT HAPPENED TO FRENCH BONDS? Yields on the French government bonds, known as OAT, topped the 5% mark as investors sold off on worries that the country would not be able to control its public debt. The gap between yields on OAT and German bonds, known as bunds, have widened to record highs and it is paying more than Greece and Italy, which were at the centre of a financial crisis about 15 years ago.

WHY THIS SUDDEN FEAR ABOUT FRANCE? While many countries are facing huge debt problems, the French case is a lot more complicated. The country faces an election next year. And two potential rulers - whoever emerges victorious - have little to comfort investors with their fiscal plans. Neither the right-wing Le Pen nor the left-wing Jean-Luc Melancon would provide concrete roadmaps to reduce spending or shore up revenues.

WHAT TRIGGERED THE SELL-OFF? Until recently, most European nations' bonds were trading in lock-step with one another. But Japanese investors suddenly took a bearish stance on France and sold off. Japanese own nearly 6.6%, or \$145 billion, of their overseas assets in French bonds. After a surge in yields in Japanese Government Bonds in the past few months, it is more remunerative to own home country paper than French, which

deficit target at 5% is higher than the European Union target of 3%.

IS THERE A PRECEDENT IN THE EUROPEAN UNION? Yes. About 15 years ago, the Euro area was swept by a financial crisis with Portugal, Italy, Ireland, Greece, and Spain on the verge of default and getting cut off, drawing the moniker PIIGS. But the European Central Bank chief Mario Draghi saved the currency with a promise to do 'whatever it takes' to protect the Euro.

IF FRANCE TURNS SHAKIER, CAN THE ECB SAVE IT? In an extreme case, the central bank has the ammunition. But it is not Greece as yet. The ECB has a 2022 programme called Transmission Protection Instrument where it could buy unlimited bonds to prevent chaos in the market. But since it is a French problem, it may not receive a helping hand. But if it becomes a contagion with other indebted nations such as Belgium and Italy getting sucked in, the ECB may bail the region out.

HOW DOES FRANCE COMPARE WITH PEERS? The difference in the 10-year yields of France and those of Europe's largest economy Germany has surged 150 basis points, almost three times the 50-basis point difference reported as recently as September. German bunds, considered the best in European debt, are currently trading around 3.45%. This has reignited memories when Greek bonds yield surged to 44%.

SO, WHAT ARE THE SIGNALS FROM THE BOND MARKET? The US, the UK, Japan etc are witnessing spikes in bond yields not seen since 2002. Thanks to unprecedented government debt since the Global Financial Crisis of 2008, investors are going on strike. The US benchmark is trading above 5%. Surging bond sales by AI investors such as Meta, Softbank, Oracle are adding fuel to the bond fire.

France's 10-Yr OAT yield climbed to its highest level since July 2002

4.84

3.57

Oct 6, 2025

Oct 5, 2026

gets expensive due to hedging costs.

Oil, Gas Sector Set to Get Central R&D Hub for Aligning State Cos with National Goals

Project allocation, funding proposed via oil min's Centre for High Technology

Sanjeev Choudhary

New Delhi: The oil ministry has proposed a centralised mechanism to steer oil and gas research and development, including project allocation, funding, commercialisation and performance monitoring, as it seeks to align state-run companies and other institutions with common national priorities.

The government is seeking inputs from state oil and gas companies on its proposal to mandate the oil ministry's Centre for High Technology to serve as the Central R&D Coordination Mechanism

Unified Control

State firms retain ownership of their R&D projects

Duplication across projects to be identified and reduced

FOCUS AREAS: indigenous tech, future energy, commercialisation

Ecosystem to include PSUs, private firms, startups and academia

National centres to work on AI CBG CCUS

Startups could focus on energy analytics

(CRCM), according to people who have reviewed the draft proposal.

"Going forward, all new R&D projects proposed under the petroleum ministry R&D ecosystem will be submitted to the CRCM and assessed through the standardised project allocation framework for allocation to the entity, or combination of entities, best positioned to execute them," the draft proposed.

"Private industry participants may also bring forward problem statements/R&D requirements, which can be assessed and directed to the appropriate ecosystem participant(s)."

State firms will "continue to own and execute their respective R&D projects" while the CRCM will interface with them "through a layered governance architecture", according to the draft.

The CRCM is also expected to identify and reduce duplication across R&D projects. An industry executive said the draft suggests the proposed coordinating body would have significant powers over state companies' R&D programmes, potentially reducing their autonomy in the area.

"Setting national priorities in R&D is a laudable objective but reducing competition in the name of duplication and controlling every project or funding may not bring the desired result," he said.

At present, all state-owned oil companies have dedicated R&D departments headed by a director or executive director. Indian Oil's R&D chief has a seat on the company's board, although the position is currently vacant.

The oil ministry's proposed ecosystem aims to bring together R&D centres of state-owned companies, national centres of excellence, private companies, startups and academia.

Home Sales Firm in Top 7 Cities, Dip in NCR; More Traction at Top End

Mumbai remains largest residential market by volume, with 72,804 units of sales in January-September, up 1%

Kailash Babar

Mumbai: India's residential market is witnessing a widening divergence across cities and price segments, with demand holding steady across most major markets while the National Capital Region (NCR) sees a moderation and higher-ticket homes continue to gain share. The trend points to a market becoming more selective even as overall housing demand remains resilient.

Residential sales across eight key markets stood at 258,238 units during January-September, broadly in line with the year-ago period, according to Knight Frank India data. Developers launched 279,899 units during the period, a 4% increase, with launches exceeding sales for the 16th consecutive quarter.

"India's residential market is entering

changed from the year-ago period.

"The market is moving towards a more mature phase where project positioning, execution capability and the ability to offer differentiated products will increasingly influence buyer decisions.

Developers with strong balance sheets and established delivery track records are well placed to navigate this transition. We expect end-user confidence to remain intact, particularly in locations supported by employment growth, infrastructure creation and improving connectivity," said Shekhar Patel, national president of developers' body CREDAI.

Hyderabad, Ahmedabad, Chennai and Kolkata also recorded positive sales trends, with volumes rising 2-4% on-year. Kolkata recorded the highest growth at 4%, followed by Hyderabad, Ahmedabad and Chennai at 2% each.

NCR was the only market to record a decline in sales, with 35,574 homes sold during the nine months, down 11% on-year.

Residential sales across eight key markets held steady at 258,238 units in Jan-Sept, developers launched 279,899 units, a 4% increase

ET THE ECONOMIC TIMES

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SCAN TO REGISTER

₹42K CR LOST IN M-CAP
Policybazaar Parent Falls Further, to a 32-Mth Low

Our Bureau

Mumbai: PB Fintech, parent of online insurance distribution platform Policybazaar, extended its decline for a seventh straight session in Monday's trading, wiping out more than ₹42,000 crore in market capitalisation and pushing the stock to a nearly 32-month low.

The decline comes after the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdi) released a consultation paper on September 23 proposing caps on distributor commissions.

The stock closed at ₹980, a level last seen on February 16, 2024, down 0.3% from Thursday's close. Over the past seven sessions, PB Fintech's market capitalisation has fallen from around ₹87,290 crore to ₹45,174 crore. The stock has lost over 48% during the period.

The stock is now back at its IPO price of ₹980. PB Fintech made its stock market debut in November 2021.

Short Takes

German Green Steel Lists at 2% Premium

German Green Steel & Power shares listed at ₹142 on the NSE on Monday. The shares were listed at a 2.16% premium over the IPO issue price of ₹139 per share. The stock closed at ₹128.3.

Orient Cables Debuts at 65% above IPO Price

Shares of Orient Cables (India) were listed at ₹450 per share on the NSE on Monday. The shares were listed at a 65.44% premium over the IPO issue price of ₹272 per share. The stock closed at ₹405 on Monday.

Runwal Enterprises Makes Flat Debut

Runwal Enterprises shares were listed at ₹305 per share on the NSE on Monday, almost flat with the IPO issue price of ₹305 per share. The stock closed at ₹301.45 on Monday.

Acevector Shares List at 19% Discount

Acevector shares were listed at ₹25.81 per share on the NSE, at a 19.34% discount to the IPO issue price of ₹32 per share. The stock closed at ₹26.08. —Our Bureau

STRONG DEMAND Move follows multiple requests from companies for cheaper, long-term funding
NHB Likely to Double Affordable Hsg Outlay for HFCs this Fiscal

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: National Housing Bank is likely to double the total refinancing and affordable housing funds available to large housing finance companies this fiscal, following multiple requests from companies for cheaper, long-term funding, officials familiar with the discussions said.

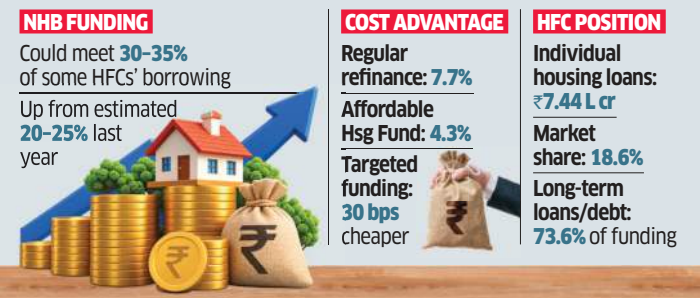
LIC Housing Finance, Bajaj Housing Finance, PNB Housing Finance, Aadhar Housing Finance and TruHome Finance are among the companies that could benefit, they said.

HFCs had earlier approached NHB and the finance ministry, seeking more funding as they look to diversify their borrowing and reduce their reliance on banks.

Raising fresh bank loans can become difficult when a bank reaches its internal exposure limit for lending to NBFCs and HFCs, the officials explained.

"Banks have limits on their exposure to HFCs, so raising fresh funds can become difficult even when demand for home loans is strong," said

More Room to Lend and Grow



id a senior official with a mortgage lender. "We have been asking NHB for a larger allocation because its refinancing is cheaper and would give us room to grow without relying so heavily on bank borrowing."

Officials put the rate on regular NHB refinancing at about 7.65% and on affordable housing funds at about 4.25%. Both are cheaper than comparable bank funding.

NHB could meet 30-35% of the borrowing raised by some HFCs this year, compared with 20-25%

last year, one official estimated. The state-owned development financial institution (DFI) had disbursed ₹32,308 crore in refinancing in the one-year period ended June 2025, compared with ₹32,085 crore in the preceding year. Affordable housing fund disbursements, which are included in the overall figure, stood at ₹5,791 crore.

Banks, however, remain HFCs' largest source of funds, with their share rising while those of mutual funds and insurers fell.

LIQUIDITY SURGE Ample FCNR(B) inflows lower banks' reliance on costlier wholesale funding
CD Pool Shrinks by ₹1.3 Lcr in a Month

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: Indian banks have run down more than ₹1.3 lakh crore of certificates of deposit (CDs) in just a month, shrinking outstanding short-term market borrowings by 19% as liquidity created by the Reserve Bank of India's special foreign currency non-resident (bank) deposit window reduced their need for relatively expensive wholesale funding.

Outstanding CDs fell to ₹5.60 lakh crore as of September 15 from about ₹6.90 lakh crore in mid-August, a decline of ₹1.306 lakh crore, according to RBI data. In the latest fortnight alone, outstanding CDs dropped by ₹76,400 crore, while year-to-year growth slowed sharply to 11.5% from 28.4% at the end of August.

The retreat from CDs follows a surge in banking-system liquidity after banks raised foreign currency deposits under the RBI's FCNR (B) swap window.

System liquidity peaked at around ₹11.2 lakh crore in early September, as banks exchanged dollars raised overseas with the RBI for rupees. The surplus reduced the need to tap short-term wholesale funding and allowed banks to let maturing CDs run off.

"With ample funds in hand, banks

HFCs had gross payables of ₹7.35 lakh crore to the financial system and gross receivables of ₹0.19 lakh crore in March 2026, according to the RBI's June Financial Stability Report.

HFCs held ₹7.44 lakh crore in outstanding individual housing loans at the end of July 2026, or 18.6% of the ₹40.07 lakh-crore home loan market reported by HFCs, public and private banks, and regional rural banks, NHB data showed. Their share was 18.3% a year earlier.

A larger NHB funding pool could help them expand their loan books while drawing less heavily on banks for new funds.

NHB provides refinancing against eligible housing loans originated by lenders, giving them access to longer-tenor funds. The institution carries a AAA credit rating and has worked with development finance agencies on affordable and green housing programmes.

Officials said targeted funding for segments such as green housing and homes in underserved regions can be around 30 basis points cheaper than regular NHB refinancing.

Tech Picks		AJIT MISHRA SVP, Research	Religare Broking
INDHOTEL			
Forming a fresh buying pivot while holding firmly above major moving averages. Accumulate.			
LAST CLOSE	₹725	STOP LOSS	₹700
PETRONET			
Witnessing rebound after forming a base around moving averages ribbon. Expect steady up move.			
LAST CLOSE	₹290	STOP LOSS	₹280
BPCL			
Inching gradually lower after the failed recovery attempt. Negative tone to continue.			
LAST CLOSE	₹296.95	STOP LOSS	₹306
DMART			
Sharp decline after marginal pullback. Indicates the prevailing corrective phase to extend.			
LAST CLOSE	₹3,567	STOP LOSS	₹3,680

ACCOUNT FOR NEARLY HALF OF LOANS BELOW ₹2 L

NBFCs Lend More to New Borrowers, but Delinquency Stable

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Non-banking finance companies (NBFC) accounted for nearly half of new-to-credit loans below ₹2 lakh by volume, even as their retail delinquency rate remained at 1.1%, below 1.3% for the aggregate industry, a report by TransUnion CIBIL and the Finance Industry Development Council showed.

About 82% of loans originated in India were below ₹2 lakh by number as of June 2026. NBFCs accounted for 47% of such originations, compared with 17% for banks and 36% for other lenders, the study showed.

Nearly 97% of loans originated in India were below ₹10 lakh by number, highlighting the importance of small-ticket credit in the retail lending market.

Borrowers who began monitoring their credit while holding subprime scores recorded better cure rates than comparable borrowers who did not monitor their credit, said Bhavesh Jain, managing director and chief executive of TransUnion CIBIL.

The cure rate measures the proportion of delinquent accounts that became current within 12 months. The overall cure rate for credit-monitoring borrowers was 52%, compared with 48% for non-monitoring borrowers.

About 48% of NBFC credit-acti-

ve customers monitored their credit profiles as of June 2026, up sharply from 3% in June 2018. Credit-active customers are those with at least one NBFC retail loan with an outstanding balance or reported limit.

Raman Aggarwal, chief executive of FIDC, attributed the improvement in asset quality to tighter underwriting, more current borrower information, increased credit awareness and greater repayment discipline.

"A good credit record determines their ability to obtain future loans," Aggarwal said. The number of credit-active NBFC customers grew nearly sevenfold between June 2016 and June 2026, while the

ir outstanding balances increased more than fivefold. Growth in the NBFC customer base was about 2.5 times faster than that of the overall credit industry, the report said. About 11 crore borrowers had active credit relationships with NBFCs as of June 2026. Nearly 36% of credit-eligible consumers had accessed credit through an NBFC at least once, while 46% of all credit-active consumers held an NBFC loan.

Avenue Falls 6.7% as Citi, Goldman Retain 'Sell'

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Shares of Avenue Supermarkets, the operator of DMart, fell 6.7% on Monday, marking their steepest single-day decline in nearly two years, as Citi and Goldman Sachs retained their sell ratings after the company's second-quarter business update amid concerns over rising quick-commerce competition and the stock's expensive valuation.

The stock closed at ₹3,555 after posting its sharpest one-day drop since October 14, 2024. Citi retained its target price of ₹3,300, while Goldman Sachs' target was ₹3,800.

Citi said it remained cautious on Avenue Supermarkets because of its expensive valuation, at 61 times estimated FY28 earnings, and risks to same-store growth and earnings from increasing competition in quick commerce.

"Sustained accelerated store expansion and improved throughput will be key to support valuation multiples," Citi said.

It is now down around 6% so far this year. The benchmark Sensex and Nifty have gained 0.6% each.

Avenue posted standalone revenue growth of 18.4% in the second quarter of FY27, accelerating from 15.1% in the first quarter. Avenue added 15 stores in the second quarter, taking additions in the H1 of FY27 to 18, compared with 17 in the year-earlier period.

Goldman Sachs said its 'sell' thesis is based on a mismatch between

avenue's growth prospects and valuation. It expects revenue growth to moderate to below 20% going forward, compared with around 30% earlier, as rising competition from quick-commerce platforms such as Blinkit and Swiggy, as well as larger retailers such as Reliance, weighs on same-store sales growth. "We expect the competitive intensity to continue to rise in large cities, and thus put pressure on Avenue's same-store sales growth," Goldman Sachs said in its latest report.

HFCL Wired for Growth with a Surging Order Book

Co doubles revenue growth guidance to 40%, raises Ebitda margin target to 23% on strong telecom, defence demand

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: The stock of HFCL has jumped three times over the past six months, beating the weakness in the broader market. The company, which manufactures optical fibre cables and defence electronics, has significantly raised the FY27 revenue growth guidance to 40% from earlier 20% and Ebitda margin estimate to 23% from 20% given a strong order book in the telecom segment and increasing traction in the defence and aerospace orders. It has benefitted from the buoyancy in the global capital expenditure (capex) towards artificial intelligence (AI) related technologies.

The proportion of its overseas revenue increased sharply to 40% in FY26 from around 12% in the previous year. The company expects to earn over 60% revenue from international markets by the end of the current fiscal year.

Given the expectation of a multi-fold rise in revenue and profits over the next five years, the stock has undergone a valuation rerating with the current trailing P/E at 64 compared with a five-year average of 39. However, weak market sentiments and rising geopolitical uncertainties may affect its short-term performance on bourses.

Driving up the company's share price and valuation multiple is the bulging order book, which doubled

Strong Momentum

Quarterly performance of HFCL (₹ cr)

	Jun'26	Mar'26	QoQ Change (%)
Revenue from Operations	1,915.0	1,824.1	5.0
Total Income	1,946.1	1,846.4	5.4
EBITDA	445.3	336.9	32.2
EBITDA Margin (%)	23.3	18.5	480 bps
Net Profit	245.6	184.5	33.1

EBITDA: Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation
bps: Basis points (100 bps = One Percentage point)
Source: Company data, ETIC

to ₹21,206 crore at the end of FY26 from just under ₹10,000 crore a year ago. It further grew to a record ₹26,665 crore at the end of June 2026, nearly five times its FY26 revenue of ₹4,949.3 crore. This strengthens the

long-term revenue visibility. Rising demand from the global AI ecosystem, diversified product portfolio, and expanding export markets have been key growth drivers for the company. To meet the

Market Intelligence

Powered By: ETIG Database

www.etintelligence.com

MARKET SNAPSHOT

SENSEX

NIFTY

Open

72340.95

22532.40

High

72631.93

26261.80

Low

71840.18

23997.10

Change

72382.47

25555.75

Change(Abs)

472.77

133.80

52-Wk High

(Dec 1186)159.02

(Jan 52)26373.20

52-Wk Low

(Oct 17)1292.88

(Apr 22)18225.85

3-Yr High

(Dec 1,25)86159.02

(Jan 5,26)26373.20

3-Yr Low

(Oct 26,23)63092.98

(Oct 26,23)18878.85

TURNOVER

BSE

NSE

Date

Turn

Shares

Trades

Turn

Shares

Trades

1/10

12097

6962

50.92

30/9

11735

6245

44.39

29/9

10576

6294

44.54

28/9

9383

6758

44.58

100535

50358

40.59

ADVANCE & DECLINE

BSE

(Number of traded scrips)

NSE

'A'

'B'

Others

Total

Advances

353

789

937

2079

1571

Declines

345

980

1123

2448

1790

Unchanged

4

52

173

429

62

Total

702

1821

2233

4756

3423

HIGHS & LOWS

BSE

(Number of scrips)

NSE

'A'

'B'

Others

Total

52WK High

5

48

90

143

95

52WK Low

34

83

93

210

155

All High

5

36

50

91

69

All Low

4

28

29

61

73

FII ACTIVITY (₹ Cr.)

DATE

BUY

SELL

NET

1/10

13106

22429

-9282

488

2/10

10087

8908

1187

23724

25486

-1762

3/10

13501

13208

293

25812

28185

-2374

4/10

10649

7632

301

21974

26470

-2697

5/10

11759

8046

3713

23828

25390

-2542

25/9

12686

12650

-3564

10

218

-208

Total Oct

11438

22429

-9282

488

54

Total Sep

308380

335421

-27039

127919

121575

3414

MF ACTIVITY (₹ Cr.)

DATE

BUY

SELL

NET

1/10

22500

19780

2720

2802

2/10

22500

19780

2720

2802

3/10

22500

19780

2720

2802

4/10

22500

19780

2720

2802

25/9

22500

19780

2720

2802

Total Sep

166895

13976

127619

36785

42521

Total Oct

2626475

222869

369616

308376

36785

390577

F&O Corner-NSE

Positive Trend

Company

Spot Price

Future Price

% Diff

% OI

Banknifty

168.27

169.83

0.93

-2.03

Blue Star

151000

1478.70

-2.07

-0.53

PB Fintech

976.20

985.30

0.93

5.44

KFIN Tech

867.50

854.40

-1.51

30.60

Prestige E

1445.00

1456.80

0.80

2.80

Indian Ren E

10900

10773.17

-1.17

0.19

Vodafone I

1124.00

1284.00

1.48

0.48

Tech Mahindr

1535.00

1521.70

-0.82

16.95

Siemens

3316.00

3362.00

1.38

0.38

Keynes Tech

33940

33665.30

-0.87

0.71

HDFC AMC

2346.00

2363.20

0.73

-2.85

Adani Energy

1409.90

1398.10

-1.04

0.01

Duvs & L

9196.00

9281.50

0.71

1.35

ICICI Lom G

16000

1587.20

-0.80

-1.01

KPIIT Technol

489.50

492.95

0.70

-1.43

Negative Trend

Company

Spot Price

Future Price

% Diff

% OI

Blue Star

151000

1478.70

-2.07

-0.53

KFIN Tech

867.50

854.40

-1.51

30.60

Indian Ren E

10900

10773.17

-1.17

0.19

Tech Mahindr

1535.00

1521.70

-0.82

16.95

Keynes Tech

33940

33665.30

-0.87

0.71

HDFC Bank

700.00

670.00

-4.29

0.88

Adani Energy

1409.90

1398.10

-1.04

0.01

ICICI Lom G

16000

1587.20

-0.80

-1.01

52 WEEK AT NSE

ALL TIME AT NSE

TURNOVER CASH MARKET

BSE

NSE

(₹ Crore)

200000

27400

26900

ET INDICES

MINDEX

ET-100

27400

26300

26200

25700

25600

25000

24500

Positive Breakouts

Company (BSE)

Days

20 Days

50 Days

90 Days

180 Days

360 Days

720 Days

1440 Days

2880 Days

5760 Days

11520 Days

23040 Days

46080 Days

92160 Days

184320 Days

368640 Days

737280 Days

1474560 Days

2949120 Days

5898240 Days

11796480 Days

23592960 Days

47185920 Days

94371840 Days

188743680 Days

377487360 Days

754974720 Days

1509949440 Days

3019898880 Days

6039797760 Days

12079595520 Days

24159191040 Days

48318382080 Days

96636764160 Days

193273528320 Days

386547056640 Days

773094113280 Days

1546188226560 Days

3092376453120 Days

6184752906240 Days

12369505812480 Days

24739011624960 Days

49478023249920 Days

98956046499840 Days

197912092999680 Days

395824185999360 Days

791648371998720 Days

1583296743997440 Days

3166593487994880 Days

6333186975989760 Days

12666373951979520 Days

25332747903959040 Days

50665495807918080 Days

101330991615836160 Days

202661983231672320 Days

405323966463344640 Days

810647932926689280 Days

1621295865853378560 Days

3242591731706757120 Days

6485183463413514240 Days

12970366926827028480 Days

25940733853654056960 Days

51881467707308113920 Days

103762935414616227840 Days

207525870829232455680 Days

415051741658464911360 Days

830103483316929822720 Days

1660206966633859645440 Days

3320413933267719290880 Days

6640827866535438581760 Days

13281655733070877163520 Days

26563311466141754327040 Days

53126622932283508654080 Days

106253245864567017308160 Days

212506491729134034616320 Days

425012983458268069232640 Days

850025966916536138465280 Days

1700051933833072276930560 Days

3400103867666152553861120 Days

6800207735332305107722240 Days

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54401661882658440861777920 Days

108803323765316881735555840 Days

217606647530633763471111680 Days

435213295061267526942223360 Days

870426590122535053884446720 Days

1740853080245070107768893440 Days

3481706160490140215537786880 Days

6963412320980280431075573760 Days

13926824641960560862151467200 Days

27853649283921121724303134400 Days

55707298567842243448606268800 Days

111414597137684486897213537600 Days

222829194275368973794427075200 Days

445658388550737947588854150400 Days

891316777101475975177708300800 Days

1782633554202951951355416601600 Days

3565267108405903902710833203200 Days

7130534216811807805421666406400 Days

14261068433623615610843332812800 Days

28522136867247231221686665625600 Days

57044273734484462443373331251200 Days

114088547468968848886746662502400 Days

228177094937937697773493325004800 Days

456354189875975395546986650009600 Days

912708379751950791093973300019200 Days

1825416795503901587187946600038400 Days

3650833591007803174375893200076800 Days

7301667182015606348751786400153600 Days

14603334364031212694513572800307200 Days

29206668728062425389027145600614400 Days

58413337456124850778174291201228800 Days

11682667411264970155634858242457600 Days

23365334822529940311269717114915200 Days

46730669645059880622539434229830400 Days

93461339290119761245078868459660800 Days

186922678580238482490157737319321600 Days

373845357160476964980315474638643200 Days

747690714320953929960630949277286400 Days

149538142864190785992126189855452800 Days

2990762857283815719842523797109107200 Days

5981525714567631438725047594218214400 Days

1196305142811266287745094518843628800 Days

2392610284222532575490189037687257600 Days

4785220568445065150980378075374515200 Days

9570441136890130301960756150749030400 Days

19140882773780260603921512301498060800 Days

38281765547560521207843024602996121600 Days

76563531095121042415686049205992243200 Days

153127062190242084831372198411984486400 Days

3062541243804841696627243968239689600 Days

6125082487609683393254487936479379200 Days

12250164975219366786508974872958758400 Days

24500329750438733573717959749177516800 Days

49000659500877467147435919498355533600 Days

98001319001754934287489838996711067200 Days

19600263800349868577977

TO REDUCE REPETITIVE SUBMISSIONS

Single-window GST Registration Set for Pilot

Multistate businesses can apply across states via one application

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The central government will pilot a single-window goods and services tax registration system for multistate businesses this week, allowing companies to apply for registration in several states through one common application.

The system is designed to eliminate the need for businesses to repeatedly submit the same details of the company, promoter and authorised signatory in each state for registration, easing one of the administrative burdens faced by companies with a pan-India presence. The facility will not be available for small taxpayers registered under the composition scheme.

The change comes as the government weighs a larger overhaul of the GST administration for businesses with multiple registrations under the same permanent account number (PAN). In July, ET reported that the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs had set up a working group to examine whether such taxpayers could be brought under a centralised administrative framework rather than dealing with multiple central tax jurisdictions.

The 11-member panel, headed by Lucknow Central GST Zone chief commissioner Vinayak Chandra Gupta, also examined the legal, administrative and technology

Registration Revamp

Option to be available on GST portal before meet

Scheme not applicable for taxpayers under composition scheme

Common information such as business details captured once.

Businesses will only have to add state-specific details

Ease administrative burdens for cos with a pan-India presence.

changes needed to implement such a framework. The committee also looked at earlier models, including the Large Taxpayer Unit framework and centralised registration under the previous indirect tax regime.

The committee has submitted its report, which is likely to be discussed at length at the GST Council meeting on Wednesday. “This (single-window registration) is on a pilot basis,” said a senior official. The existing registration process available for taxpayers and for both the centre and states will continue, the official told ET.

Further action will depend on the discussion and decision at the GST Council on whether the arrangement should be optional or mandatory, which taxpayers should be covered and how a single administering jurisdiction should be identified, the official said.

Bullion Imports by Nominated Agencies may Come Under GST

Our Bureau

Kolkata: Government agencies such as MMTC and State Trading Corporation of India may soon come under the goods and services tax (GST) regime for gold and precious metal imports, as authorities seek to bring different import channels on an even footing and reduce classification and valuation disputes that have led to prolonged litigation.

The matter is expected to come up at the October 8 GST Council meeting, with the broader proposal aimed at aligning the tax treatment of bullion imported through banks, nominated agencies and exchanges. At present, banks and certain nominated agencies have to pay 3% GST when they import precious metals.

The move could effectively end the preferential treatment extended to certain agencies since 2017, when gold, silver and platinum imports were tightly channelled through a few banks and nominated agencies. Since then, the bullion ex-

change route has developed, with duty and tax being paid through the new channel.

Renisha Chainani, chief research officer at Augmont, said removing the exemption would provide a level playing field across import channels. “The 2017 exemption made sense when only a few banks and nominated agencies brought bullion into India. Now that bullion exchanges offer another route, the exemption would follow the same rule,” she said.

The proposal also seeks to address the operational complications that would arise when classification codes change in the budget but corresponding tariff notifications are not aligned, industry executives said. Such gaps have resulted in disputes over whether a change applies to the goods or merely to their classification.

Bringing the routes onto the same tax footing could therefore reduce interpretational disputes while making bullion sourcing more transparent and efficient for jewellers.

Highway Engineers to Face Rating Cuts for Failures in Projects

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The ministry of road transport and highways has amended the rating criteria for author engineer (AE) and independent engineer (IE) consultancy firms, making them liable for catastrophic failures in road projects.

Under the revised criteria, 20 marks will be deducted from their rating for each catastrophic failure, according to a recent ministry notification. “The deduction shall be applied to the individual project score of the project on which the catastrophic failure has occurred,” it said.

Major structural collapses and severe serviceability losses in national highway projects are classified as catastrophic failures, leading to penalties for responsible concessionaires and enforcement of accountability. The individual project score after such a deduction will be taken into account, including a negative value, while computing the overall rating score. The same deduction will apply to all joint venture partners and associates, the ministry said. The government had earlier this year introduced a deduction of 30 marks for each catastrophic failure while rating concessionaires. However, there was no corresponding provision in the rating criteria for AE or IE firms. The government is of the view that AE and IE firms, as representatives of the authority on site, are responsible for design review, supervision, quality control and safety and should therefore be subject to penalties.

Gadkari Calls for Better Highway Planning and Safety Standards

NEW DELHI: Road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari called for greater focus on quality, safety, speed and world-class standards in the development of national highways, stressing the need for better planning and preparedness at the detailed project report (DPR) stage. This includes proper surveys, alignment planning, land acquisition, utility shifting and timely statutory clearances, Gadkari said while addressing a two-day Chintan Shivir in Gujarat. —Our Bureau

RATING CONCESSIONAIRES

Govt had earlier introduced a deduction of 30 marks for each catastrophic failure while rating concessionaires

MUMBAI PORT AUTHORITY

मुंबई पत्तन प्राधिकरण

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

RFP No. CET - 77/2026 | GLOBAL INVITATION | PPP - DBFOT

Mumbai Port Authority under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Govt. of India, invites online proposals from eligible Indian / international developers / joint ventures for

Development of World-Class Full-Service Viksit Bharat Mumbai Marina and Integrated Waterfront Assets, Mumbai on Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) basis.

Operation and maintenance of 424 wet berths developed by Port (Further development to 696 berths by Concessionaire)

39.86 ha Protected Water area + 7.30 ha Onshore

₹922 Cr Estimated Project cost

45 years concession period

Marina Facilities

- Marina terminal, Marina club, sailing school, dry stack and repair yard.
- Supporting infrastructure: 5-Star Hotel and Tourism Business Centre.
- Total Permissible Built-up Area - 1,06,000 sqm.

Location

Opposite the Domestic Cruise Terminal, with access via the Eastern Freeway and Atal Setu.

Bid documents available from	Pre-bid meeting	Last date for bid submission
12.10.2026	27.10.2026	25.11.2026

Bids to be submitted online only at www.eprocure.gov.in. Tender documents can be downloaded from www.mumbaiport.gov.in and www.eprocure.gov.in.

Chief Engineer, MbPA, Port House, Shorji Vallabhdas Marg, Ballard Estate, Mumbai - 400 001 | Email: chiefengineer@mumbaiport.gov.in | Tel: 022-6656 4031

Corrigenda / addenda, if any, will be published only on the above websites and not in newspapers.

GROWTH RESILIENCE Economists say India's resilience and strong fundamentals can support sustained high growth, but navigating global shocks and domestic challenges will be key

India's Growth Outlook Remains Robust, But Risks Rising: Berglof

Anoushka Sawhney

New Delhi: India's strong fundamentals makes it feasible for the country to achieve 7-8% growth, but trade disruptions, oil price shocks and climate risks, including El Nino, are making the path more challenging, Swedish economist Erik Berglof said.

He cautioned against greater protectionism and urged the government to build resilience by keeping the economy open and diversifying its sources of trade, raw materials and energy.

“For India, I am worried that the shocks will lead to some more protectionist policies. I think the long-term solution is really to make sure that you have many options when it comes to trade, resources of raw materials and sources of energy and so on,” Berglof said.

Greater cooperation among countries in the Global South could help build such resilience, the centre director of House of Governance and Public Policy at Stockholm School of Economics said. Countries should focus on developing productive trading relationships, with significant scope for greater integration across Asia, he added.

On the risk of India falling into the middle-income trap, Berglof said the ability of an economy to transform itself remains critical. India has already demonstrated significant transformational capacity through “re-markable” development of its renewable energy sector, and that gives hope of India not falling into the trap, he added.

The broader transformation, according to Berglof, will have to be driven by innovation and productivity across agriculture, manufacturing and services. “It's all about innovation and productivity, and that I think is going to be the solution to create that dynamism in the

India can find ways of integrating with a sort of open architecture type AI which, I think, is the future for developing both services and industry

ERIK BERGLOF
Swedish economist

Resilience Positions India for Larger Global Role: Landau

Anoushka Sawhney

New Delhi: India is well positioned to withstand a volatile global economy marked by geopolitical tensions, higher interest rates and rising stress in the advanced economy bond markets, said Jean-Pierre Landau, associate professor of economics at Sciences Po and former deputy governor, Bank of France. He noted that the country's resilience is increasingly positioning it to play a larger leadership role in the global order.

“India is displaying exceptional great resilience in the current volatile and uncertain environment,” said Landau, pointing to sustained growth, expanding exports, new trade agreements and continued foreign investment.

Landau observed stronger confidence emanating from India about its growth prospects and its ability to confront coming challenges. He added that in this geopolitical environment, India is going to be a major actor in BRICS, Asia and also among emerging economies. He noted that AI could provide an opportunity for India to take a leadership role, as the world needs someone to take initiatives to create a process of discussion and consultation on technology, adding that he would be happy to see India take such an initiative.

Landau said one of the big changes in the global financial system is that debt problems are now more visible in advanced economies, especially the US. Bond markets in these economies have become more volatile, and their traditional status as safe assets has also weakened. This could increase the risk of financial shocks around the world, India, however, is “extremely well placed” to

India is displaying exceptionally great resilience in the current volatile and uncertain environment

JEAN-PIERRE LANDAU
Associate professor of economics, Sciences Po

CITES SANCTIONS-RELATED COMPLIANCE CONCERN

Adani Airports Stops Handling Russian Cargo

Arindam Majumder

New Delhi: Adani Airports has stopped handling certain Russian-linked cargo at Mumbai airport, citing compliance concerns related to US sanctions. This has triggered a dispute with local representatives of Russian carriers Aeroflot and Volga-Dnepr over shipments already left at the airport.

In multiple communications to Mumbai airport authorities, Naveen Rao, head of Deltos Aviation—which represents Aeroflot Russian Airlines and Volga-Dnepr—said the dispute also involves a charter operation at Navi Mumbai Airport by Volga-Dnepr Airlines, where slot arrangements had initially been confirmed but were subsequently revoked.

Adani Airports operates eight airports in the country including major gateways such as Mumbai and Ahmedabad.

Rao said he was informed by airport officials that the decision was linked to the sanctions imposed on Russia by the US Office of Foreign Assets Control.

Adani Airports did not respond to ET's queries. People aware of the development, however, said that the decision was taken after the company raised a \$1 billion investment through a share sale to investors including US funds managed by BlackRock.

Rao has now written to the civil aviation ministry, urging it to step in to resolve the issue.

India officially maintains trade relations with the Russian government and recently signed trade deals.

TIMES ascent

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	Deputy Vice President (Digital Marketing)	2	33	45
	Content Specialist	1	25	40
	Head Sales	1	40	52
Advertisement No.: CRPD/SCO/2026-27/25 (Contractual Position)	Central Research Team (Product Lead)	2	30	45
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• DATE FOR FILING ONLINE APPLICATION & PAYMENT OF FEES: FROM 30.09.2026 To 21.10.2026.

Place: Mumbai
Date: 30.09.2026
General Manager (RP & PM)

M.P. TEXTBOOK CORPORATION

“Pustak Bhawan” Arera Hills, Bhopal-462011(M.P.)
Tel. : 0755-2551565, 2576300, E-mail ID : info.mptbc@mp.gov.in
-support-eproc@nic.in (for- E-tendering assistance)
No. 7916 Date : 05.10.2026

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

(P-1/2027-2028 and P-2/2027-2028)

Online tenders are invited for the supply of (i) 80 GSM S.S. Watermark Maplitho Printing Paper (P-1/2027-2028) & (ii) 250 GSM Art Card Paper (P-2/2027-2028).

The tenders have been processed on the e-Procurement System Portal <https://mptenders.gov.in>. Detailed NIT, Tender Document and other details will be available on the portal from 04:00 P.M. on 06.10.2026. The Bid documents can be downloaded upto 11:30 AM on 27.10.2026 and online bids can be submitted upto 11:30 AM on 27.10.2026. For any technical related queries please call at 24 x 7 Help Desk Number 0120-4001 002/0120-4200 462 / 0120-4001 005/0120-4493395. All Corrigendum/Amendments/Changes, if any, will only be issued and made available on website <https://mptenders.gov.in>

M.P.M./128380/2026 **DY. GENERAL MANAGER (PAPER)**

TENUGHAT VIDYUT NIGAM LIMITED

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Letter No.: 958 /26-27 Dated: 01.10.2026

CORRIGENDUM

Sub: Correction in the description of Sl. No. 4 of the e-Tender Notice published vide Letter No. - 892 /26-27 dated 25.09.2026 for works in Coal Handling Plant-1, TTPS, Lalpania.

Ref.: NIT No. 19/CHP-I/W/TVN/RAN/2026-27: SAP-SRM RFx No. 100013556.

In the above-mentioned e-Tender Notice, the description of work appearing at Sl. No. 4 shall be read as follows, in place of the description published therein:

Sl.No.	Corrected Description of Work
4	Annual Contract for cleaning and removal of coal dust / slurry / wastes etc. along running conveyors from Reclaim hopper-3 (RH-3 minus meter, pent house). Conveyor 8A/8B up to Primary Crusher House (PCH), conveyor-7 and any other jobs assigned by EIC in Coal Handling Plant at TTPS, Lalpania.

PR No. 390470

All other terms and conditions of the aforesaid e-Tender Notice shall remain unchanged.

Sd/- (Rajesh Ranjan) ESE (C&M)

PR 391065 Tenughat Vidyut Nigam Ltd.(26-27) D”

Mid-sized Restaurants Hungry for Funds as Investors Stay Away

LOSING APPETITE Investors wary of funding businesses that are yet to show sustainable profitability: Execs

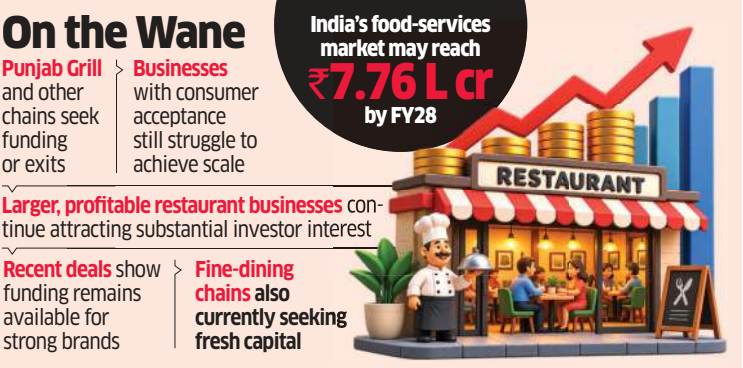
Reghu Balakrishnan & Ratna Bhushan

Mumbai | New Delhi: Mid-sized organised restaurant chains and quick service restaurants (QSR) are battling a financing hurdle with at least a dozen chains finding it increasingly difficult to attract fresh capital. Executives attributed this to investors turning more cautious on funding businesses that are yet to show sustainable profit metrics and strong store-level economics.

Mid-sized chains including Punjab Grill, Truffles, Mad Over Donuts, Charcoal Eats, YouMee, CX Partners-backed Dindigul Thalappakatti and General Atlantic-backed Absolute Barbecues are among chains seeking either the next round of funding or investor exits, said industry executives.

“Investors today are also much more disciplined,” said Rahul Singh, a serial investor in restaurant chains and co-founder of The Beer Café. “They are looking for proven unit economics, profitability and capital-efficient growth rather than simply a large top line. That creates a real funding gap for businesses that have demonstrated consumer acceptance but need another meaningful tranche of capital to reach scale.”

The Burman family, promoters of packaged goods maker Dabur India, has



been exploring selling a majority stake in some of the core brands under group company Lite Bite Foods such as Punjab Grill and Asian cuisine brand YouMee. Similarly, doughnut chain Mad Over Donuts, founded by entrepreneur Lokesh Bharwani, has been looking for a fundraise for the past six months, said the executives cited above.

Tamil Nadu-based biryani chain Dindigul Thalappakatti (DT) is also exploring a majority stake sale, as the initial investors want an exit. DT, also backed by Tree Line Investment and the family office of Havells Group, was valued at ₹450 crore in 2019 when CX Partners to-

ok a majority stake. “Biryani in India is as diverse as its languages,” said a Mumbai-based private equity investor. “What works in Telangana can be very different from what appeals to consumers in Karnataka, Delhi or Punjab. Anyone looking to build a pan-India biryani brand will therefore face significant challenges in catering to these distinct regional tastes.” The challenge, executives say, is more intense for mid-sized chains as large investments are continuing to gain traction.

“We are now planning our next phase of expansion; we are in conversations with partners,” said Tarak Bhattacha-

rya, executive director, Mad Over Donuts. He didn't elaborate.

Lite Bite Foods, Charcoal Eats and CX Partners didn't respond to queries. A General Atlantic spokesperson declined to comment.

“While valuation multiples in parts of the listed QSR universe have corrected, that has clearly not shut the market for high-quality private restaurant businesses,” said Siddharth Bafna, partner and head of corporate finance, Lodha & Co.

“In our experience, businesses that are performing well, have strong unit economics and a credible growth runway continue to attract significant investor interest,” he said. “It is primarily businesses whose operating performance has struggled that are finding fundraising difficult.”

Recent major deals include Vixar's, formerly Airpword Partners, acquisition of a significant minority stake in homegrown dessert and waffle chain The Belgian Waffle Co for about ₹70 crore. Popo Global, which owns The Pizza Bakery and other brands, recently raised ₹532 crore from Artal Asia. Siguler Guff invested \$40 million, or about ₹380 crore, in Trimex Foods, the operator of Chili's, PAUL and Cinnabon outlets in India. Subway India secured about ₹130 crore from Playbook Partners earlier this year and has now filed for a ₹600-crore IPO.

FMCG, Retail Cos Log Robust Growth in Q2

Shares mixed on inflation concerns; DMart & V2 fall, while Marico, Nykaa & V-Mart gain on D-Street

Our Bureau

Kolkata: Consumer demand gathered some momentum in the second quarter for FMCG companies Marico and Godrej Consumer Products, and retailers such as DMart, V-Mart Retail, V2 Retail and Nykaa, although shares of retailer DMart's parent company plunged the most in nearly two years over concerns of increased competition from ecommerce firms and rich valuations.

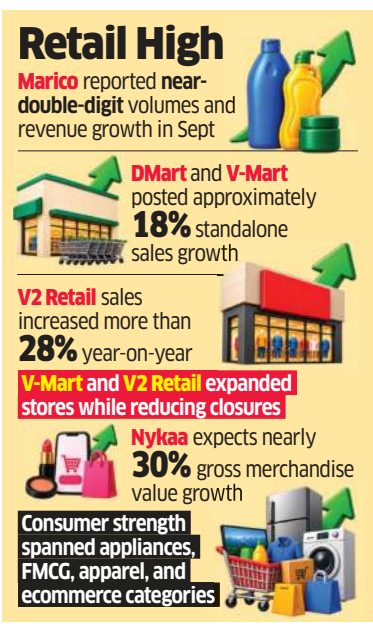
Nykaa, Marico and V-Mart shares climbed, while V2 Retail shares hurtled to 52-week lows.

Marico on Monday said underlying volume growth in the September quarter touched double digits, and consolidated revenue should expand similarly. The FMCG company, however, highlighted inflationary risks. Godrej Consumer Products too said its standalone business will deliver revenue growth in the teens and high-single-digit underlying volume growth, despite an es-

timated impact of approximately 100-150 basis points from trade inventory correction. The company said the performance is supported by healthy growth across both personal care and home care. “Domestic demand remained resilient during the quarter, even as the operating environment stayed volatile through the period,” Marico said. The maker of Parachute said it was on track to surpass its near-term guidance across key financial parameters, helped by the sustained strength of its core brands and the scale-up of newer growth engines.

Marico also expects a sharp year-on-year improvement in gross margin. While prices of crude-linked derivatives have risen, copra prices have remained rangebound at around 35% below their peak levels, it said. Godrej too said the quarter witnessed “renewed inflation” across several key raw-material baskets such as crude-linked derivatives and palm oils.

Retailers also reported a strong quarter. Avenue Supermarts, which opera-



tes DMart, and V-Mart Retail recorded around 18% year-on-year growth in standalone sales, while V2 Retail expanded sales by more than 28%.

But the Street reaction was mixed. DMart shares plunged 6.7%, the most in nearly two years, after two top Wall Street brokerages retained their ‘sell’ rating following the business update, citing competition from ecommerce firms. V2 Retail stocks plunged more than 16% to a 52-week low, while V-Mart shares climbed nearly 3%.

V-Mart's same-store sales growth was 3% during the quarter but rose to 11% after adjusting for the shift in festive timing. V2 Retail's same-store growth increased to 15% on the same adjustment.

The improvement was also reflected in retailers' store expansion plans. Unlike last year, when companies were focused on shutting underperforming outlets, store closures moderated in the September quarter. V-Mart opened 23 stores and closed one, while V2 Retail added 49 stores and shut three.

SUITS & SAYINGS

ET's roundup of the wackiest whispers in corporate corridors

High Stakes

A lavish Bengaluru dinner last week has set corporate and legal circles talking. Billed as a birthday celebration for a prominent lawyer—albeit a few weeks late—it brought together several of the country's leading corporate lawyers, courtesy of a well-known business family figure. The timing added intrigue. The lawyer is representing one side in a high-stakes corporate dispute, while a close family connection of the host is understood to be on the other. Just a belated birthday bash, perhaps—but one whose guest list was always going to get noticed.

Invisible Chief

Company insiders have a new nickname for this outgoing tech CEO: “Mr India”. With his successor named and exit date approaching, the boss is said to be increasingly hard to spot. Insiders joke that he appears to be channelling Shekhar Kapur's invisible hero. Except, what worked rather well as a superpower on screen can be a little less useful when there's a CEO transition to manage.

Privy to the whispers in power corridors or juicy tips on India Inc? Do share with us at etsuits.sayings@timesofindia.com

Bharat Forge Wins Contract for Aerospace Engine Parts

Mumbai: Bharat Forge said it has secured a long-term contract from Pratt & Whitney Canada for supply of mission-critical aerospace engine components. The components will be manufactured at Bharat Forge's aerospace facility, company said. “We look forward to supporting Pratt & Whitney Canada's programs and furthering India's advancement in aerospace manufacturing expertise,” Amit Kalyani, vice-chairman, Bharat Forge, said. —PTI

HEALTH CHECK

Centre may Seek Legal View on Licensing of Sterile Drugs

Move follows SC upholding HC verdict on limiting CDSCO's enforcement powers

Teena Thacker

New Delhi: The government is considering obtaining a legal opinion on a proposal to bring all sterile drug products under central licensing oversight, after the Supreme Court dismissed its challenge to a Himachal Pradesh High Court ruling that limited the enforcement powers of central regulatory officials over drug manufacturers.

The drugs consultative committee (DCC), which advises the central and state governments, at a recent meeting, discussed the proposal to bring all sterile drug products under the central licence approving authority (CLAA) scheme. It recommended constituting a sub-committee to examine the feasibility of the proposal and to obtain a considered legal opinion before any further action is taken.

The move assumes significance as the Supreme Court recently declined to interfere with the Himachal Pradesh High Court's finding that a drugs inspector of the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) did not have independent enforcement powers under Chapter IV of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act. Chapter IV of the Act governs the manufacture, sale

Action Plan

Panel proposed subcommittee to assess feasibility & legal implications



Proposal covers injectables, ophthalmic preparations, and small-volume parenterals

Existing central oversight covers only specified sterile medicine categories

and distribution of drugs.

The SC order has brought the Centre's enforcement jurisdiction under Chapter IV into the legal focus, even as the government considers expanding the central licensing framework to cover sterile products currently regulated by state drug authorities.

The proposal was referred to the DCC by the drugs technical

advisory board of the CDSCO. It seeks to bring all sterile drug products, including small-volume parenterals, injectables and ophthalmic preparations under the CLAA scheme.

At present, only specified categories of sterile medicines fall under the CLAA framework. These include large-volume parenterals, sera and vaccines, recombinant DNA-derived products, cell or stem-cell-derived products, gene therapeutic products and xenografts. Other sterile products are licensed by state authorities.

The proposal argues that sterile products warrant specialised regulatory oversight because of their vulnerability to microbial contamination.

According to the proposal, the existing framework is fragmented, with different categories of sterile products falling under either central or state licensing. It also flags variations in scrutiny of applications and inspection practices among state regulators, particularly when additional products are approved after a manufacturing licence has already been granted. The proposal seeks to bring all sterile drug products, irrespective of category, under the CLAA framework to establish a more uniform regulatory regime.

Hospital Pricing Part of Wider Value Chain: Max Health MD

Rica Bhattacharyya

Mumbai: India's private hospitals should not be viewed on the price of individual drugs, injections or consumables without accounting for the wider clinical value chain involved in delivering care, Max Healthcare chairman and managing director Abhay Soi said, amid growing scrutiny over hospital pricing.

Soi's comments come against the backdrop of Maharashtra scrutinising steep markups on hospital consumables and the Supreme Court's recent observation on a cancer drug carrying a markup of 10 times with patients required to procure it through in-hospital pharmacies.

“By the end of the day, a hospital is not selling an IV fluid bag. A hospital is not selling an injection,” Soi said. “A hospital is administering the injection.”

“There is a particular training, there is a particular sort of storage requirement, then administering the medicine and then disposal through proper biomedical waste processes. There is an entire value chain,” he said.

Hospitals have thousands of individual billing items, with margins varying across products and services, Soi said. “Some won't have margin, some will have margin. But ultimately it translates to that 8-9% net profit,” Soi said.

Hospital profitability needs to be viewed against the sector's capital intensity and continuing investment requirements, he said. “Now, your equipment gets totally depreciated. You have to replace your entire equipment every 10 years. Eventually, you have to reinvest as well,” he said.

India will require massive investment to expand hospital capacity as demand rises, he said. The private sector currently has less than 100,000 tertiary-care beds, while industry players have announced plans to add about 40,000 beds over the next four to five years.

“As per WHO estimates, India will require approximately 1.2 million additional hospital beds. This will entail an estimated \$120 billion in investment over the next decade,” he said. This includes cost per bed, excluding land.

Hospital occupancy has risen from around 50-55% pre-Covid to 68-70% currently and new facilities are reaching full occupancy faster, Soi said. “Earlier it used to take two years to get full occupancy, now it's happening in a year or eight months,” he said.



A hospital is not selling an IV fluid bag. A hospital is not selling an injection. A hospital is administering injection, says Max Health's Soi

Bubonic Plague Seen as High-risk Disease, But Treatable

Russian authorities reportedly imposed anti-epidemic provisions after a laboratory staff at a research institute in Siberia died of a “mysterious illness”. The cause is feared to be bubonic plague, but it is not confirmed yet. Roughly 200 people are placed under observation in quarantine. Vikas Dandekar looks at the symptoms of bubonic plague, whether it could become a pandemic and the different forms of the plague.

HOW DOES BUBONIC PLAGUE SPREAD?

According to the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, there are two ways in which it can spread. Plague bacteria are often transmitted by the bite of an infected flea. During plague,

many rodents die causing fleas to seek other sources of blood. People and animals that visit places where rodents have recently died from plague are at risk of being infected from flea bites. Dogs and cats may also bring plague-infected fleas into the home. Flea-bite exposure may result in primary bubonic plague or septicemic plague. Humans can also become infected when handling tissue of a plague-infected animal.

CAN BUBONIC PLAGUE BECOME FATAL?

According to the WHO, plague is an infectious disease caused by the bacterium Yersinia pestis. The infection is generally associated with small mammals and

their fleas, although humans can become infected through direct contact with infected material or, in pneumonic plague, by respiratory particles. Untreated bubonic plague can have a mortality rate of 50-60%, according to several research data.

WHAT ARE THE CONDITIONS OR SYMPTOMS OF PLAGUE?

There are different forms of plague. Bubonic plague causes painful swollen lymph nodes. Pneumonic plague affects the lungs and is the most severe form.

IS THERE A THREAT OF BUBONIC PLAGUE BECOMING A PANDEMIC?

Bubonic plague is seen as a high-risk disease but does not pose the same global threat as it is known for since it can be effectively treated with antibiotics. Unlike the Covid-19 pandemic,



VARANI SAHU

unless it is highly contagious, mutates and spreads quickly in population, it can't cause serious levels of mortality. The pneumonic form of plague is, however, seen by experts as a dangerous condition. Unlike the bubonic form, it can be transmitted directly from person to person. Without treatment, pneumonic

plague is extremely fatal.

IS BUBONIC PLAGUE SIMILAR TO EBOLA?

Bubonic plague and Ebola are similar as they are zoonotic diseases and can cause outbreaks and mortality or deaths. However, they are not biologically or epidemiologically the same. Bubonic plague is a bacterial infection whereas Ebola is a viral disease transmitted primarily through contact with the body fluids of infected people or animals. The symptoms also differ. Bubonic plague characteristically causes painful swollen lymph, while Ebola commonly causes fever, weakness, gastrointestinal symptoms and, in some cases, bleeding. Importantly, bubonic plague can be treated effectively with antibiotics, whereas Ebola requires specialised supportive care.

THE MORNING BRIEF PODCAST

Flydubai Incident: Can Aviation Security Stop the Threat from Within?



Anirban Chowdhury speaks to aviation security

experts Arik Arad and Shanon Wandmaker about the Flydubai incident, the growing challenge of insider threats, continuous vetting and how aviation security may need to evolve.

Tune in to ETPlay.com. Available on EconomicTimes.com/podcast, Amazon Prime Music, Apple Podcasts, JioSaavn and Spotify.

Honda Motor Looks to Cut Development Time, Costs with Tata Tech Tie-Up

Mumbai | Tokyo: Honda Motor aims to cut costs by as much as a fifth and halve development times through its new partnership in India with Tata Technologies, according to two people familiar with the matter, as pressure from rivals forces the Japanese automaker to rethink its go-it-alone approach.

Reeling from electric vehicle (EV)-related losses that it expects to reach more than \$12 billion, Honda is pivoting to gasoline-electric hybrids and slashing expenses. Last month, Reuters reported that it is seeking to cut more than \$9 billion in costs over next four years and has told suppliers to drastically reduce prices.

In May, engineering firm Tata Technologies said it had been selected to develop vehicles for a Japanese automaker. It declined to name the partner, but two people and another person familiar with the matter said it was Honda.

Under the outsourcing agreement, Tata Technologies will develop cars for the Indian market, while Honda expects to achieve up to 20% cost reductions and halve its development times, from around five years at present, two of the people said. —Reuters

Legal action
Former UK prince Andrew is taking the UK police to court over his February arrest in the Epstein files case



A billionaire investor's bet on restoring his daughter's sight

Following a brain haemorrhage, Bill Ackman's daughter Lucy is showing signs of recovery with an experimental mitochondrial therapy

Elizabeth Dwsokin

Billionaire Bill Ackman's life was upended this February when his 26-year-old daughter collapsed in her Brooklyn apartment, suffering a brain haemorrhage that would render her unable to move, speak or see.

The hedge fund manager did what any good father would do—at least, any father with vast financial resources and what friends describe as a 'Mr Fix-It' tendency. He sprung into action, getting her top-line care at New York

City's Mt Sinai Hospital and consulting a network of well-connected friends all over the world. He helped her access a novel cell therapy that has been gaining traction among longevity enthusiasts. And then — motivated by a newfound desire to accelerate scientific research — he vowed to spend more than \$400 million to launch an institute dedicated to longevity and brain health.

"Our goal is to build the world's greatest brain research, rehabilitation, recovery, human optimisation and longevity institute," he said on

X. He posted that the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA), in May, gave his daughter Lucy's medical team a first-time emergency authorisation to transplant mitochondria — the energy-producing part of human cells — from her leg muscle to her eyes, in the hopes that the tiny cell powerhouses would facilitate healing in her optic nerves and perhaps even restore her vision.

Medical milestone

The mitochondrial transplantation given to Ackman's daughter Lucy is attracting interest from both injury researchers and longevity scientists, who see mitochondria as a possible tool for reversing some effects of ageing.

Best known as the cell's energy powerhouse, mitochondria also play a role in clearing damaged cells, potentially aiding regeneration and healing.

The first human mitochondrial

transplant, from abdominal muscle to the heart, was reported in 2017. Dozens have since been performed, including one involving the brain in 2024, but none had been carried out on human eyes until now, said Daria Mochly-Rosen, professor of chemical and systems biology at the Stanford University School of Medicine.

Treatment plan

David Putrino, a Mt Sinai neuroscientist responsible for Lucy Ackman's care, said that he and colleagues had been working on mitochondrial transplant research for about a year. In April, they read a study in the journal *Nature*, in which a mitochondrial transplant was successfully used to help a mouse recover from an injury that crushed the animal's optic nerve. The study convinced the Mt Sinai medical team that it was time for a therapeutic attempt in humans.

Lucy's doctors approached her family with the idea, and the team ultimately applied for a time-sensitive regulatory permission to obtain the drug, known as an eND, something Putrino said he had done only two times before in his career.

For the first few weeks, the treatment — an injection into her eyes — gave Lucy the ability to perceive light. After about a month, the benefit appeared to wear off.

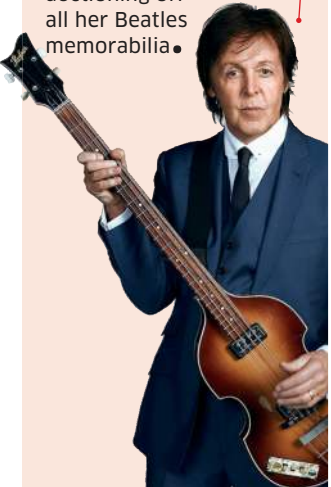
"We are working on a method to inject her eyes with more frequency," Ackman posted recently, adding that mitochondria "has amazing potential".

— The Washington Post



\$3,960

The estimated cost of a front door key to Paul McCartney's childhood home that is up for auction by Dominic Winter auctioneers on October 7. The 'remarkable piece of Beatles history' is expected to fetch more than 3,000 pounds. McCartney lived with his family from 1955 until late 1963 at the home in Allerton, Liverpool — described as "the birthplace of the Beatles". He composed some of the band's earliest songs there with John Lennon including 'She Loves You'. After the McCartneys left the council house, the new occupant sent the key, a photo of the house and a letter to an American Beatles fan, who is now auctioning off all her Beatles memorabilia.



Longevity goals

OpenAI CEO Sam Altman has backed Retro Biosciences, which aims to add 10 healthy years to the human lifespan, while Amazon founder Jeff Bezos is reportedly a funder of Altos Labs, focused on cellular rejuvenation. Peter Thiel, Sergey Brin and Larry Ellison have also invested in life-extension research, while Elon Musk co-founded Neuralink and its former co-founder Max Hodak now leads Science, developing a retinal chip for age-related vision loss.



Sam Altman, Jeff Bezos, Larry Ellison, Peter Thiel and Sergey Brin

PICS: BLOOMBERG, GETTY IMAGES, REUTERS

PIC: AI GENERATED

picture perfect



Miss, world

A little wanderlust, a touch of glamour and plenty of starry getaways as these famous women head off on their latest adventures

1. Singer Dua Lipa sported a stylish look for an interview with artist Ai Weiwei in Porto about his new book. 2. Model Bar Refaeli took a picturesque stroll during her trip to Paris. 3. Supermodel Miranda Kerr looked a vision in white in the French capital. 4. TV personalities Kris Jenner and Khloé Kardashian enjoyed a holiday in Shanghai. 5. Skiing champion Lindsey Vonn returned to her home in Utah to "rest, recharge".



PICS: INSTAGRAM



3

'For the first time, I feel ashamed...'

Luka Modrić has been playing football at the highest level for more than two decades, time in which he has played over 200 international games. But despite all the glittering success, he can still experience crushing lows from time to time.

As England inflicted the heaviest ever defeat on Croatia in the nation's history, a 7-0 thrashing at home, Modrić said he was "ashamed".

The 41-year-old said it often looked like Croatia had half their side missing, as England ran riot in Rijeka. "You can't



PIC: REUTERS

play football like that... we looked like we had four or five players less. It is difficult to find an explanation for such a performance without duels, fouls, aggressiveness, togetherness," he said.

"I've been here for 20 years, but for the first time, I feel ashamed after a game," he added.

Tough stretch

Things will now get even tougher for the Croats, as they face world champions Spain next.

Modrić, who won the Ballon d'Or in 2018, added: "You

can lose, or play against an opponent who is better — and they are right now. But in any case, losing like this and squandering the reputation we've built over the years is unacceptable."

"It was a catastrophic night. We need to pull ourselves together, stay together because a new difficult game awaits us [next]. We have to show our true colours, that there is defiance and pride in us, desire, willingness, togetherness, these things cannot be lost overnight," he added.

— Daily Mirror

Unpacking one year of 'Blazymania'

The Franco-Belgian's designs have sparked frenzied buying of items costing thousands of dollars

Exactly a year since he unveiled his first collection at Chanel, Franco-Belgian designer Matthieu Blazy has proved himself to be a shrewd and hugely profitable recruit by the family-owned French fashion label.

Some of Blazy's designs have proved so popular they have sparked a neologism — 'Blazymania' — which has come to mean the frenzied buying in stores of items that often cost thousands of dollars.

When his first collection, Spring-Summer 2026, arrived in stores in March, videos of buyers streaming into Chanel shops went viral on social media.

And while the luxury sector is going through a tough spell, sales at the company increased 16 per cent in the first half of this year compared with 2025, according to confidential sales data reported in August.

Alix Morabito, director of buying at luxury Paris department store Galeries Lafayette, has also gauged the extent of 'Blazymania': Every new delivery is eagerly awaited and it can sometimes be difficult for shoppers to get hold of pieces because the waiting lists are so long.

"There's a new balance to find between desirability, scarcity and generosity," she said.

Bringing joy

Eric Briones, director of the Paris School of Luxury, said that only the fourth designer in Chanel's history had "brought joy" to the brand.

"Before, it wasn't exactly all smiles. Now there is joy everywhere, even in sales at a pop-up store in Shanghai," he explained.

Appointed in 2025 to succeed Virginie Viard, Karl Lagerfeld's

channelling Chanel



PICS: GETTY IMAGES

discreet successor, Blazy landed one of the biggest jobs in fashion, aged just 40.

Said to have impressed with his in-depth presentations during the recruitment process, he embodies "a new generation with sincere humility", Chanel fashion president Bruno Pavlovsky said of him at the time.

That was seen as good a fit for Chanel's discreet family owners, Alain and Gerard Wertheimer.

Blazy began his career at Maison Margiela in 2011, before moving to Celine and then Calvin Klein in New York, where he worked under Belgian designer Raf Simons until they were both sacked in 2018.

Named as Bottega Veneta's creative director in 2021, he helped reinvent the Italian leather goods brand, earning him the nickname the 'magician of Milan'.

Magic formula

So, what is Chanel's magic formula now? "He has broken down the brand's codes, projecting them into a new era," said Pierre Groppe, fashion and lifestyle editor-in-chief at *Vanity Fair* magazine.

The emblems of the house founded by Coco Chanel in 1910 remain visual cornerstones: Tweed, often woven in highly modern iridescent and metallic tones; the camellia; pearls; the double C; black and white; and the silhouette of the 1920s dress falling below the knee.

Everyday accessories and clothing have been introduced, along with denim, humour and pop references.

Groppe highlighted the enthusiasm among a new male audience for Chanel ready-to-wear, including "loafers, trainers, blazers and bags".

The house has also taken on male ambassadors, including actor Pedro Pascal, but still has no officially designated men's line. Just "pieces that suit everyone", Blazy says.

— AFP

A dose of bird song

Can birdwatching reinvent itself as a new wellness craze?

Scientists created a smartphone application, UrbanMind, to collect people's real-time reports of mental well-being before and after hearing wild birdsong. By analysing 26,000 data entries, they were able to statistically prove the link between hearing birds and an elevated mood. The natural mood boost was found to last up to eight hours and even helped some participants with depression.

The report's lead author Ryan Hammoud suggested doctors should add birdwatching to their 'social prescribing' roster. "We have for the first time shown the direct link between seeing or hearing birds and positive mood," he said.

"This study has potential for mental healthcare policy. Visits to habitats with a high degree of birdlife could become part of social prescribing schemes, playing a role in preventing mental health difficulties and complementing more traditional interventions."

Positive effects
With more than 12 million hashtags and 5,00,000 videos online, it's safe to say birdwatching is no longer a pastime for the older generation or the eccentric few. Since the lockdown, Gen Z has become so obsessed with 'birding', that it is now classed as an official 'Hot-girl hobby'.

But perhaps what's really made birdwatching soar is the positive effect it can have on your health, especially your mental well-being.

Calming and comforting
Good Morning Britain's Dr Amir Khan can explain exactly what happens in the body when we hear birdsong. "It does wonders for our body," he said. "It reduces our stress hormone cortisol which lowers our blood pressure and our heart rate and increasing our dopamine and serotonin levels, which makes us feel relaxed and calm and happy."

It even changes our brainwaves. "Birdsong is calming and comforting but it's not repetitive — it changes every so often — so what it does, is it changes our brainwaves as well," Dr

Khan said on a podcast. But for the most part, fans have stressed that the joy of birding is in its simplicity. Most of the time, it can be done anywhere, and at almost any hour.

Sean summed it up perfectly in a recent discussion. "We're so lucky to have this around us for free," he said. All it takes is patience and a few feathered friends. •

— Daily Mirror

Company culture calls the shots

Why a corporate environment may matter more than policy when it comes to remote work

More than six years after the COVID-19 pandemic began, over one in five of US workers who can work remotely do so either full time or at least one day per week.

Even though a new normal has set in, no single approach has worked for all employees. To see what factors affected the long-term shift to remote and hybrid work that kept going after the pandemic subsided, and to learn more about the pandemic's effects on research firms more broadly, a research team was formed at Babson College, US.

In keeping with social science research methods, the team agreed to not name any of these companies. Through a series of interviews with senior leaders, project team leaders and other employees from 2021 to 2023, all four companies told most of their employees to work from home in March 2020.

Slow to change
Other research into how likely an employer was to allow remote and hybrid work arrangements after the pandemic focused on executives' traits, such as their age and personalities. But the team also found that these choices regarding where employees work can have more to do with an employer's organisational culture: The set of assumptions, beliefs and norms that shape how people who work together make decisions and interact with each other.

Because it develops slowly over years, organisational culture is hard to change. When a crisis strikes, that culture acts like a script that determines which decisions feel possible and which seem untenable. •

— AP



STYLE OF A WOMAN A matter of taste

For Arushi Agrawal, founder of SEVA Home, elegance is about restraint



My style
I like clean lines, considered proportions and a restrained palette where the quality does the talking. In my twenties, I was experimental and followed trends. Style, for me, has become less about being noticed and more about feeling like myself.

Brand talk
I'm drawn to houses with a strong point of view and impeccable craft, such as **Chanel**, for its timeless elegance and The Row for its quiet minimalism.

Splurge fest
I love discovering fashion districts such as the Marais district in Paris, with its independent boutiques, trendy concept stores and cobblestone streets.

Style advice
Coco Chanel said, "Before you leave the house, take one thing off." Elegance is often about restraint.

Must-haves
A well-cut blazer, a great pair of tailored trousers, a little black dress and a pair of classic pumps. If I had to pick one, it's the blazer. It can make jeans look polished and works with a dress or trousers.

Accessory speak
A pair of pearl earrings, a versatile leather handbag, a silk scarf and a pair of sunglasses. Together, they can lift even the simplest outfit.

Prized item
My wedding *odhni*, which my father-in-law draped over me just after I finished my *phasas*. It marked the moment I became part of a new family.

Add to cart
Homeware. I love entertaining at home, so I'm always looking for beautiful tableware. •
— As told to shannika.ramos@timesofindia.com



Circle Studio kantha shorts ₹9.5k



Nori weekender bag ₹6.2k



D'YAVOL tinted sunglasses ₹31.2k



Gap mandarin collar full-sleeved shirt ₹3.9k



Ralph Lauren chino cap ₹9.7k



Sennheiser wireless headphones ₹39.9k



Bata slippers ₹1.2k



Péro co-ord set Price on request

FLIGHTS OF FANCY

Weekend trips made easy with these essentials

etpanache@timesofindia.com

HOW TO

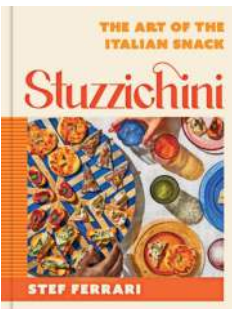
- Packing for a weekend away doesn't mean overstuffing your bag. The trick is to build a capsule of easy, versatile pieces that work both for lazy days or evenings out.
- Add a few layers: An oversized shirt, a lightweight jacket and sunglasses result in a compact wardrobe that feels put together without requiring you to pack an entire closet.
- Co-ord sets are an instant outfit with minimal effort, as the top and bottom separately can be mixed and matched with the rest of your wardrobe.

bread winner

A seasonal fruit crostini with ricotta

Like so many preparations in chef Stef Ferrari's cookbook, *Stuzzichini*, and in Italian food in general, it's almost impossible to call this a recipe. Instead, it's an act of trust: You must trust that whatever fruit you choose for this crostini will pair perfectly with fresh ricotta, good-quality honey, and your choice of crunchy bits, herbs and spices, as long as it's done with intention and care.

Some seasonal fruits to use include



red cherries, figs, pears and tart peaches, but keep an eye out at the market and an open mind. Use the following as a good starting point per slice: 1 to 2 tablespoons ricotta, 2 teaspoons honey, ¼ cup of fruit.

Ingredients

- Baguette, sliced on a bias
- Extra-virgin olive oil
- Whole-milk ricotta
- Seasonal fruit (cherries, pears, peaches, apples, figs, oranges) cleaned and pitted, cut to your preference
- Honey and nuts
- Freshly cracked black pepper, fresh herbs and grated citrus zest

How to

- Brush the baguette slices with oil and toast on a sheet pan in a 190 C oven for 10 to 12 minutes. Allow to cool completely.
- Spread the ricotta evenly across the slices. Arrange the fruit on each slice and drizzle with honey. Add any optional toppings and serve. •

— AP

Powering the next wind wave

Windergy India 2026 is set to bring together industry players from across the country and the world for a three-day event in Chennai

etpanache@timesofindia.com

India's wind sector is scaling at a rapid pace, with installed capacity surging past 58.5 GW as of August 31. This is unlocking vast commercial opportunities across manufacturing, innovation and global investment for domestic and international stakeholders alike.

Against this dynamic backdrop, Windergy India 2026, the dedicated show for the wind sector, returns for its eighth edition. Organised by the Indian Wind Turbine Manufacturers Association (IWTMA) and PDA Ventures Pvt Ltd, the three-day trade fair and conference is scheduled from October 7 to 9 at the Chennai Trade Centre, Chennai.

Backed by government and industry

Windergy India 2026 is supported by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), Ministry of Power (MoP) and apex industry bodies. Supporting partners include Guidance Tamil Nadu, German Agency for International Cooperation (GIZ), German

Wind Energy Association (BWE), German Offshore Wind Energy Foundation, Spanish Institute for Foreign Trade (ICEX), Danish Energy Export, India Energy Storage Alliance (IESA), National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE), Indian Wind Power Association (IWPA), National Solar Energy Federation of India (NSEFI), Net-Zero Energy Transition Association (NETRA), Skill Council for Green Jobs (SCGJ), Invest India and GRIDCO.

Wind ecosystem on display

The exhibition will showcase developments across turbine technology, offshore wind, energy storage, digitalisation, repowering solutions and advanced O&M, bringing together OEMs, component suppliers, EPC firms, developers, grid integrators, and digital leaders.



Industry professionals networking at the event



Dignitaries during the ceremonial inauguration of the event last year

The event will also feature dedicated international pavilions representing Denmark, Germany and Spain, offering a platform for global wind power companies to showcase technologies.

Complementing the exhibition, the two-day conference on October 8 and 9 will centre on the theme 'Wind - Powering India's Energy Resilience'. Discussions will examine some of the key issues shaping the sector, including state-led investment, manufacturing localisation, offshore wind expansion, export growth, asset management and workforce development.

Other featured engagements

Innovation hub: The hub will showcase emerging technologies aimed at making wind projects smarter and more efficient. The solutions span the project lifecycle, from AI-driven logistics and blade engineering to asset intelligence, including MeitY-incubated venture.

Strategic roundtables: High-level technical and regional roundtables will focus on some of the sector's key challenges

and emerging opportunities, including Indo-German offshore wind R&D, BESS sizing for hybrid projects and evolving regional investment policies.

Academia sessions: Dedicated sessions will connect students and academic institutions with industry leaders to discuss career pathways, turbine recyclability and the skills needed for the growing green jobs ecosystem.

Windergy India 2026 will also bring together a strong line-up of industry partners. Suzlon Energy Limited is the Platinum Partner, with Envision Wind Power Technologies India Pvt Ltd and Senvion India Private Limited as Gold Partners. Venwind Refex and Renfra Energy India Pvt Ltd are Silver Partners. UL Solutions is the Advisory & Certification Partner, while Latent Group is the Dinner Partner.

Functional partners include Winergy (drive solution; lanyard and badges), ExxonMobil (lubricant), Globe Ecologistics (logistics), NeXHS (registration area), Adani New Industries Limited (visitor bag and chair tag), Leap Green (delegate kit) and MHT Ropeways (hydration).

For more information, Visit: www.windergy.in Contact: Nijith Nair on +91 8867697232 Email: nijith@pdaventures.com

Know the cold truth behind your hot tea

How temperature and energy turn a steaming beverage into a refreshing drink

What's the science behind a perfect pitcher of iced tea? A simple answer is that the near-boiling tea transferred its hotness to the below-freezing ice cubes. This transfer raised the temperature of the ice cubes so that much of the ice melted. That both cooled the tea to a refreshing drinking temperature and diluted it for a proper taste.

The explanation for how it all works depends on two related concepts: Temperature and energy.

What are temperature and energy?

The concept of temperature grew out of the sense of what feels hot and cold to human touch. Boiling water is too hot to touch safely and a candle flame is even hotter. Ice cubes feel cold. A thermometer is a special temperature meter that more reliably and repeatedly determines the degree of hotness or coldness of substances than our sense of touch.

Energy is a more complicated concept. One way to think about energy is to track what it costs nature to make changes from one set of conditions to another. Another type of energy is called potential energy, and it accounts for the energy stored by the forces acting between or within objects.

Whatever amount of energy is gained in one place must be lost from somewhere else. Scientists call this rule of nature conservation of energy, or in cases involving thermal energy, the first law of thermodynamics.

Energy transfer

When the hot tea encounters the ice cubes, the molecules of tea-flavoured water collide with the molecules on the surface of the ice. The liquid's molecules slow down. The ice's molecules speed up and some even leave the solid and mix in with the liquid tea.

The tea loses thermal energy and lowers its temperature. That energy transfers to the ice, which gains that energy and increases its temperature.

The process of energy moving from one place to another due to differences in temperature is called heat transfer. Left to itself, nature transfers thermal energy only from higher to lower temperatures. That observation is called the second law of thermodynamics. It's why you will never see a cup of cold tea turn into a cup of ice cubes and hot tea.

This process continues until the ice eventually reaches a temperature of 0 degrees C, its melting temperature. At that point, the ice cannot take any more energy and stay solid, even though it is still absorbing thermal energy from the hotter tea.

Heat transfer cooling means that energy leaves the tea. Thus, the thermal energy of the tea turns into the potential energy of the water molecules that used to be part of the ice, lowering the temperature of the liquid in the pitcher. The process continues until eventually all the tea and whatever ice that survived the melting are at the same refreshing 32 degrees F.



AI GENERATED

— AP



PIC AFP

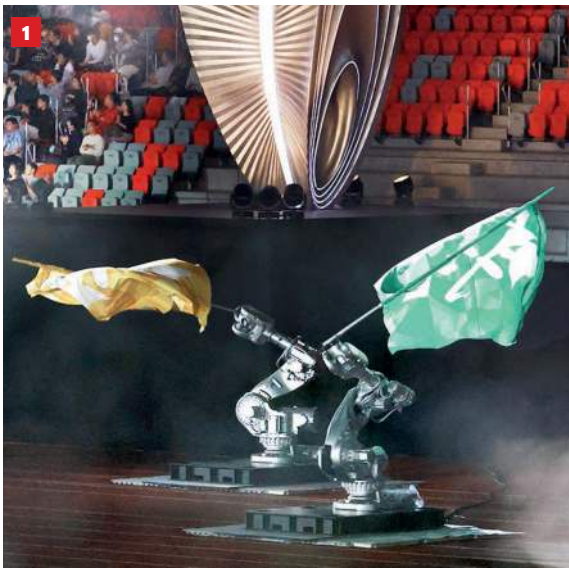
“I am worried that new, powerful technology is being introduced where people risk being photographed, filmed or audio-recorded without knowing it.”

quote unquote

— TORGEIR MICAELEN,

Minister of Digitalisation and Public Governance, Norway, on the government's plan to propose a temporary ban on the use of AI glasses in selected public places, including beaches, schools, playground, pools and gyms.

Soaring to new heights



1. Robotic arms wave flags during the closing ceremony of the 20th Asian Games in Japan on October 4



2. Virgin Group founder Richard Branson sits in the captain's seat of an Airbus A350 full-flight simulator flight deck

Arctic thaw is warming the planet

As Ted Schuur stepped along the edges of Smith Lake, Alaska, a bubble surfaced from the muck underfoot. And then another.

They're bubbles of methane, a potent heat-trapping gas made from decomposing plants and animals that had once been stuck in Alaska's frigid permafrost. But that frozen ground is thawing because the Arctic is warming four times faster than the rest of the globe. For thousands of years, frozen ground stored dead plants and animals, but the accelerating thaw is allowing them to decay into methane and carbon dioxide.

“Once you start leaking this carbon out, there's so much in the ground that it's not going to shut off,” said Schuur, an ecologist at Northern Arizona University, US.

Frozen matter

There's three times as much carbon still frozen in permafrost than what's now in the air, but all over the



Permafrost melts on the coast in Alaska



AI GENERATED

Arctic those heat-trapping gases are escaping into the atmosphere. Their release adds to what's already in the air from burning coal, oil and natural gas, changing the balance of how the world deals with the buildup of heat-trapping carbon, Schuur said. Permafrost is ground that stays frozen — below zero degrees Celsius — for at least two years and often for centuries. That frozen ground — found in Alaska, Canada, Siberia, Antarctica and other elevated terrains — has special advantages,

trapping decaying matter, keeping it from turning into greenhouse gases and just being firm enough for communities to build their lives upon.

Changing climate

Permafrost thaw, along with other emissions are likely to increase warming by 20 per cent by the end of the century, according to a September study.

It may be a small amount, not worthy of scenarios of doom, but it's something “that we're going to have to deal with” on top of everything else, said University of Victoria climate scientist, Andrew Weaver, who first calculated the half-a-degree of expected permafrost warming in a 2012 study.

— AP

Gerrit De Vynck, Jeremy B Merrill

Millions are sharing personal information and private thoughts with AI as they integrate apps like ChatGPT more intimately into their lives than they did with previous generations of technology. Many talk to AI apps as they might a close friend or therapist, turning to them for emotional support and incorporating advice into their own lives and thinking.

By the numbers

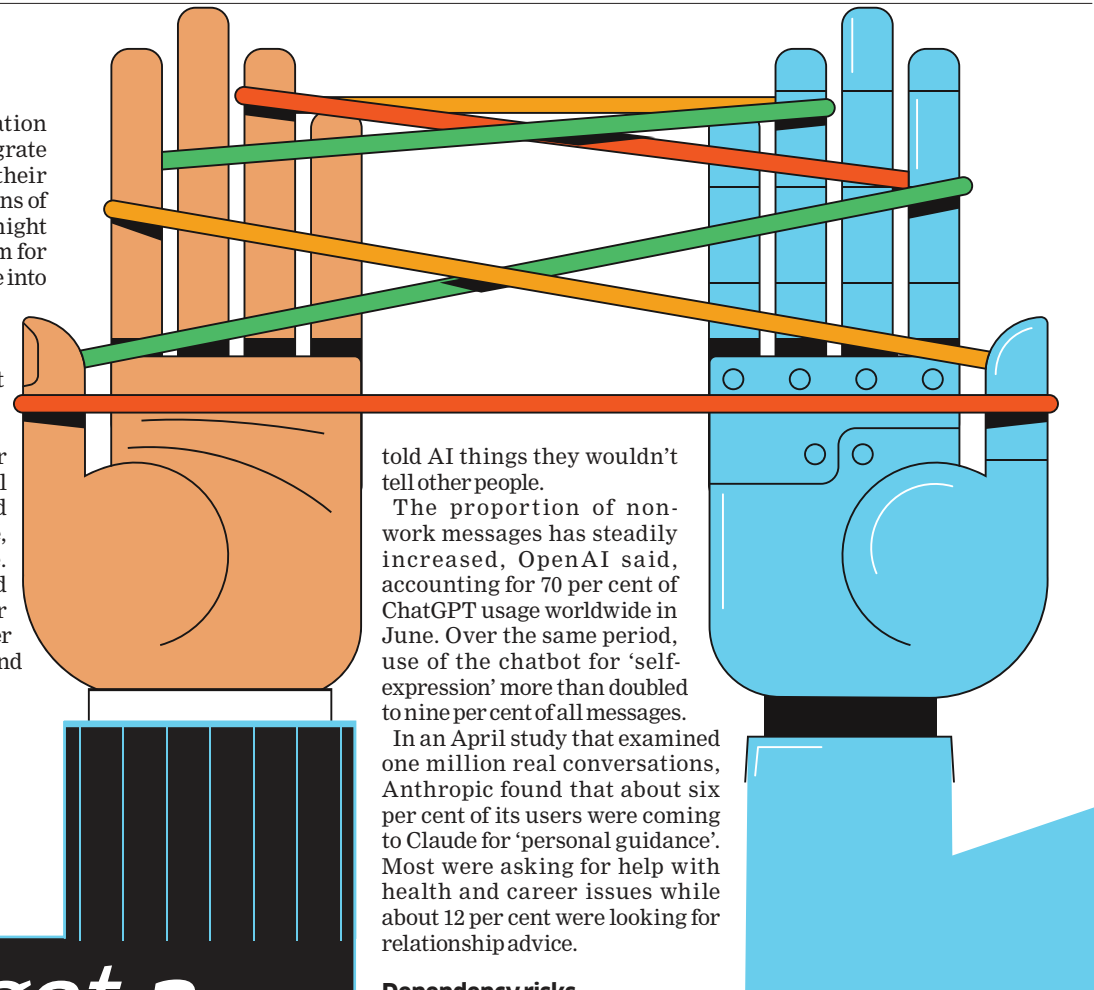
According to a new poll from researchers at Elon University, US, and *The Washington Post*, 27 per cent of Americans turn to AI chatbots like OpenAI's ChatGPT or Google's Gemini with personal, emotional or social queries. That category included seeking entertainment, relationship advice, romantic chats or connection when alone. Among the people who said they used chatbots for personal or emotional queries or discussions, nearly a third said they consider the chatbot they use most often to be a friend while a little more than half of them did not.

Recent surveys show that more people turn to chatbots for advice and companionship

They've got a friend in AI

Jessica Dai, a PhD student in computer science at the University of California at Berkeley, US, published a study in June based on three years of conversations about AI on the social forum Reddit. People initially posted basic questions about how to use AI after the launch of ChatGPT but posts for what Dai calls “emotional engagement” increased steadily over time.

When asked to describe their relationship with AI, respondents to the Elon University survey said that it provided companionship they couldn't get from another person. The popularity of AI chatbots for personal and emotional support has made the companies custodians of highly private data, raising new privacy questions. Nearly four in 10 of AI users who said they use chatbots for emotional and social reasons said they have



told AI things they wouldn't tell other people.

The proportion of non-work messages has steadily increased, OpenAI said, accounting for 70 per cent of ChatGPT usage worldwide in June. Over the same period, use of the chatbot for ‘self-expression’ more than doubled to nine per cent of all messages.

In an April study that examined one million real conversations, Anthropic found that about six per cent of its users were coming to Claude for ‘personal guidance’. Most were asking for help with health and career issues while about 12 per cent were looking for relationship advice.

Dependency risks

Some of the heaviest Claude users were also the most sceptical of AI, according to Deep Ganguli, who leads Anthropic's social impacts team. “The same individual who is using Claude for day-to-day work is concerned about Claude's impact on the economy,” he said.

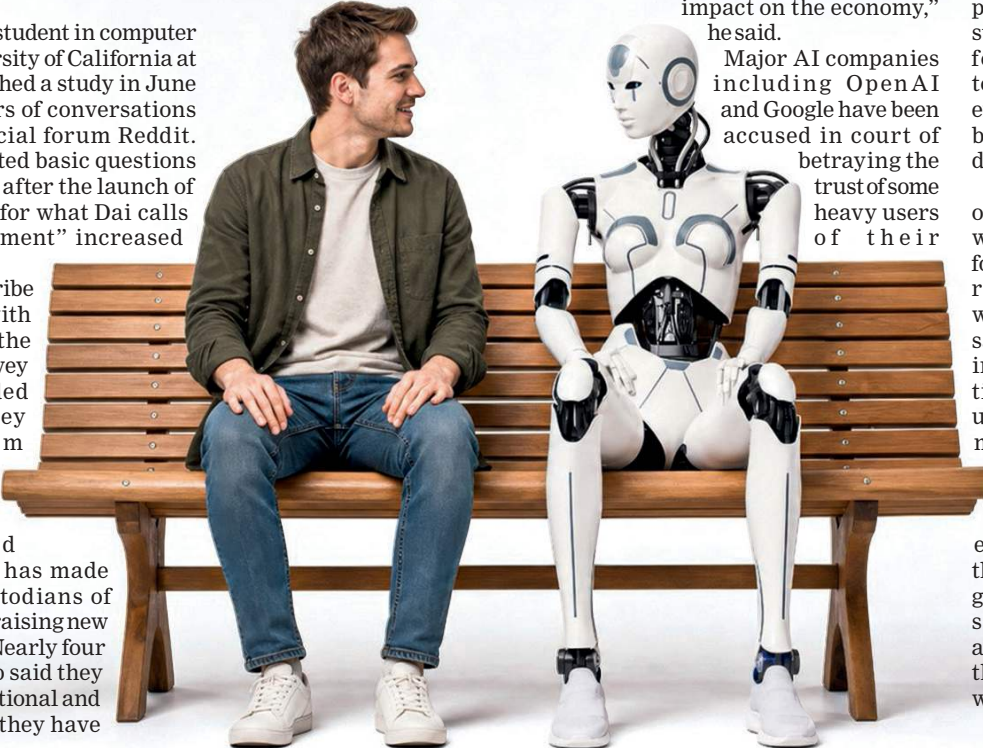
Major AI companies including OpenAI and Google have been accused in court of betraying the trust of some heavy users of their

chatbots. Families of people who developed delusional ideas or harmed themselves or others after long AI chats allege in ongoing lawsuits that the companies designed their products to be compelling or addictive without proper regard for safety. A recent study by the non-profit Translucence found that AI models from top providers are less likely to encourage discussions of suicide but still sometimes reinforce delusional behaviour.

In the Elon University survey, over one-third of respondents who said they regularly used AI for personal and emotional chats reported that chatbots agreed with them too much. 15 per cent said the bots make them feel less in touch with reality. At the same time, nearly 60 per cent of those users said chatbots were very or moderately helpful at helping them make personal decisions.

Dai said that in her study, she saw many people engage emotionally with chatbots in ways that were positive. They included getting AI help to process upsetting social interactions or getting advice on connecting with a parent they have a difficult relationship with, she said.

— The Washington Post



“A liberal is a man too broadminded to take his own side in a quarrel.” – ROBERT FROST

Trump’s ballroom faces a hermetic adversary

Liam Madden is an old Irish man who has made a career out of filing impossible legal challenges

Terrence McCoy

Donald Trump loves his ballrooms. The one at the White House is still being constructed, but the US president has already started planning another — on the other side of the Atlantic, in the Irish village of Doonbeg. In Doonbeg, where the Trump International Golf Links and Hotel stands on a windswept beach, the president had promised “the nicest ballroom in Ireland”. It would measure 12,000 square feet and seat up to 320 guests. For perspective, the population of Doonbeg is 300. The only objection has come from one Liam Madden, a hermetic figure notorious for blocking thousands of development projects across Ireland. “Please,” Madden urged the appellate board, “refuse this nonsense.”

Hermetic lifestyle

Madden is a tall man with white hair who lives in a historic stone house. He has no cellphone, no website, no social media. The only way to reach him is through a malfunctioning landline, or an email address that identifies him, in Latin, as the Irish Vitruvius. But everybody knows Liam Madden. When confronted by bothersome projects, the Irish turn to



So, in January, while flipping through the papers, when he saw a “golden opportunity” — what the Trump family proclaimed the “nicest ballroom in Ireland”, Madden knew what he must do. “If there is a god in heaven,” he declared, “I will win the appeal.”

Golfing history

Designed by golf legend Greg Norman, the Doonbeg Golf Club opened in 2002, at a time when the local population was just 206. But it was bleeding money. In 2014, it was put up for sale, and worry spread through Doonbeg. “It was like, ‘300 jobs gone,’” said Caroline O’Brien, a resident. A saviour arrived: An American buyer named Donald Trump. In May 2014, before he was ever president, he declared his plans for his new property: “One of the main reasons I’m here is the ballroom. A truly great ballroom. People from all over the world will be using this ballroom.” In the other corner is Madden: Over the years, he has opposed an elevator in a cathedral, a fast-food development, a car auction site, another of Trump’s proposals, and Conor McGregor’s bid to build a boutique hotel, challenging the UFC star to a “bare-knuckle fight”. As Irish federal senator Joe Flaherty said, “Nobody in their right mind would want to be Liam Madden — the criticism, the open contempt — but he relishes it.” And relish it he does. The national appellate board is expected to rule on his objections by the year end. “Joe Biden beat Donald Trump once,” he said. “I [would’ve] beaten him twice.”

— The Washington Post

this quarrelsome, punctilious man for his ability to torpedo plans. Many call him a “serial objector”, someone who makes a living by appealing planning commission decisions. Madden, however, bristles at that classification, instead referring to himself as a “god”, a “hero” and a “celebrity”. “I’m modest as well,” Madden, 76, added. “That’s one of my failings.”

secret sauce



Noodle empire billionaire eyes US expansion

Takaya Awata went from being a college dropout to a billionaire selling bowls of chewy udon noodles across Japan. Now, he’s betting that the humble dish can find a global following — much like burgers or pizza. Awata is the founder of Toridoll, which has become one of the world’s largest fast-food chains, primarily by growing its flagship Marugame Udon brand, which is now entering the US market. The challenge with going global, however, is to find a way to win over consumers who are unfamiliar with this staple of Japanese cuisine. Unlike the better-known ramen style of noodles which are thinner and yellowish, udon are thicker, chewier and whiter, and typically served in a simple broth. Challenges in store Moreover, the US is a tricky market which other brands have found it difficult to crack. Casual chic rice-burger chain MOS Burger tried and failed, as did ramen noodle chain Dosanko. Japanese bowl



café Yoshinoya, which first came to the US in 1975, radically downsized in the early ’80s before rebuilding. “The US is a challenging market,” said Kazunori Tsuda, an analyst at Daiwa Securities. “Sales can be three or four times those in Japan, but labour costs and rents are also higher.” Awata said Marugame’s selling points are a sense of theatre surrounding its hand-tossed noodles — like the iron griddle showmanship of its chefs — and the general trendiness of Japanese food culture in the US. “We expanded our business while making a lot of mistakes along the way,” he said. “It’s like baseball: If you can hit 30 per cent, you’re doing well.”

— Bloomberg

\$1 million

The amount of money that Carlos Ghosn, former Nissan CEO, is alleged to have paid French politician Rachida Dati. Ghosn and Dati are both on trial over the payment. Dati received the money from Renault-Nissan, the entity that was set up to coordinate an alliance between the two auto manufacturers. It was more than a decade ago, at a time when she was a member of the European Parliament and also a lawyer. The case focuses on what services Dati received the money for: Whether she provided any genuine advisory work or was simply monetising her political influence. Ghosn and Dati, who both deny wrongdoing, risk a 10-year jail term. The EU’s assembly tightened its rules around the time of the payments. Although EU lawmakers weren’t prohibited from earning consultancy fees for outside work, the new rules explicitly barred them from accepting payments in exchange for influencing parliamentary decisions.



PICS: REUTERS, BLOOMBERG

prize point

Five things to know about the Nobel Prize

Since 1901, the Nobel Prizes have been awarded for work leading to great advances for humanity. This year’s awards started with the Medicine Nobel — which went to Karl Deisseroth of the US, and Peter Hegemann and Georg Nagel of Germany — and will conclude with the Economics Prize on October 12. Here are a few facts about the prestigious honour:

In detention Totally five laureates have been prevented from attending the Peace Prize ceremony in Oslo. In 1936, German journalist Carl von Ossietzky was detained by the Nazis. Myanmar’s Aung San Suu Kyi was under house arrest when she won the prize in 1991. In 2010, Chinese dissident Liu Xiaobo was in prison. In 2022, Belarus’s jailed human rights campaigner Ales Bialiatski was represented by his wife Natalia Pinchuk. And in 2023, Iranian activist Narges Mohammadi was in prison.



Young and old In 2014, 17-year-old Pakistani human rights activist Malala Yousafzai became the youngest Nobel winner. And in 2018, Arthur Ashkin was awarded the Physics Prize at the age of 96, making him the oldest Nobel winner. However, Ashkin got to retain the honour for only a year. In 2019, another American, John Goodenough, became the oldest winner for his work on lithium-ion batteries used in smartphones and EV cars. Goodenough was 97.

Posthumous awards Since 1974, the Nobel Foundation has



gave him the award. **Women laureates** Only 68 of the 633 Nobel prizes have been given to women, representing about 10 per cent, though the share has been steadily increasing since the early 2020s. The science fields have the lowest representation of women laureates. The various committees that award the prizes have repeatedly refused to introduce quotas, instead encouraging nominations of women scientists. Marie Curie was the first woman laureate in 1903, and she is, to this day, the only woman to have received two Nobel prizes, first for physics in 1903 and then in 1911 in chemistry.



Nobel, the poet Alfred Nobel, the inventor of dynamite, also loved poetry and was an admirer of Percy Bysshe Shelley and Lord Byron. He wrote poetry himself his entire life, sometimes in his native Swedish but mostly in English. However, in 1862, at the age of 29 and questioning his literary talent, he sent a letter in French to a young woman that said: “Physics is my field, not writing.”

stipulated that the prize may not be given posthumously. Before the change, two people had won a posthumous Nobel: In 1931, the Swedish poet Erik Axel Karlfeldt, won the Literature Nobel. And in 1961, Dag Hammarskjöld, the secretary-general of the United Nations, who died in a plane crash, won the Peace Prize. However, in 2011, the committee selected Ralph Steinman of Canada for the Medicine Nobel, unaware that he had passed away just three days before the announcement. The foundation nevertheless



Zuckerberg, wife buy \$35-mn Gothic castle

Billionaire Mark Zuckerberg and his wife Priscilla Chan have bought a 200-year-old Gothic castle in Waterford, Ireland, about 150 kilometres outside Dublin. The Meta CEO, who’s worth \$196 billion, purchased the three-storey Strancally Castle worth \$35 million, though the price he paid isn’t known. “Mark and his family are excited to continue caring for this historic home and look forward to spending time in Ireland, where Meta maintains its international headquarters,”



a spokesman said. Built in 1827 for an English politician, the property has been extensively renovated over the years by its previous owners. Meta employs about 1,500 people in Ireland, with Dublin home to its international headquarters. Its Irish operations include a virtual and augmented reality business in Cork and a data centre outside Dublin. However, the Zuckerbergs will continue to live in the US and use the castle only when visiting Ireland.

— AFP

THROWBACK TUESDAY

A flashback into the lives of celebrities

Taylor Swift The pop star shared a childhood memory with younger brother Austin (left)



Jakub Mensik The Czech tennis star’s thoughts are with his pet dog, Dona, who passed away recently. Several of his peers sent him condolence messages



Celine Dion The Canadian singer recalled a moment from 2012, when she returned to the recording studio in Las Vegas after a maternity break



Brooke Shields The actress shared snaps from a photoshoot she had done in the late ’70s for a sportswear brand



Jamie Oliver The celebrity chef recalled his time filming his TV show in the waters around Italy. “If travelling through Italy taught me one thing, it’s that food is the soul of Italian culture,” he wrote